Better Angels Of Our Nature

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/24282997.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

Categories:
F/F, F/M

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018), He-Man and the Masters of the Universe

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Angella/Micah (She-Ra), Entrapta/Hordak (She-Ra), He-Man | Adam/Teela, Queen Marlena/King Randor (She-Ra)

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Angst with a Happy Ending, Queen Angella Rescue, No beta we die like cats, Temporary Character Death, References to He-Man and the Masters of the Universe

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Part 2 of Turn Right Timelines

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by Firebird_X

Summary

There aren't enough post-series Catra-rescues-Angella fics. QED. =^_^=

Also, WARNING SEASON 5 SPOILERS. AND MASTERS OF THE UNIVERSE: REVELATIONS SPOILERS.

No Queen Left Behind

Chapter Summary

> When Catra learns what happened to Angella, she'll stop at nothing to make her terrible mistake right.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra wandered the camp in a daze, watching in amazement as the rebels packed up to return to Brightmoon. The overwhelming cheer, enough to drive her mad not long ago, put a reluctant smile on her face. *They're crazy,* she thought, her own presence the irrefutable proof of her position. She and Adora had split up for the first time since the end, She-Ra helping with the heaviest furnishings while Catra sorted through Entrapta's most delicate gear. *Trusting me not to break stuff. They're all crazy!* In defiance of her objections, Catra placed Entrapta's equipment in storage with precision and care.

"Glimmer, I don't think this is a good idea," King Micah said. Catra blinked and looked up.

"Don't be silly, Dad!" Glimmer insisted, entering Entrapta's tent and guiding her father in after by one hand. "Catra, this is my father, King Micah." Micah's eyes widened at the sight of her. Catra gulped and straightened, ears darting up. "Dad, this is Catra. She rescued me right out from under Horde Prime's..." she giggled. "Well, hole where a nose should be."

"Stars," Micah breathed. "Those eyes...do you remember anything from before the Horde, Catra?"

Catra gulped. "No sir. Your, um, Majesty."

Glimmer snickered behind one hand. "Are you seriously the Horde scum who almost won the war, like, five times?"

Seriously? Catra wonders, crushing old rage with strength to rival She-Ra's. She needed that strength. "Didn't think you'd miss her, Sparkles."

Glimmer's eyes widen, so much like her father's, and her brain starts working again. "Don't! I don't. I just...you know, don't mind you being smart and funny and cute. That's all!"

The tension vanished, replaced by an almost enjoyable annoyance. "I. Am. Not. Cute!" Catra snapped, bristling.

Glimmer snickered. Again. "You should've seen yourself putting away Entrapta's stuff. It was," she put a fist on her chest and smirked, "ahem – *Adora*–ble."

Catra's ears went flat. "I hate you."

"Magicat," Micah blurted. Both women looked at him, eyes widening. "You're a magicat." Catra's jaw dropped. "You didn't know, did you? Shadow Weaver..."

I am not. Gonna cry. Catra swallowed, blinking back tears. "No. I...thank you, King Micah. She told me I could never learn magic."

Micah scowled a fraction. "I'm sure she wanted you to believe that, but I'd wager my best grimoire that she only implied it." Catra glanced away, trying to remember when Shadow Weaver had told her straight out. *"No talent for sorcery"..."too foolish and lazy"..."you wouldn't last a week in Mystacor"...* He sighed, straightened, and forced a smile. "I can recommend you to Mystacor when you return, if you like."

"Really? Thank you!" Catra gasped. Then she smiled without mirth. "Heh, one of the few places I haven't messed up. Besides, I always wanted to prove her wrong."

Micah nodded. "I'll speak to Casta after you leave. Glimmer, I'll let you talk to your – friend." He slipped his hand from Glimmer's hand and disappeared before the princess – *no, queen,* Catra remembered – could catch him.

"Wait. Dad!" Glimmer's sigh was as explosive as ever. "I'm sorry about that," she continued. "I really hoped he'd be okay with you. And, wow, magicat, huh?" Her smirk returned, though at a less absurd angle. "Melog picked the right partner."

Catra nodded, mind wandering. "Hey, Sparkles, does he not like me for my general evil and horribleness, or did I do something specific?"

For a moment, Glimmer shook. Glimmer *was* shook. Before Catra could do anything about it though, the queen turned a sad look on her. "You...you don't know, do you?"

Catra's blood froze. *Not princess. Queen.* "No. No, I can't have." She quivered, ears pivoting back and lashing tail gone bushy. "No one died at the Battle of Brightmoon. I was careful." Glimmer gasped at that. "She wasn't anywhere near our fights after that." The look Glimmer gave her then – it wasn't fury, or hatred, or judgment, it was sorrow. "Even you couldn't forgive me for – for – no..."

The world blurred through tears Catra couldn't even slow. "When you opened the portal," Glimmer explained, and Catra felt stabbed, "the sword powered it. Someone had to pull it out, but they had to stay behind. Adora was going to, but...Mom..."

Catra ran, cursing herself a coward with every step. "Catra!" Glimmer cried.

"You made your choice. Now live with it!" Adora's condemnation hunted Catra, inescapable. Etheria became a blur of green, She-Ra's triumph all around them. Somehow, that made it hurt more. The words echoed in her skull until she thought it would explode. *I killed her,* Catra finally realized, collapsing into a sobbing heap. *Glimmer's mom. I...I...* She threw back her head and screamed, wishing she'd died a thousand fights ago.

Melog appeared at her side, nuzzling her cheek. "They should have killed me," Catra whispered.

”Catra!” Adora cried, Swift Wind soaring overhead. Catra looked up to discover night had fallen, then glanced at Melog. *I could disappear,* she thought, curling around her companion. *Just...go away, and they could forget about me*– “Catra, come back! Just talk to me! *Please!”* Catra’s enhanced hearing picked up a single sob. “Please...”

With a sigh very near another sob, Catra stood, Melog glowing beside her. She-Ra leaped from Swift Wind, landing by Catra’s side, changing back and holding her tight. “Catra. Please. Stay,” Adora begged.

Catra might have been able to handle any other words. Those shattered her, and she wept into Adora’s shoulder. “How can they forgive me?” Catra asked between sobs. “How can you?”

“That’s who they are,” Adora explained. “Me...I love you.”

After a minute, they sat in the grass, still holding onto one another. Catra found the courage to look Adora in the eye. “Adora. Please. Tell me what happened.”

Adora swallowed. “Are...are you sure? You don’t have to...”

“Yes. I do,” Catra insisted, holding Adora’s hand. “I have to live with it.” Adora flinched.

Then Adora told her.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Adora followed Catra into the camp, staring at her fiercely marching girlfriend in confusion. *What happened?* the blonde wondered. *When I started explaining, Catra looked like she was going to her execution, but now – the only time I’ve ever seen her this determined was in the Heart.*

Glimmer appeared beside them in an explosion of glitter. “Catra! Thank the Stars. Adora, is she okay?”

"No. I'm not," Catra admitted. Adora and Glimmer shared a look of alarm. "But that's okay. I don't deserve to be."

"Catra!" both princesses objected.

Bow ran up, panting. "What...the heck...is going...on?" he wheezed. "Your dad's doing some kind of crazy tracking spell with seven circles. Aunt Casta can't decide whether to stop him or take notes."

"Tell him I'm back," Catra said, running claws through her hair. "Where's Entrapta?"

"Entrapta? She's with Hordak, which is super-weird to say," Bow explained.

Catra nodded. "Good. That'll save me some time." She marched towards Hordak's tent, one of the few still standing. Melog followed.

Glimmer slapped her forehead. "Ugh. Adora, make her make sense!"

"Not a word, Adora," Catra snapped, quickening her pace.

Huh? Adora stared after Catra. "How am I supposed to know what to say when I don't have any idea what you're doing?"

"Good," Catra said, not slowing.

"It's okay," Bow said, almost jogging to catch up. "I think I know."

That froze Catra solid. "Bow," she whispered.

"I won't say anything," Bow agreed.

"Oh, come on!" Glimmer erupted, throwing her hands in the air.

"Glimmer." Adora shuddered at Catra's broken voice, a sound she'd hoped she would never hear again. "Please. Let me do this."

Glimmer crossed her arms and glared. “Catra–”

Catra turned and fell to her knees. Adora’s eyes went wide enough to hurt. Glimmer gasped. “Please, Glimmer.” Catra looked shattered, ears and jaw quivering, eyes wavering, arms limp.

Glimmer sighed. “Fine. I’ll tell Dad to call off the Spell of Doom or whatever.” She vanished again.

Catra leaped to her feet and resumed her march on Hordak’s tent. If she hadn’t known Catra so well, Adora might have thought her begging an act. “Now will you tell me what’s going on?” Adora blurted.

“We’re almost there,” Catra said, indicating the tent with a wave. “I...don’t want to have to do this twice.

Adora sighed and relented. The trio reached Hordak’s tent without further drama. Hordak sighed while Entrapta cackled. Adora almost smiled. Catra knocked on the frame. “Entrapta? Can I come in?” Catra asked.

“Of course!” Entrapta exulted. They entered to find Hordak standing with his arms out, as if for a suit fitting, while Entrapta rebuilt his exoskeleton around him. “Shape-changing circuits need some work, but everything else seems to be operating efficiently. Your physiology appears restored, as well.” She rubbed her chin with one hair tendril. “I wonder if your exile was based on something other than scientific data.” Adora couldn’t say whether the scene was more sweet or creepy. *About even,* she decided.

“Politics, probably,” Catra offered. Hordak raised an eyebrow. “I’d bet you were too...‘person-y’ for him.” Bow snickered. Adora elbowed him. Hordak, for his part, merely nodded. “Hey, Entrapta, I...really need your help with something.”

“If it’s science, I’m in!” Entrapta gushed.

Hordak groaned. “Can we learn Catra’s intent first, Entrapta? Do not rush to trust her,” he objected.

Catra glared at him. "You are literally the one person on Etheria who doesn't get to say that," she snapped. Adora gulped. Entrapta's smile vanished, and she made a nervous sound. Hordak snorted and looked away. Catra sighed. "First part's fair, though. I want to rescue Queen Angella."

Adora's jaw dropped. "What?!" she blurted.

Bow grinned. "Called it!"

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Three days later, Bow wasn't grinning. Entrapta and Hordak were both asleep, snuggled in the curls of her hair in a way that would have been terrifying – well, three days ago. Bow yawned. Adora snored in the corner of the tent. Most of the others had returned to Brightmoon, though they got regular visits.

Catra was working on her fifth magic circle of the evening, pretending she had slept the night before. Melog mewed at her side, earning an ear-scritch, but she kept working. "Is there any point in telling you to get some rest?" Bow asked.

"No," Catra replied with all the emotion of a Horde clone. She turned to Shadow Weaver's spell book, flipped a few pages, and began a sixth magic circle. The one she'd been working on hung in the air with two others, each glowing a different color (silver, lavender, and red). She frowned. "This has to be it. 'The gap between dimensions.' Still not sure how that works. Why can't I find anything?" She shook her head, beads of sweat and tears darting from her fur. "It's fine. Like Entrapta said, there's no Mara safeguards and no Despondos sinkhole. I can do this."

Bow groaned and shook his head. "Catra, you became a sorceress in, like, two days. Castaspella is freaking out, and Shadow Weaver didn't freak her out." Catra froze. *Aargh!* Bow shook his head. "Not like that! I mean, you're picking up magic faster than King Micah, and he was the best student Mystacor ever had."

"He was a kid," Catra retorted, "I'm after one specific thing, and I have Melog." She scratched Melog's head, and the enormous cat purred. "She says thanks for the treats, by the way."

"Aw. You're welcome, Melog." Bow crouched and gave Melog a head rub. The alien cat pushed into Bow's hand, but returned her attention to Catra after a few moments. "Look, Catra, my point is, you're doing amazing. Really, we should have thought of this weeks ago."

Catra huffed and ran claws through her growing mane. "You were a little busy, dealing with a psycho magicat, then, y'know, saving the universe. Plus, it wasn't safe before." She turned her attention back to the book, blinking. Catra rubbed her eyes. "We couldn't really do anything until now." She yawned, Melog following suit.

Bow sighed again. "Catra, either Queen Angella is still alive, and you resting won't hurt anything, or...or she's not, and it still won't hurt anything."

Catra whirled on him. Bow gasped at the bags under her eyes, the droop of her ears, the matting of her fur. "You don't know that!" she wailed, trembling. All three sleepers stirred. Catra clamped her hands over her mouth for a moment, then exhaled in relief when they remained asleep. "Maybe she dehydrates slowly, or her air supply could be running out, or the dimension gap drains magic, or – or something." She grabbed Bow's arms, all pretense of control vanishing as she wobbled in front of him. "I have to *save* her, Bow!"

Bow hugged her. Catra held onto him, shaking and sniffling back tears. *She's not even complaining. This is bad.* He pulled back and looked her in the eyes. "Catra, listen to me. If Angella is still alive, we'll rescue her. But you need to rest. Please." He turned her to look at Adora, who whimpered in her sleep and reached for something that wasn't there. For someone. "If you won't do it for me, do it for Adora."

"Cheater," Catra muttered. Bow gently nudged the magicat towards Adora, and when she stumbled, unable to resist, Catra relented and let Bow guide her to the mat. When the still-sleeping Adora threw an arm around Catra and welded them together, both stopped shaking. Catra smirked in spite of herself. "Means you're...doing it right."

Bow watched with a smile as Catra's eyes fell closed. He thought about her fierce desperation as she mewed with gentle peace in Adora's arms. *I can't believe this is the same woman who fought so hard to beat us.* His smile grew as he headed towards his cot. *I guess that's because...she isn't really, any more.*

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Eight days after the Battle of Etheria, Hordak watched as Entrapta pieced the final sections of the mini-portal together, Catra using her newfound telekinesis both to assist with construction and empower the device. *I should hate Catra, as she should me,* Hordak mused. *Perhaps Entrapta is correct. There may be a place for me here after all – particularly if this project is successful.* Still, a question nagged at him. "Why have we not enlisted King Micah or Queen Glimmer in this endeavor? They are both powerful sorcerers, and have a vested interest in our success."

Catra pointed at the modified portal device with a glowing hand. "I don't want to give them hope then take it away, Right Hordak," she explained. Entrapta giggled at the 'nickname,' so Hordak tolerated it. "I've done enough to them."

"Besides, Castaspella's checking our sorcery work, and she's the queen of Mystacor," Bow added, the boy's odd enthusiasm eliciting faint smiles from the others.

"Seriously, you just thought of that question now?" Adora asked, grinning at him. "Even I asked about it, like, a week ago."

Catra mumbled something about Adora "quipping at" Hordak before she did, then returned her focus to the portal device. *Hm.*

No matter how I – care for – Entrapta, it would likely be wise to find an expert in Etherian culture. His eyes pivoted to Bow. *Later.* He turned his attention back to his readings. "Resonance match at 87%. I recommend a minimum safe match of 98%."

"How close do we need to be to open the gateway?" Catra asked. Adora's hands both formed fists.

"93%, but I agree with Hordak," Entrapta insisted. "It's too unstable to risk a jump in that range."

"How about a scanner?" Catra continued, tail lashing. "Bow could fire one in on an arrow."

"Huh. That might work," Bow agreed, "and there's no danger to anyone."

"Then let's do it." Gritting her teeth, Catra carved another magic circle in the air, Melog glowing as she did. The dimensional resonance jumped to 94% in three seconds. *Hm. Impressive.* The magicat shuddered and staggered in place.

"Catra!" Adora objected, rushing to hold her. "You've got to be more careful!"

Catra, oddly, snickered. "Look who's talking." Adora scowled.

Glimmer and Micah appeared in a burst of absurd sparkles. "Wait!" Glimmer blurted.

"Aah!" Catra, Bow, and Entrapta gasped as one. Bow rushed to lean on the portal device at an odd angle, while Entrapta tried to cover it with her hair. Hordak and Adora facepalmed in nearly-perfect synch. "Gli-Sparkles!" Catra babbled. "Just helping Entrapta with one of her experiments." Her laugh was weak.

Micah half-smiled. "Catra, we've known what you're planning for two days. Casta's the best teacher Mystacor's ever had, but she can't keep a secret to save her life."

“And Dad’s great with magic theory,” Glimmer added. “This is sweet, really, but we’ll be okay.”

Bow lowered his head. “It...wasn’t just her idea, Glimmer. I was worried too.”

“We’re losing resonance,” Hordak pointed out. “If we’re going to send a probe, we must do it now.”

“Activating portal!” Entrapta cheered, throwing the switch. The yawning void opened, naught save floating stone visible beyond.

Bow prepared an arrow while Catra shuffled to Glimmer’s side, appearing uncertain. “Glimmer? You...never answered, about...why don’t you hate me?”

Glimmer sighed, shrinking a centimeter. “I did for a while. It turned me into the jerk who blew off her friends and almost destroyed the world.” Her smile at Catra was...shy? “Then, y’know, you sacrificed yourself to rescue me. And got us home, helped us free Erelandia, and saved Adora. You’re a good friend when you give yourself a chance.” Her smile broadened. “Horde scum.”

Catra chuckled sadly as Bow fired. “Y’know, I have a nickname.”

“Huh? Oh, right, ‘Wildcat!’ It is kinda perfect for you,” Glimmer noted.

Catra swallowed. “You’re...not such a bad friend yourself, you know.”

“We have data!” Entrapta cheered. They all rushed to the wondrous scientist’s side. Hordak and Adora nearly bumped into each other, and the former conqueror realized she’d been listening to Catra as well. She blushed and looked away. “Hordak, is that a magic reading?”

Cursing himself for permitting social interaction to distract him, Hordak returned to his screen. “Yes, Entrapta. More than that – it

is optical energy."

"Light?" Micah breathed, wide eyes tinged with tears.

Catra and Glimmer hugged. "She's alive!" they cheered as one.

"Yes, but I am detecting an increase in void fluctuation," Hordak reported. *A reaction to reality's presence,* he realized. "The subject is weakening."

"What?" Adora gasped, rushing to the portal.

"Contact appears to have caused pattern degradation," Hordak explained.

"Will closing the portal help?" Catra asked, already climbing into her spacesuit. Entrapta clasped hands of flesh and hair.

Hordak glowered at the screen. "Unknown."

"Then we're out of time," Catra said. "Micah, Glimmer, keep that gate open, whatever it takes. Adora, anchor me."

"No! No, you're not going without me!" Adora cried.

"Weren't you paying attention? The gap is *eating magic* now! It's like anti-She-Ra in there! Everyone else here is magic, it has to be me!" Catra retorted. Melog whined

"And me," Bow added, already halfway into his suit. "I'll go too." Catra bristled. "You're already a sorceress, Catra. You should have backup." She sighed, putting on her helmet in lieu of argument.

Hordak looked at Entrapta. "Sorry," she said. "The First Ones tech in your exoskeleton is powered by magic. You shouldn't go either."

Adora trembled. "Promise me you'll be careful," she pleaded, taking Catra's hand.

Catra's face moved through multiple expressions before settling on something Hordak could only describe as "gentle." She cupped

Adora's cheek in one hand. "I promise." She turned to Bow. "Let's do this."

Bow nodded as Entrapta typed with her hands and attached cables to their belts with her hair. Adora transformed into She-Ra and grabbed both cables. Then the pair leaped into the void.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Catra shivered in the empty world, leaping from stone to stone with Bow at her side. Melog pulled most of her newfound magic out from her, but even with her meager new ability, she felt the place pulling life from her bones. "Hey, Catra, you okay?" Bow asked, putting a hand on her shoulder when she paused on a table-sized rock.

She grinned at him. "Yeah. Doing great. Just don't call me cute."

Bow frowned. "Catra, you were panting. The only person I've ever known with more stamina than you is Adora." Her tail puffed out for a moment. Bow flinched. "Sorry, but you get my point, right? This place is hurting you."

"It's hurting Glimmer's mom worse. I hated Shadow Weaver – I had the *right* to hate Shadow Weaver – and losing her still tore me apart," Catra explained. "We are *not* losing Angella now, not when we're so close!" Gritting her teeth, she leaped to a large platform above them. She froze and stared.

One of the few stories from Catra's childhood that didn't involve Adora revolved around Catra and Rogelio finding a butterfly in a spider web. Catra bragged to Ro that she'd watch the spider eat the butterfly, but as soon as he turned his back, horrified, she'd tried to free it.

Catra had been seven. She'd accidentally killed not only the butterfly, but the spider as well.

The moment she reached the platform, Catra saw Angella in a great storm ring, splayed out like the butterfly, caught in gray

tendrils. The queen looked up, eyes shaking in terror. The tendrils – *Be honest, Catra, it's webbing,* she told herself – sealed Angella's mouth shut, leaving her to shake her head and beg through whimpers. "I'm with the Alliance now!" Catra cried, pointing to Bow. "We're here to bring you home!" She leaped again, just one stone away from the queen.

The corrupted half of Catra's head peered out from the cloud funnel, one hand clawing towards the real thing. "hEeEy, cAaAtRa," the thing said. Catra's fur stood on end, suit or no suit, when two voices echoed in the distortion.

Bow turned to fire, but hesitated at the sight of Catra's former self. "Catra? Was that other voice what I think it was?" he gasped, arrow wavering.

Then the rest of the torso emerged, and Catra recoiled. A Horde Prime made of toxic green fire was *wearing* the shell of her corruption, with two left arms grasping the edge of Angella's prison. "CaSt oUT tHe shAdOWs," it mocked. "AlL beiNGs must SUFFer tO beCOMe PURE." The rest of it rounded the stormcloud...with eight legs. Its lower half was that of an enormous spider.

Catra never blamed herself for screaming. The sight of Angella weeping and using one finger to point toward their gateway stiffened Catra's spine. "Catra!" Bow called, firing a goop arrow at Spider-Prime. The glue burned away instantly. "What do we do?"

"You free Angella!" Catra ordered, crouching and punching her claws through her suit.

"What are you going to do?" Bow asked, staring.

"The one thing I'm good at," Catra explained. Then she leaped at Spider-Prime, screaming and raking her old self – along with as much webbing as she could get her claws through.

"LITtLE SiSTEr," Spider-Prime called, its voice becoming more like his, "WHy dO YoU STRUGgLE? YOU CANnOT WiN WIThOUT ShE-

RA."

"Will you shut *up?!"* Catra howled, slashing wildly at the monster. A blow from one of its legs sent her sprawling into the web, where Bow was using a – buzzsaw arrow? – to cut Angella loose. "Bow! Rescue faster!" Spider-Prime skittered towards her, its legs leaving burn marks in its wake.

"I'm trying!" Bow objected.

"Catra! Resonance at 93.7% and dropping!" Entrapta warned. *Great. As if this fight wasn't enough of a mess.* Catra pulled herself up on the webbing, getting a fraction more stuck. Angella shook her head again, crying. *She's thin. Pale. We have to finish this fast.* Spider-Prime laughed and jabbed at her with one burning leg.

Catra smirked. *Finally.* She thrust out a perfect claw-hand strike into the hip joint, severing the leg. Spider-Prime screamed and recoiled, the leg falling into the web and burning it away. "Melog, less magic! Bow, grab the queen!"

She forced herself not to choke up when both partners obeyed without question. "Okay, now what?" Bow asked.

Catra braced herself, then stabbed her claws into the leg again. *Had worse,* she insisted, pushing aside Shadow Weaver memories and the burning pain, then sliced Angella the rest of the way free.

Angella immediately ripped off the webbing on her mouth, wincing for a moment. "Leave me and go! That's an order!"

Catra smirked at her. "Uh, you do know who I am, right?" she asked. "Bow, move!"

Bow fired a grapple arrow several rocks away and headed down towards the portal, one arm around Angella's waist. "Catriska!" Angella cried.

Catra froze. *"Who was she, mama?" Catriska asked, squirming in her mother's arms as she looked up at the statue. The heroine had eyes like hers...*

"Resonance at 93.5%," Hordak reported.

Catra shook her head, driving off the alien memory. "I'm Catra! I'm the worst enemy the Alliance ever had! Now GO!" She turned to face Spider-Prime. It wasn't smiling any longer, the dark-Catra parts burning away in Prime's monstrous light.

"You're Catriska of Halfmoon, the daughter of my husband's dearest friend!" Angella insisted. Catra barely dodged another leg stabbing at her, grateful beyond measure that the way back was down. "And if I weren't a coward, you wouldn't have belonged to Shadow Weaver!"

For a moment, Angella's confession tore up half-healed wounds, the old Catra threatening to leak out. *No,* Catra told herself. "Coward? When every other princess ran away, you *were* the Rebellion, *alone,* for twelve years!" She leaped back again. "Adora! Get Bow and the queen *out* of here!"

Catra's retort stunned Angella so completely that Adora was able to pull them free before the queen could object again. The magicat indulged in a genuine smile. *We did it. Maybe now I can face them–* Spider-Prime slashed at her with two more legs, then lashed out with gray webbing. *–but I kinda have to survive first!* "Adora! Three meters – PULL!"

Her obsessive, determined love pulled Catra back within a centimeter of exact, yanking her away in time. Spider-Prime roared. "LITTLE SiSTER," it snapped, her voice almost gone from the monster. "YOU WiLL NEVER BE FREE oF YOUR SiNS."

"Catra, we're at 93.2% – you've gotta get out!" Entrapta pleaded.

Catra remembered breaking. She could still feel the instant, in the Crimson Waste, when Adora told her about Shadow Weaver, and she thought she'd learned how stupid kindness was. *I was*

wasting it on the wrong person, she realized. No one moment could heal a lifetime of abuse and cruelty, but this – it felt like the exact opposite of that moment, like something precious had snapped back into place, something good, something *Catra,* a part of her that was right even without Adora. "Four meters!" Catra shouted, and Adora pulled again. Once more, she evaded Spider-Prime by a whisker. "You're right," she admitted.

Spider-Prime froze, staring with too many eyes. "I'll always have sent Angella here, always left Adora in that pit, always conquered Salineas. But I'll always have done this, too." She hopped back, falling under a swing from its burning, stolen claws. Catra smirked. "I'll always have rescued Glimmer from you. I'll always have made friends with Melog." Spider-Prime roared again.

Her smirk melted into a gentle smile. "And I'll always have told Adora that I love her. That's what beat you, you know. Not a weapon, not an army, and definitely not sorcery. Love." She reached into a pouch and held out her hand. Spider-Prime stared at the stick-figure drawing of Scorpia, Entrapta, and Catra holding hands. "You can change too, you know. Just go into this. We can find you a body if you stop trying to conquer the universe. No matter how deep this hole might be," she said, waving at the nothing around them, "there's always a way out. All you have to do is take the right hand."

Catra's smile died as Prime laughed, the last of her old self burning away. "'THOUGH ALL IS REDUCED TO RUBBLE, PRIME SHALL RISE AGAIN.' TELL SHE-RA THAT."

Catra shook her head "Sorry. I don't offer as many chances as Adora. NOW!"

Prime screamed as She-Ra pulled Catra from the void just as the gateway began to close. Catra's smirk returned. "You miscalculated," she said, watching Prime scramble impotently in the emptiness as the opening vanished.

The desperate hugs that consumed the magicat were so wonderful, even Catra couldn't complain.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

"That. Was. Awesome!" Adora gushed, leading the train of rebel heroes marching along the Whispering Woods' one trail.

The other princesses laughed as Catra facepalmed. "Put me back in," she groaned.

"No," Brightmoon's royal family insisted as one. Adora's heart felt like it would explode with joy at the growing laughter.

"'You were the Rebellion for twelve years'? I'm putting that over the gates to Brightmoon," Micah quipped.

Angella's laughter froze in her throat. "Absolutely not!" she quailed. Glimmer laughed.

Scorpia turned heart-eyes on Catra. "You kept it," she gushed.

"What? No! I just found it!" Catra objected. She looked away, tail lashing behind her. "Then...I kept it." More laughter. Catra was as red as her old uniform.

"I can't believe he fell for the 'clumsy Catra' bit," Adora laughed, mimicking her claw-stab. "I mean, I never fell for that one."

Catra looked down, hands twisting. Melog purred. "Y-you know you're not really an idiot, right?" she muttered. Adora's eyes bulged. *Did – did that just happen?* she wondered.

Too overwhelmed to stop herself, Adora swooped Catra around Netossa-style to dip her into a kiss. She grinned at the dazed look Catra gave her afterwards. "I love you, you know."

Catra blinked and started to nod – then froze again when they rounded the last corner and emerged before Brightmoon. She

looked up and stared. Glimmer teleported over and hugged them both. “Welcome home,” Glimmer said.

Catra blinked back tears and smiled again. “Yeah. Home.”

Chapter End Notes

Two fics in three days WHAT MADNESS IS THIS

...but I had to write this. I HAD TO.

Also, I use the same backstory for Catra and Shadow Weaver as in Turn Right. I even recycled a line from Princess of the Moon. This is also one of the timelines in that continuum, though it won't matter unless I get through Season 5 in that fic (so, probably not).

Forever Healing

Chapter Summary

Angella finds Catra before Micah's mural in eerie parallel to her first solitary meeting with Adora. It turns out that neither saving the universe nor fixing her worst mistake has healed all of Catra's wounds. Love will have to suffice in atonement's place.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Angella brushed a lock of hair out of Micah's face, watching him sleep. She reveled in his peaceful expression, having heard by then of his nightmares and whimpered "Angie"s during the invasion. After hours of just him and Glimmer, then a few hours more of just *Micah,* the newly-reinstated queen had insisted that he sleep

In all honesty, it hadn't taken long, she mused. He was still tired – years on Beast Island fighting to survive, then months fighting against (and then for) Horde Prime, had taken their toll. *He's just so – careworn.* Angella let in her hatred for Shadow Weaver and Hordak, then tried to let it go. It was more successful than she expected. *All the same, a small part of me will probably still hate them when Hordak's bones are dust.*

Her mind wandered, for the first time since her family had made time for itself, back to Adora and Catra. *Castriska,* whom Shadow Weaver had violated in more ways than Angella could have imagined in her nightmares. Catra, the most brilliant and determined foe the Rebellion had ever faced. Catra, who had literally saved the entire universe by climbing out of the pit of her grief and pain to admit her love at the end of all things. Catra, who had nearly died saving Angella herself.

(Catra, who pulled the lever where Shadow Weaver had held Glimmer's hand and abused both children. *Let go,* Angella commanded herself, but she still imagined pummelling Shadow Weaver flat.)

The queen wrote a quick note to Micah in case he woke to find her missing, and wandered the halls as she had on so many nights thinking him lost. *Hordak, not only defeated but an ally. Shadow Weaver, dead for good and all. The Stars, returned at last. You do have trouble with sudden change, Angella.* She paused when she realized where her feet were taking her. *Stars, I'm headed for his mural,* Angella realized, chuckling. Even away from him, she sought her husband's comfort. *I do believe it is time for me to return to my actual husband's–*

"What am I doing here?" Catra muttered just before she came into view.

In a few moments, Angella amended, well aware the coming conversation could take much longer. "That," she offered gently – which didn't stop Catra from leaping back and yelping – "is a rather broad question. Can you narrow it down, perhaps?"

"Y-Your Majesty!" Catra blurted, doing something Angella imagined was an attempt at a bow, yet also included a salute of some kind. It looked so familiar in its earnest clumsiness, the queen's heart ached.

Oh. Of course. It was a near-exact replica of Adora's attempt at etiquette when they had first run into each other before this very mural. "I did say that right, right? I mean – Bow coached me on titles, but not the...curtsying thing, since you're supposed to do that in a dress or something? I–" Catra babbled.

"Commander Catra. Stop. *Breathe,"* Angella commanded. Catra obeyed, her deep breath almost comical. Angella remembered threatening Adora during a similar encounter. *I will do better this time,* she promised herself. "What is troubling you?"

Catra's ears shot upright. "Me? I'm fine." The last word stuck in the magicat's throat for an instant. *Ah. A deflection too well worn to deceive her friends, but she hoped it might work with me.* "I'm just, y'know, not used to someplace this sparkly. I mean, I've never been to Brightmoon – i mean, inside," she trailed off, eyes darting down, head lowering. "sorry."

The last word, whispered as it was, echoed through the queen's heart. "First, let me say that I accept your apology for all its implied...misjudgments." Catra sighed, shaking her head. "That said. Micah determined, during the time you planned my rescue, that Shadow Weaver erased your memory of Halfmoon. Brightmoon law is clear that in any case where magic is used to tamper with the mind, any crimes committed by the victim are the responsibility of the sorceress."

Catra stared, jaw slack for a moment. "But, wait, Shadow Weaver always bragged that she didn't need mind control," she objected.

"And yet she attempted the same thing with Adora," Angella reminded her. "Catra, had you remembered a past of love and family, the Horde could not have turned you into the person you were for a time."

"I was five! At the most!" Catra blurted. "I still did those things, *chose* to do them, hurt Adora's friends, hurt *Adora,* I can't, I can't–" Catra's knees buckled. Angella was grateful for experience in catching an exhausted Glimmer, holding the girl before she could collapse. "I...I found a letter."

Angella helped Catra sit, leaning against the mural, then sat beside her. "I beg your pardon?"

Catra sighed. "A letter. From Adora. To me. I was looking for a snack." Her smile looked broken, like a reflection of the Horde Prime...thing that had worn Catra's folly. "When Adora found out Shadow Weaver liked cutting my rations as punishment, she turned into a stash fiend. She'd hide little slices of ration bar

everywhere. She liked reminding me that I'd give her half of mine when she was sick."

Angella kept her face carefully neutral. She imagined tearing Shadow Weaver's mask off and pummeling her with it. *Unhealthy, that's unhealthy,* she told herself. "What did the letter say, Catra?"

"That she knew we were enemies now – then. That...we'd always be enemies. How much she missed the parts of me that weren't horrible. That she...wouldn't change anything she'd done, even if she could." Catra hugged herself. "That's the part that hurts the most. It just dragged out all the...messed-up, stupid, angry, *everything,* inside me."

"Have you talked to her about it?" Angella asked, rubbing circles in Catra's back.

"She's asleep," Catra muttered. "Adora's exhausted, it's been nine days since the end and she still works herself half to death if I'm not paying attention."

Angella offered the kindest smile she could muster. "And you have not?"

Catra huffed and looked away. "That was *different,"* she insisted. "We had no idea how much time you had left. Besides, I was right, wasn't I?" Angella raised an eyebrow. "You were helpless and alone with Horde Prime, for crying out loud."

Angella briefly considered correcting Catra's model of her experience in the gap-realm. *Later,* she decided. "Time flowed differently there. To me, Horde Prime only had me bound for a few moments before your arrival," she settled on instead. Catra relaxed a fraction. "Very well, you want to wait until Adora has rested. Fair enough." Catra looked at her in surprise. *Has this child received so little respect for her own agency?* Angella wondered. "Are you willing to talk to me about it?"

"You?" Catra blurted. "But you're the queen! And...important!" She slapped her forehead. "Ugh, the stupid's contagious. Look, I get

that you're grateful for the rescue, but it was my fault you were in there in the first place. I'm just– " She lifted her head slightly, eyes sliding towards Adora's door. "I'm such a coward," she mumbled, slumping back down.

Angella couldn't help smiling again. "'Coward?' Did you not sacrifice yourself to Horde Prime for my daughter? Or fight a First Ones monster, alone, to save Adora?" Catra's blush grew with each reminder. "Or bare your heart to her to save the universe? Or risk everything after finding happiness at last to rescue one obsolete queen? Twelve years has nothing on your courage, Catriska."

Catra blinked. "'Obsolete?' You know what, never mind. How long have you known who I am?" she asked.

"Since yesterday," Angella replied, smile vanishing, "though I should have sooner. By the Stars, Shadow Weaver named you 'Catra,' It wasn't exactly a Mer-Mystery."

Catra's mouth fell open, then closed. Angella chuckled, remembering Mermista's father. *He was a handful. Or ten.* She remembered him wrestling with a squid to impress Mermista's mother. Angella blinked. *I can't remember their names,* she quailed. After a moment, she shook it off. Catra took a breath. "Okay. So, you're as bad about beating yourself up as Adora. Got it." Angella chuckled. "Do you think that was really Horde Prime?"

Angella sighed, letting herself smile again. "I could not guess, though I hope he was. I would rather the war ended with exile rather than execution. To think you tried to forgive that monstrosity." Her smile broadened. "Are you the same girl who nearly toppled Brightmoon? Surely not."

Catra's ears shot upright as she blushed. "Sh-shut up!" she blurted, looking away. Angella giggled, feeling a thousand years younger. "I mean – gah! Sorry!" The magicat buried her face in her hands.

With as much gentle care as she could muster, Angella drew Catra closer, curling one wing around her. “Are you quite done deflecting, dear, or have you other questions?”

The magicat spluttered, then curled in on herself. In spite of all the normal cats she’d cared for, Angella was still amazed at how small Catra could become. “She gave up on me,” Catra whispered. “And I – deserved it.”

“Catra. There is blame, and there is responsibility. You have chosen to take responsibility for your actions, which is all to the good,” Angella explained. “Have you thought, however, that perhaps you are overcompensating?”

Again, Catra spluttered. “Overcompensating? I blew up the world!” she pointed out. “You almost died!”

Angella put a hand on Catra’s shoulder, willing it to be kind. “Yes. It takes great skill to overdo remorse in your case.” Catra tried to speak, but aside from a tiny mew, no sound came out. “Catra, in my experience, people want to believe that we either have absolute control over our fates, or none at all. It is never that simple. Context matters. You were kidnapped as a child, mind-wiped, abused, denigrated, indoctrinated, discriminated against, expertly manipulated, and *literally tortured* for most of your childhood. I suspect you made sacrifices for Adora that she is not aware of to this day.” Catra huffed – and leaned into Angella’s arm. “Your countless traumas do not make your worst actions right, but to me, those actions are both understandable and forgivable, especially given your extraordinary efforts to atone for them.” Again, Catra mewed, somehow curling further into herself. “You’re angry with her, aren’t you?”

Catra gasped and looked up at Angella. “How – agh!” The magicat’s hands shook. “Yes! Yes, I am, but I’m even angrier that I don’t have the right.”

By the Stars. Angella took care in moving to hug Catra. “Yes you do.” The queen felt Catra’s gasp as much as heard it. “Catra,

emotions happen. They are neither right nor wrong, save love, which is never wrong. It is our actions that we must direct, and you have learned the importance of this."

Catra snorted. "Yeah, the hard way. The really hard way."

"Yet the pain others have caused you played its part," Angella insisted. "Further, if I might hazard a guess, you are struggling with how to deal with Adora's stubborn streak." Catra chuckled while Angella continued. "While capable of admitting error, she must clearly be confronted with overwhelming evidence."

Catra growled, ears pivoting back. "I – I'm not blaming her for that again. I can't."

Angella blinked; while not as exhausted as the magicat, she had not slept much herself since her ordeal. "Blame? For–" Angella gasped. *Shadow Weaver literally tortured Catra. But not Adora. That was more – subtle.* She indulged in making a fist with her free hand. "Oh. *Oh."* The queen unclenched her fist and rubbed her face. "Catra, have you spoken to Adora about this?"

Catra looked up at her in alarm. "What? No! No, and I'm never going to! You know what Adora's like, she'll never forgive herself if she knows that witch was hurting me right in front of–"

"Catra?" Adora's sleepy voice echoed along the hall. "You there?"

Catra turned pleading eyes on Angella. "Please. You can't tell her, not now. Even – even at my worst, when I burned the whole world because Shadow Weaver left me for her, there was still enough love left in me to protect her from that." Angella grimaced, and Catra's eyes widened. "Please."

"I understand, Catra, but you are not protecting her," Angella pointed out. "Adora deserves to know the truth."

"Catra?" Adora tried again. Angella stroked Catra's hair as the woman – *Stars, barely more than a girl, really,* the queen thought

– shivered.“If you’re looking for something to eat, we can just go to the kitchen.”

“I will not tell her,” Angella conceded, and Catra gave a surprising hug, “but you should. Talk to one another, Catra. Trust her.”

“Told you. Coward,” Catra said.

“Oh, no,” Adora gasped.

Catra’s ears and tail shot up in alarm. “Crap. I forgot to put the letter back!” she gasped.

“Catra! Catra, where are you?” Adora cried, bursting through the door. Melog bounded towards them. “For the Honor–”

“Over here, Adora,” Catra replied. Quickly.

“I have her, dear,” Angella added. Adora practically appeared before them, Melog mewing and rubbing against Catra’s hip. “You two really should talk, Adora. I would suggest sleep, but I rather doubt either of you will get much tonight.”

Adora’s eyes were wide and shaken, already rimmed with tears. “Catra, I’m so sorry–”

“For what?” Catra snapped, turning further into Angella’s embrace. “Being right? Again?”

“I was wrong!” Adora blurted, and Catra looked up with such desperate hope that Angella had to suppress the urge to hold them both. “I shouldn’t have given up on you. I should never have – and I would, I’d do so many things differently if I could, I’d talk, I’d *listen–”*

“Adora!” Catra cried, flinging herself into the heroine’s arms. They held each other, shaking in silent communion.

“Well, that appears to be my cue,” Angella noted, standing. “Still, I think I must elaborate on what I thought my last request.” Both

young women looked up at her. “Adora, let Catra take care of you. Catra, let Adora take care of you.” Angella smiled. “Take care of each *other.”* Then she scooped them up in a cushion made of light, both yelping in alarm. “Now. To bed with you both.” Indulging in a mother’s prerogative, she carried them back to Adora’s room and gently deposited them on her cot. “I will be up for a time if you need me.” With that, she showed herself out.

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Catra and Adora looked at each other and laughed, the magicat collapsing onto the cot. Melog put her paws by Catra’s shoulder and licked her cheek. “Okay, okay, I’m better, Melog.”

Melog huffed and dropped back to the floor, curling up and staring. Her eyes and mane turned orange. Adora smirked. “Busted.” Catra glared. *Traitor,* she thought. Melog huffed again and looked away. “Melog’s a tell the size of Brightmoon.” The smirk vanished, and Adora sat beside Catra, taking her hand. “Talk to me? Please?”

Catra closed her eyes, too exhausted to even turn over. “Sparkles’ mom is kinda awesome.”

Adora paused. “I know,” she replied, giving Catra’s hand a gentle squeeze. “Did she help?”

“Yeah.” Catra shuddered, remembering too much all at once. “I think. She said it was okay for me to be mad at you, if I didn’t do anything bad.” She managed a faint smirk of her own. “Well, she was way more speechy about it, but hey, queen.”

Adora sighed, and Catra opened her eyes again. The sorrow on her face broke Catra’s heart. “Catra, I’m glad you understand that you hurt people, but that doesn’t make it okay that other people hurt you. It’s not okay that *I* hurt you, or that I let Shadow Weaver hurt you–”

“You didn’t *let* her hurt me, Adora!” Catra snapped, failing to sit up. “We were kids, what were you supposed to do?” Then she

froze, eyes wide. “Wait, you knew?” Catra whispered. “You *knew* what she was doing to me?”

Adora’s eyes mirrored Catra’s. “I – I thought I did. I mean, the paralysis, the threats, cruel words every day – Catra, was there more?”

Stupid! Stupid stupid STUPID! Catra howled at herself, curling up as tight as she could. “That was enough,” she whispered. *Don’t ask,* please *don’t ask*–

Adora didn’t ask. When Catra felt Adora’s hand quivering in hers, she realized Adora didn’t have to. “I’m such an idiot,” she breathed.

Catra uncurled. Adora’s eyes were wide, and she’d gone pale enough to rival Hordak. “Adora, no, please,” Catra begged.

“The nights you never came to bed, the mornings you could barely move, all the times you were on half-rations, you *always* flinched at Garnet lightning, you barely had a mark after Scorpia – oh Stars, when we were sixteen, you crawled into bed and begged me to run away with you,” Adora remembered. *Nonono not like this!* Catra tried to sit up, but collapsed, too exhausted after nine days of pushing herself *way* too hard. “It was her, wasn’t it? All of it.”

“Now? Seriously?” Catra tried to bare her fangs, in voice and in truth, but neither worked. “You figured it out now?”

Adora took a deep, shuddering breath, then let it go. “Catra? May – may I hold you?” Catra sighed and nodded. The cot was hardly wide enough for one person, but somehow Adora managed to curl around her. “I...I get why you didn’t tell me before. She’s gone now. Please don’t let anyone hurt you again without telling me. *Please.”*

Catra released a thoroughly catlike whine, then surrendered. “Fine. Okay.”

Adora shuddered against the magicat. "I get why you were so mad in Thaymor, now. I saw it with strangers, but not–" A tear dropped onto Catra's shoulder. "I'm such an *idiot."*

"Adora, please, enough," Catra sighed. "I kinda overreacted. A lot. And it was still me not wanting to share you, and feeling like second best, I didn't make those up–" Catra froze. *Oh. Oh, WOW. This is exactly what I deserve, isn't it?*

Catra laughed, stopping when Adora stiffened and looked her in the eyes. "Catra, that sounded like a bad laugh," Adora said.

"Nah. I just realized, I did all those horrible things to prove I'm worth something without you." Catra smirked and shook her head. "And oh look, all I proved is, I'm not." Adora gasped. "Everything I'm good for is about you. Isn't that just the perfect punishment?" Melog whimpered. Catra's smirk vanished at the horror on Adora's face. *Oh. Crap.* "Well, except that I love you and I'm still happy with you but–"

Adora uncurled from around her and stood. "Okay, no." She reached into the air. "For the Honor of Grayskull!"

Before Catra's eyes had adjusted to the blinding flash, She-Ra had scooped her up in her arms and carried her out into the hall. "Adora! Did you turn into She-Ra or Scorpia?" Catra tried to squirm out of Adora's arms, but even though Adora wasn't pinning her down, she lacked the strength to pull herself out.

In moments, they were in front of Glimmer's door. "Glimmer? I need your–" Adora began.

They vanished and reappeared in a burst of shimmering light. Catra's stomach was too tired to overload, settling for a nasty lurch and one gulp. "Sorry, Catra," Glimmer looked her over with a gasp. "Stars, are you okay?"

"I'm fine," Catra muttered before she could stop herself. She tried to facepalm – and missed, covering her mouth instead.

Glimmer stared for a moment. “I’m getting Bow,” she announced, vanishing and reappearing with a pajama-clad, teeth-brushing Bow before either of them could react.

Bow dropped his toothbrush, jaw following. “Catra?” he gasped. “Have you been eating?”

“Aagh – of course I’ve been eating!” she objected, clenching fists. Her stomach didn’t so much growl as roar. Adora glared. Catra looked away. “I’ve been eating light, so what?”

“Catra thinks she’s not worth anything without me,” Adora explained to the Best Friends Squad. “Help?”

Glimmer looked at Bow with a pleading gaze that stunned Catra, whose attempt at a growl came out as a mewl. *How did this sparkly princess end up caring about* me *of all people?* she wondered.

Bow grinned. “Actually, I was going to do this in a few days anyway–” he began.

“Wait, *what?”* Catra blurted.

Bow sighed. “Look, Catra, it took me a while to get past – you know,” Bow began.

"You know, it took me a while, but I finally figured out your character." Catra shook it off. “Yeah.”

“But I finally realized that all you ever wanted was for people to accept and appreciate you for the person you are. I really get that,” Bow continued, briefly subdued. “So, since you need food and rest, first thing is, we’re gonna have a sleepover!”

Glimmer lit up. “Bow, that’s a great idea!” she gushed, teleporting a mass of blankets and pillows to the floor.

“We’re gonna talk about all the amazing things you’ve done,” Bow continued, Adora smiling like a star and Melog purring like an

engine, “and when you’re rested, you’re gonna lead a mission to remind you how awesome you are.”

Catra scoffed. “The only good I’ve done is fixing my own mistakes,” she muttered.

“Ugh!” Glimmer threw her hands up. “Look, Catra, no one’s gonna say you didn’t do anything wrong, but you didn’t build the portal, kidnap children, or create the Horde. You’re doing way more good now than any bad you did.”

“You’re also wrong about the mistakes thing,” Adora added. “You didn’t have anything to do with the First Ones, but you saved me from that monster, and then again in the Heart.” She chuckled. “Besides, you took down Shadow Weaver and Hordak! As a *bad guy,* you were a better hero than I was.”

Catra’s ears shot upright. *What?!* “Are you crazy?” Catra snapped. “Queen Angella–”

“Home,” Glimmer retorted.

“Salineas–” Catra tried again.

“Completely restored,” Bow pointed out, waving a Galactic Horde control pad Catra recognized. He pulled it out of her reach before she could grab it. “Funny how the Horde’s bots fixed the place up like new. But you’d know all about that, huh?”

“Only you could conquer an entire kingdom without killing anyone, Horde scum,” Glimmer quipped, her smile gentle.

“Aagh,” Catra groaned, curling up in Adora’s arms. “Don’t sleepovers have sleep? Princesses don’t make sense.”

The other three laughed, then Adora lowered Catra into a nest of bedding. “Everyone deserves love, Catra,” Bow continued. “Love’s not about earning.”

Glimmer's smile vanished. "No matter what Shadow Weaver taught you."

"And we'll be here to prove it to you," Adora insisted. Catra couldn't help mewing and curling up against She-Ra when she dropped down behind her. "As long as it takes."

"...thanks," Catra murmured, already drifting off. Bow's eyes sparkled like his girlfriend. She was too tired to let it bother her.

For the first time in her life, Catra felt completely safe, letting herself rest at long last.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Adora watched, pretending not to be terrified, as Catra marched towards the renegade Horde company, walking into the kill-box of a valley apparently alone. *She'll be fine. We found their commander's snipers. Netossa, Spinerella, Perfuma, and – Angella, of all people – are ready to take them out. Glimmer's overhead with Swift Wind for a fast rescue if we need one. Melog has me and Bow cloaked if she needs us. Entrapta and Hordak are in Darla if things get really messy.* Adora took a long, deep breath. *She'll be* fine. *Breathe.*

A smile crept across Adora's face when she remembered Catra explaining why she wanted to bring Angella along. *"The lady who wanted to stay trapped in a void with Horde Prime to protect* me *thinks she's a coward. I'm not gonna let that slide."* All the same, she imagined the Sword in her hand as a vanguard strode out to meet her love. "Commander Catra," the leader said. Adora didn't recognize the voice, but from the way Catra's ears swiveled up, she did. "So good to see you again."

"Hey, Dreer," Catra replied, and their leader slid off his helmet. He looked like a male Light Spinner, his smirk on an azure face, pointed ears as long as Catra's. "You're good, but you were one of Shadow Weaver's. This isn't your show. Where's Vultak?"

Dreer's smirk vanished. "How–" he stopped, then snarled a curse. "Sneaky. You've always been sneaky. Doesn't matter. General Vultak is beyond you. He's rebuilding the Horde, and he has an entire terrified galaxy ready to obey someone who can lead them." He glared at Catra, one finger pointed out, glowing with dark power. "It could have been you. The Horde would have followed you into the void, but you went back to *her.* Shadow Weaver's golden child – she gave Adora *everything,* while she took even your magic!"

Adora's heart lurched, tears forming – until Catra *laughed.* She drew a magic circle in the air, then shattered it with her claws. "Please. I've got magic, but we both know I never needed it. Stand down." Her smirk vanished. "The Horde was a lie." Dreer's soldiers murmured behind her. "The princesses were never evil. We didn't bring peace. Prime literally stuck Hordak's dream in his head, and it was a boot stamping on every face, forever. I never cared about any of that crap. All I wanted was to prove myself to someone. I chose the wrong people."

"*We* believe in you!" one of the other soldiers cried, and Adora's heart started again.

The one voice turned into a torrent, Catra's eyes growing wider with each addition. "You destroyed the Box!" "You ended rationing punishment!" "You fixed requisitions!" Adora gasped as one voice after another cried out the things she'd done, not to them, but *for them.*

"Enough!" Catra roared, holding up her hands. Dreer turned, jaw dropping at the sight of his soldiers obeying her. "If you believe in me, go home. The war is over! No one is going to attack the Fright – Scorpion Hill. Queen Angella has declared an amnesty for everyone in the Horde, if we can just live in peace." The soldiers stared for a moment, then murmured among each other.

Dreer gulped. "E-enough of this farce! Fire!" he ordered.

Nothing happened. Dreer gasped. A bear-woman tore off her helmet and glared at him. "Do you think we're going to attack *Commander Catra,* you traitor?"

Catra laughed. "Nah. He just means the snipers my team took out five minutes ago." At those words, Netossa and Spinnerella stood, revealing one windblown group caught in blue strands, while Perfuma and Angella emerged with half their captives bound in vines and half sealed in jeweled light. "You really want to give up now, Dreer."

"Feckless child!" Dreer snapped, magic glowing around one hand and a stun baton flying into the other. "I challenge you for leadership of the Horde!"

Catra shrugged, her smirk growing. "Okay." Adora gasped, leaping forward and reaching for the Sword, magic words on her lips–

It was over in a flash. Before Dreer could fire his baton, let alone form a spell, Catra had dashed into his face, leaped, slashed his baton into diced metal with one hand, kicked his spell hand, and driven a knuckle-punch into the gap between breastplate and belt. Dreer folded like Bow playing Bridge. Catra tossed the fringe of hair that had grown back aside while Dreer groaned at her feet. *Oh, Stars,* Adora thought, staring as she licked her lips. *Catra looks amazing like that.*

Bow chuckled. "Come on," he said, waving as Melog turned them visible and he headed over to help get the former soldiers home. "You can ogle your girlfriend later."

Adora's face went blazing hot. "I – I wasn't *ogling!"* Melog chuckled and padded after Bow. Adora wondered if sinking into the ground might be one of She-Ra's powers.

It wasn't, so she had to endure more than a few chuckles – even from the Horde soldiers! – as she jogged over to Catra's side. Adora watched, glowing with pride, while Catra moved through the group, assuring them that the Princess Alliance wouldn't harm

them. “Skiffs are on the way,” she told one fire team. “Scorpia’s got the Zone running. You’ll be fine.”

“So, you’re not good for anything besides me, huh?” Adora asked. Catra yelped, leaped, and whirled on Adora. The soldiers spun, hands on baton holsters. She-Ra put up her hands. “Hey, her words, not mine. This operation’s secondary goal was proving her wrong.”

Adora bit down on a squee when even the team of random Horde soldiers turned “really?” looks on Catra. Catra’s blush was the most exquisite thing Adora had ever seen. “ADORA!” Catra wailed. Melog leaped to her side, and the two vanished. The Alliance members laughed.

It didn’t take long for Adora to find Angella, Catra and Melog under a tree, looking towards the distant Fright Zone. “It is good to see Scorpion Hill recovering,” Angella explained, Catra scratching Melog’s head while the big cat licked her arm. “I’ve petitioned the Alliance to hold the next Princess Prom in Scorpia’s realm.”

Catra laughed. It was the most beautiful sound in the universe. “And I promise 100% less Heat Bombs this time.” She finally saw Adora standing there. “Hey, Adora. Enjoying the view?”

“Yep. Best in the world,” Adora replied, looking at Catra. The magicat looked away, blushing.

“I should check on Glimmer,” Angella said, spreading her wings and soaring off.

“Subtle,” Catra chuckled. She gave Adora that smile. “Thanks, Adora. For trusting me.”

“Of course,” Adora replied, hugging Catra. “I have faith in you.”

“You never did have much faith in me.” The old memory seemed to glitch into oblivion as Catra returned the hug. “So,” Catra said. “Still want that road trip?”

“Only if you’re ready,” Adora insisted.

Catra laughed again. “Come on. What would you dorks do without me?”

Adora joined her laugh. “Good thing we’ll never have to find out,” she replied, sliding out of the hug to hold Catra’s hand. Side by side, they walked together toward the future.

Chapter End Notes

Aargh I thought I was done with this fic but TOO MANY FEELS

Seriously, I loved the ending of Season 5, but did Catra end up as anything other than Adora's gf? Fortunately, even a cursory glance at Adora's post-development character makes it obvious that she'd have NONE of that. Besides, I wrote a Momgella fic with no Momgella. WTF.

For anyone who's wondering, yes, that's the letter from Rebel Princess Guide.

Also, I had to get in a little "Catra being badass turns Adora on" action. *g*

Magicats

Chapter Summary

> Catra discovers that the only thing harder for her to deal with than judgment is adoration.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Even after a month in Brightmoon, Catra hadn't gotten used to peace. Happiness was even stranger – in some ways, it was *a* stranger to her. Still, wandering through the celebration, Adora's hand in hers, was joy even the magicat couldn't mistake for anything else. The occasional glare she got was surprisingly tolerable. Stars, Catra found herself getting more smiles than glares.

And it's not like this isn't practical, Catra told herself. *There's like six different plays on about how She-Ra saved the universe from the Horde. Double Trouble has to be here somewhere.* She glanced at one performance, wincing at the sight of her fictional self toy with a crystal-possessed Adora. "Hey," Adora insisted, pulling Catra closer, "it's over."

"Yeah, I know," Catra muttered. Then her eyes widened as play-Catra and play-Adora froze, moving towards each other with agonizing need, lips slowly pursing. "I don't remember us being that…intense, though."

"I think it's called 'artistic license,' or something," Adora mumbled, cheeks burning, as she tugged Catra along faster.

Then, where the play had given Catra pause, the children dressed as She-Ra and – Catra herself? – froze her solid. Rather than fighting each other, however, the two girls were battling puppet Horde-clones about their size. Grinning adults paraded the figures past on long sticks for the pair to defeat. "Don't matter how many

clones you have! We're She-Ra and Catra!" kid-Catra boasted, the ears on her headband wiggling.

"No one can beat us together!" kid She-Ra cheered, twirling a little wooden Sword. Adora gasped and hugged Catra. *No way. Kids are playing – me?*

"But you're *bad,* Catra," one of the adults called, shaking a larger Horde Prime puppet at them. "You'll always be bad." Catra froze. She couldn't breathe. Adora's hand in hers became her only anchor to Etheria.

"Nuh-uh!" kid-Catra snarled back. "Just 'cause I was bad before, doesn't mean I've gotta be bad now!" The grown-up with "Horde Prime" sneered for their figure, pulling their puppet back. The other adults smiled.

"You can't make us fight each other any more!" kid She-Ra jumped in, literally, side by side with Catra's little counterpart. "For the honor of Grayskull! Boom!"

The adults laughed and cheered, scattering their puppets. The Horde Prime puppeteer tried for a dramatic "Nooo!", but was laughing too hard to pull it off. *So, definitely not Double Trouble,* Catra decided.

"What are you doing?" The children froze, as did Catra, as a sea elf hobbled towards them on a metal leg, leaning heavily on her cane. "That tyrant is no role model."

"B-but she learned to be good," kid-Catra stammered, tears brimming in her eyes.

The sea elf stared at the girl for a moment, eyes narrowing. "And now she's a hero?" the woman rapped her artificial leg with the cane. "Must be nice."

"Hey," the Horde Prime actor jumped in, "they're just kids, leave them alone." The sea elf turned on him, scowl deepening.

Okay, no, Catra thought, striding forward before a shocked Adora could stop her. "Hey! You wanna yell at someone for being me, try starting with me," Catra insisted.

The kids dressed as her and She-Ra gasped, then cheered. The old sea-elf recoiled for a moment before realizing Catra wasn't attacking. "You don't get to be self-righteous with me, magicat traitor!" she snapped, leaning towards Catra on her cane. "You did this. No one should pretend you're some kind of role model!"

Adora rejoined Catra, but she ignored the hero. "And I'm sorry about it, and if I can help you, I will," Catra replied, "but come after me, not a couple of little kids."

"What would you know about it, monster?" the woman said.

Catra snorted. "Taking out someone hurting you on other people is how you become me, lady," she pointed out. The old woman froze. Then, with tears in her eyes contrasting the snarl on her lips, she raised the cane, and Adora moved to intervene, and Catra stepped forward to stop her–

–but a clawed hand grabbed the cane and forced it back down before the woman could swing. "That's enough," the man said, helping the sea elf regain her footing. That let Catra get a good look at the...magicat?!

He was big, with enough muscle to make up about two Catras, gray furred with white points, golden eyes like Catra's one, and a compressed staff like Huntara's on his hip. Behind him, a magicat woman a bit younger than Catra leaped beside him, with purple fur and blue eyes like Catra's other. "I understand your anger, madam," the magicat man continued, everyone frozen and staring at him, "but Shadow Weaver stole Catriska's memories with her freedom. Please let us make this up to you in her stead."

The sea elf hobbled back, jaw dropping. Catra shook her head, blinking through crimson haze to focus. "Who–" she began.

The memory roared to life in her mind… *Catriska laughed. "Again, Uncle Percy! Again!*

Sir Percival laughed back, playing with the compressed hilt. "Well, if my favorite niece insists," he quipped.

"That's cheating. I'm your only niece," Catriska noted with a pout. Kyra smiled and hugged her daughter.

Catra gasped. "Uncle...you're an uncle..."

The other magicat woman smiled, golden eyes alight. "She's starting to remember, Sir Percival!"

Percival's jaw hardened. "That...could present issues," he whispered, staring at Catra. Her head felt like Shadow Weaver was practicing lightning between her ears. "Try to calm down, kit."

Everything tilted, noise too loud and colors spinning and lights too bright and shadows too dark and she saw Percival playing with her and fire raging through her home and dark magic a spear through Mom's heart and lost lost everything lost–

-SR- -SR- -SR-

I'm not panicking, Adora lied to herself, gripping Catra's hand as though she would disappear if Adora let go.

They'd spent days making sure Catra recovered from her sacrifices working to rescue Angella, the magicat spending as much time in the infirmary as their room. Adora had hoped more than anything that they wouldn't see the place again until one of them was giving birth.

For the first time, the thought didn't make her blush.

At least we're not alone, Adora thought, grateful for the Best Friends Squad, royal couple, and Melog being there. *And then there are the...other magicats.* Sir Percival – *Uncle* Percival, apparently – sat on the other side of Catra's cot, stroking her still-

too-short hair while Adora held Catra's hand. And the other magicat lady, whom they still hadn't introduced, watched Catra with intense concern from a perch on a cabinet, curled up so much like a nervous Catra it made Adora's heart ache.

"Come on, you guys," Glimmer insisted, "stop worrying. It's Catra! She's probably the toughest – non-princess alive."

Percival replied with a wan smile. "Even after Shadow Weaver, she still takes after Kyra in some ways," he said, hand pausing on Catra's forehead.

"That's Catra's mother, right?" Adora asked, finding the strength to look at him properly.

Micah nodded with a smile. "I can't believe I had trouble remembering her. She was a dear friend during my years in Mystacor. A few years older..." the smile faded. "...and in love with Light Spinner."

Bow gasped. "Oh, no..."

The other magicat's eyes narrowed. "It's a good thing she's dead," she hissed, holding out a palm. Fire came to life above her palm. "For her."

"Felicia..." Percival sighed.

Angella stared while Micah gasped and stood. "Felicia? Little Felicia?" the king asked.

"For Bast's sake! I'm not a baby any more," Felicia huffed, uncurling her arms from around her knees to cross them.

Micah smiled. "You got away," he whispered.

Felicia shook her head, closing her eyes. Adora noticed tears forming in spite of that. "No. Catriska saved me. She got me to the palace, pushed me into a vent, closed the grill behind me."

Her tail lashed almost exactly the way Catra's would when she was upset. "She got caught saving me."

"Oh." Adora smiled. "Oh, wow. Catra thought she'd been abandoned, but all this time, she'd been a hero from the beginning." She stroked Catra's hair, trying to keep the *please wake up* mantra in her mind under control. "Stars, I want to be here when she finds out." Felicia huffed and looked away. Adora chuckled. "Are you related?"

"Cousins," Percival explained, his smile returning.

"The D'riluth family has been the heart of magicat defense for generations," Angella explained. "The council has chosen half the kingdom's queens from them since before Mara's time."

Catra groaned. The conversation stopped, all eyes on the slender magicat. "Wha – where – oh, slag," Catra sighed. "I fainted? Kill me now."

"You didn't faint," Percival half-growled. "That was Shadow Weaver's magic kicking in."

Catra snorted, holding her head with her free hand. "It sure felt like someone kicking my head in."

Felicia hissed. "I wanted to kick Shadow Weaver's head in."

"Shadow Weaver should die in a fire," Catra snapped. Before Adora could even gape, Catra smirked. "Oh wait. She did."

Adora clamped her hand over her mouth, horror and laughter warring inside her. Felicia laughed, apparently having no such conflict. Micah's face went neutral, though. "Catra," Adora finally said, regaining some control, "that was – *so* inappropriate."

"But fair," Glimmer agreed, crossing her arms.

"Catriska," Percival cut in, and the banter came to a stop. "It wasn't your fault. What Shadow Weaver did to you happened

because you saved an innocent child," he continued, and Adora recognized the distress in Felicia's ears going flat, "and you collapsed today because the witch wanted you helpless if you ever remembered."

"That certainly sounds like her," Micah muttered, sounding sad. Angella gave him a one-armed hug which he returned.

Catra's bravado vanished as quickly as it had appeared. "I – I still–"

"Got mindwiped and brainwashed saving me," Felicia whispered, then uncurled and leaped down to land beside Percival. "Forget them. Come to Halfmoon! You can be with us – with your people," the princess gushed, grasping Catra's other hand. Catra's eyes went wide, shining blue and gold. Adora fell in love with her all over again. "You belong there."

"Yeah, until they find out what I – until *you* find out–" Catra pulled both hands free and curled up as tight as Adora had ever seen. "– don't – don't *look* at me."

Angella and Micah looked at each other in alarm. Adora wrapped Catra in a hug, holding her close. "It's going to be all right, Catra," Adora said. Melog shrank to housecat size and leaped into Catra's arms, nuzzling against her cheek.

"Triss," Percy whispered, stroking her hair, "we already know." Catra turned her head to look up at him, eyes wide. "We've been trying to reach you for so long, but..."

Felicia sighed. "My mom is kinda overprotective."

"You too, huh?" Glimmer asked, her smile sympathetic.

Angella gasped. *"Glimmer!"*

Glimmer stared suddenly, eyes misting over. "I...missed you so much..."

Somehow, that distracted Catra from her misery, and she looked up at Adora, the question obvious in her eyes. "No idea," Adora replied. "It wasn't exactly something unusual my first year in Brightmoon."

"'Glimmah'?" Catra muttered, shaking her head.

"Please," Felicia pleaded, "give us a chance."

Catra's head fell back onto the gurney. "You're not the ones who don't deserve one." Felicia let out a familiar, unhappy mew.

Adora stood. *Okay, no.* She concentrated, and a memory of the Failsafe flickered over her heart. Catra gasped. "You saved the universe," Adora reminded her love, matching gazes with light-soaked eyes. "I was beaten. Broken. Lost. You reached me and set me free, then gave me the strength to survive all Etheria's power."

"You did a lot more than one good thing, Horde scum," Glimmer added, smiling.

Catra sighed and sat up. "Everyone here knows how that lady lost her leg, right?" When no one responded, she put her hand over her eyes, holding her head. "I'm not getting out of this, am I?"

"You'll get a hero's welcome," Felicia insisted. "I promise."

Adora's eyes widened when Catra looked up again, her expression a mask but ears and tail shooting out. "I...okay. Just...I take promises seriously." Adora held Catra's hand again, trying not to worry. *That's an understatement.*

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Catra hadn't stopped gaping since they walked through the illusory wall at the end of the maze. *This is the most beautiful place I've ever seen,* she thought, unable to stop herself from gawking like a rube.

Towering spires covered in some gorgeous blue stone with golden streaks, apparently called lapis lazuli, magically controlled the water supply. They pulled streams through the air to fill aqueducts overhead, creating shining arches of liquid in the process. Long buildings built with stone columns and crimson bricks were lit by crystals literally called tiger's eyes, golden light shining between red bands. Archways of sand-colored stone held up bridges between buildings in the upper layers, where Bubasti rode elegant skiffs and impressive winged steeds called Takdryl – lizards shaped like horses, but with claws and fangs. Plus, you know, the wings.

They were cool enough that Catra almost wanted one. Almost.

And everywhere, *everywhere,* there were people who looked like her. Bubasti – magicats – of every shape and size, with fur ranging from midnight black to snowy white, with metallic blue, golden orange, silver-gray, and her own tawny brown in between. Almost none of them wore shoes, much to Catra's relief.

A lot of them were staring – but Felicia's promise proved true. Most stared in awe, amazed at the lost champion come home. Whispers of "even Shadow Weaver couldn't control her" and "rescued She-Ra" wove around them.

Sure, there were a few more cynical gazes and voices, wondering how much Horde there still was in the prodigal molly – the word for female Bubasti, apparently. *I would've thought the whole thing was a con if* some *of them weren't suspicious, at least.* She held onto Adora's hand like a lifeline all the same and rounded another corner.

The palace stopped Catra in her tracks. It was a massive stepped pyramid, ten stories tall, with broader segments forming most of the body covered in lapis, while traditional staircases ran up all four sides to a chamber at the top covered in tiger's eye. Brightmoon was the only larger castle Catra had seen.

(She forced herself not to think of the Velvet Glove. It wasn't a real castle anyway.)

At least the others were as amazed as Catra was. Adora stared like the tourist she was, while Glimmer and Bow chattered with excitement. Micah was greeted as the returning hero he was, a few of the older magicats joyful at finally meeting his wife. Only Melog was impassive, accepting the adulation of the Bubasti as their due.

I wish Scorpia was here, Catra thought, feeling more like Adora's plus one than she had since before the Sword. *Or Entrapta.* Then Felicia leaped in front of her, smiling and holding out her hand. *That works, I guess.* Gathering her ragged courage, Catra followed Uncle Percy and Princess Felicia up the long staircase to the royal complex.

Then two of the guards transformed – they changed into great cats, one a massive tiger, the other a sleek panther – and raced up the steps. Catra froze, but mercifully, so did the others, except Micah. "That's...a thing we do?" she asked.

"Great Saz, they didn't even guide you through the First Change?" Percival stared in disbelief. "Did Hordak *want* to lose?"

Catra shrugged as they walked up the stairs – then almost stumbled when the stairs moved, carrying them up. "We were all pretty self-destructive in the Horde. Besides, Shadow Weaver hated me." Adora tensed beside her.

Felicia bristled, fur rippling. Catra pulled herself closer to Adora, winding her tail around Adora's wrist. The princess' mouth flattened into a line, then she transformed into a purple lioness and raced up the steps. Percival sighed. "Please excuse her," he said, scratching his hair. "Felicia's always felt bad about Catriska's capture."

Before any of them could process that, they arrived at the massive throne complex. There, magicat courtiers in fine outfits of

deep blue and shining gold watched, their chatter dying as the heroes walked past. Catra stroked Melog's mane, working to keep them both at a calm sky blue.

In moments, they were before twin thrones. One held a woman with raven hair and lavender fur, dressed in an elegant blue wrap with a gold belt and trim. Her eyes were a piercing scarlet, and her crown was simple, a single band of gold with a modest sapphire in the front. In the other sat a massive, tawny man with a fiery crimson mane encircling his face. He wore blue armor, but his was trimmed with steel rather than gold, only his bracers the ubiquitous color. Standing on the woman's other side was an elderly magicat, his fur almost silver, wearing a dark gray robe and leaning heavily on a cane. "Catriska, you stand before Queen Selina and King Claudus, rulers of Halfmoon and protectors of the Eyes of Qadi," Percival explained, then turned to the monarchs and straightened. "Your Majesties, it is my great honor to escort home Lady Catriska D'riluth, our lost champion."

"I'm a what now?" Catra blurted. The entire court froze. "Sorry, your, uh, majesties," she muttered, trying to bow. "I...the Horde didn't tell me anything about...well, me."

"Most champions of Halfmoon earn their titles through trials," the old guy replies, his voice just above a whisper. "However, some champions give birth to children with heterochromia, bearing the marks of great potential."

"Thank you, Minister Cloudfoot," the queen said with a nod. "It is clear, Lady Catriska, that you were deprived of much during your captivity." Catra gulped, tail lashing, but said nothing. *No idea what I'd say,* she thought. "It is my hope that you will stay for a time, learning of your people..." Selina smiled at last, her eyes warm and kind, "...and, perhaps, considering a place in our family."

Catra gasped, grateful she wasn't the only one. "What?" she blurted, kicking herself for that word having become half her vocabulary.

"Our debt to you is beyond repayment," Selina continued, "but I remember when you were a kit, and our families have always been close. We would be honored to adopt you, if you are willing."

Glimmer stepped forward before Catra's brain could unlock. "Whoa, hold on," the princess objected.

Felicia's narrow-eyed glare bordered on lethal, shadows gathering in one hand and a tiny flame in the other. "You think her unworthy, human?"

Glimmer's eyes bulged. "Unwor – *we* were talking about adopting her!" she insisted, gesturing at her parents.

For an instant, Catra couldn't see, blinded by a mix of disbelief and panic. Adora's grip felt like it was all that held her in reality. "You can't want me, you can't, you can't," Catra sobbed, swaying in place. There was a storm of motion around them, ears hypersensitive as Catra's eyes betrayed her.

"Catra!" Adora hugged her, holding her tight. "Breathe, come on, honey, it's okay."

"Sir Tao, escort our guests to their quarters," Selina ordered. "Today has clearly been...over-stimulating in some ways." Catra clung to Adora even as she spiraled. *Stupid, pathetic, weak...what's* wrong *with me?*

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Glimmer waited outside Catra and Adora's room, watching the door alongside Princess Felicia while Sir Percival helped calm the two down. "So, uh, no hard feelings?" Glimmer offered, rewarded with a laugh like a young Catra's.

"No, no hard feelings," Felicia replied, giving Glimmer a shoulder nudge. "I think our dads are talking about some kind of foster arrangement, so she can be both our sisters." the magicat's smile vanished. "If she even wants us."

Glimmer sighed. “I don’t know how much she remembers, but it’s...not a lot,” she said with a shrug. “Besides, Catra’s got...parent issues.”

“Shadow Weaver,” Felicia hissed. Glimmer nodded, swallowing her guilt. “Did you know, she offered to let Catriska escape?” Glimmer stared, jaw dropping. “She said something about one last mercy, for ‘a love long lost,’ as long as Catriska got out of the way.”

“And let her catch you,” Glimmer whispered. Felicia nodded, tears glistening with reflections of blue. “What happened?”

Felicia laughed. “What do you think? Triss bit her leg!” Glimmer gaped for a moment, then joined the laugh. “I could hear Shadow Weaver howling and stumbling, trying to pull Triss off while she sunk all her claws in!”

“Oh, Stars, I can just see it,” Glimmer chuckled, shaking her head. “Catra never does know when to quit.” Felicia nodded. “It sounds like you remember her, y’know, more than that.”

Felicia turned somber again. “Mom had...complications, when I was born. I’m an only child.” Glimmer nodded in sympathy. “Half my earliest memories are of Triss being, like, the *best* big sister. She was smart, and fun, and she never *ever* talked down to me even though she was almost two years older...” Felicia hugged herself with one arm, and it was so much like Catra’s insecure moments that it broke Glimmer’s heart. “I ran,” she whispered.

“Felicia–” Glimmer tried.

“She told me to run and I *ran* and *hid* like one of Set’s own cowards,” Felicia whimpered, shaking, “and Shadow Weaver murdered her mom and stole her memories and dragged her into a living nightmare!” She stared at the door with dull eyes. “It should’ve been me.”

“Whoa, hey, hey,” Glimmer said, taking Felicia’s free hand, “no one should have gone through, that. You were what, three? And I’ll

bet you just about anything that Catra's glad it happened saving you, instead of being found in a box."

Felicia spluttered, straightening and letting her arm go. "Is – is that what Shadow Weaver told her?"

Glimmer snorted. "She actually put Catra in a box. That's how Adora found her." Felicia's eyes narrowed again, glaring at the door. "Look, those two have plenty of of history, but trust me, they've both been through a lot. Nothing's going to tear them apart now."

Felicia sighed, looking down. "So. Um. I heard your boyfriend say something about a space trip."

"Bringing magic back to the universe," Glimmer said, nodding. "Plus, the Horde conquered a lot of planets, and Adora's people are probably out there somewhere."

"The First Ones." Felicia's tail lashed behind her. "Does she have to leave so soon?"

"Of course not," Bow said as he approached. *How did I get so lucky?* Glimmer wondered, not for the first time, sharing a smile with him. "Etheria needs a lot of help too, and I bet the Bubasti can do plenty now that the Horde's gone."

Felicia smirked, and Glimmer was again amazed at how much she was like Catra. "We're already doing plenty. Magicats are masters of illusion. We've had agents helping keep Vultak pinned down for years." The smirk vanished. "Mom and Dad wouldn't let me go out until I was 'of age,' blah blah blah," she continued, rolling her eyes, "but we've been keeping an eye on things disguised as other species."

Glimmer looked away. "Did...you send anyone after her?"

"Four different teams that first year," Felicia explained. "None of them ever returned."

Percival opened the door, and Catra walked out, freezing at the sight of the trio standing outside. “Um. Uncle Percy offered to show me how to do the...change thing.”

“The First Change?” Felicia blurted, watching Melog rub against Catra’s hip. “You guys really need to see this. It is so cool.” Catra swallowed and nodded.

“Hey,” Glimmer said, teleporting to Catra’s side and putting a hand on her shoulder, “you’ll do great. I know it.”

“That makes one of us, Sparkles,” Catra muttered.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Catra had never felt so good doing something that wasn’t tied to Adora.

Her body felt light, graceful, *free.* Her friends whooped and cheered as Catra darted through rings, leaped across platforms, ran along rails. She grew to rival Melog for a leap, then shrank to housecat size to fly through the air, then landed in her normal form.

“Holy Bast, you’re a natural!” Felicia cried, pumping a fist.

“Look at you go!” Percival chimed in, transforming and leaping up to join her.

Adora laughed. “So what other awesome magicat stuff can you do?”

“Dunno,” Catra replied, “but I’m gonna love finding out.” She glanced at Percy, changing and grinning in what she’d come to think of as her ligress form. “Hey, Uncle Percy, is the nine lives thing a magicat power too?”

Percy’s smile vanished. “So you know about that,” he replied, looking Catra over. “How many times have you died?”

"Wait wait wait, you *died?"* Adora blurted, eyes wide. "But, on Horde Prime's ship–"

"That was my last one," Catra replied, smirking as Adora stared. "You and your crazy She-Ra magic gave them all back." She couldn't help laughing at the dumbfounded look Adora gave her.

"You're doing better," Glimmer noted, smirking back.

Catra changed back into her normal form again, smile vanishing. "Yeah, I guess," she muttered. "It's just...a lot, you know? This changing thing helps."

"Magicats are changing folk," Percy explained. "Our other gifts are sources of great joy, but the First Change is a need."

"Okay, STOP," Adora demanded, and everyone did. "You died *nine times?"*

The others looked horrified. Catra shrugged. "Yeah. Mostly doing stupid crap." They all stared. It almost made Catra laugh again. *Honestly, what did they expect?* she thought, going through her deaths. "Shadow Weaver killed me the first time. Burned one for Sparkles. You saw the thing with Prime. The rest...yeah, stupid."

Glimmer's jaw dropped. "You *died* for me?!"

"I had one left," Catra noted. "I mean, I died to freak Adora out escaping from Princess Prom. Don't make a big deal out of it." Adora's eyes blew wide.

Felicia's eyes turned diamond hard. "Can Cloudfoot bring back Shadow Weaver, so I can kill her again?" Percival stared at her in horror. "I'll donate one of my lives, if that helps."

"She's not worth it," Catra replied, leaping back down. "Look, Felicia...I'm flattered. By, y'know, the adoption thing." She put a hand on the younger magicat's shoulder. "Can I have some time? I'm still remembering stuff."

Felicia nodded, transforming and leaping away. “Take all the time you need, Triss,” Percival said, giving her a quick hug. “We’re here when you’re ready.” He, too, changed and darted off.

“Yes!” Glimmer fist-pumped. “So, you’re coming back, right?” At Catra’s confused stare, she chuckled and rubbed the back of her neck. “It’s actually kind of funny. We hadn’t said anything yet because…well, we didn’t want to spook you.”

Catra snorted a chuckle. “Actually a good call.”

“Glimmer,” Adora sighed. Glimmer deflated, and Bow gave her a hug while Adora turned to face Catra. “Are you okay, Catra?”

“No!” Catra cried, causing all three to lock up. “I’m a slagging mess, Adora! I thought nothing could be worse than everyone hating me, but this – I think it’d be easier if they looked at me like a monster!” She held her head and looked down. “Why don’t they hate me?”

“Maybe because you saved the princess,” Bow offered, “and now we know Shadow Weaver was *trying* to make you mean.”

“Yeah. Well. It worked,” Catra sighed, ears and tail drooping. “I remember my mom, now. She was the best. And I...”

“You know, my mom told me something after you rescued her,” Glimmer said, doing Catra’s one-armed hug thing. “When I...told her what I’d done. She said that I made mistakes. Then she told me something important. ‘We are more than our mistakes.’” Catra looked up in surprise. “‘Everyone makes mistakes, Glimmer. What matters most is what you do next.’”

“My mistakes are a lot worse than yours, Sparkles,” Catra grumbled.

Glimmer crossed her arms. “Um, nope. Used your friends? Almost got them killed? Risked blowing up the world once to prove you were right?” She sighed. “Listened to Shadow Weaver?”

Catra chuckled. “Hey, she was better at that than the magic.” She looked away. “Look, I don’t know about this adoption thing, but...I really want to find out more about Halfmoon. Where I came from, what that means...” she looked back up, feeling incredibly vulnerable. “...you guys understand, right?”

“Of course,” Bow insisted. Glimmer nodded.

“Outer space can wait,” Adora agreed. “From now on, we do this together.” Catra hugged Adora and purred.

Sir Tao rushed in, causing Catra to leap back and straighten. “Lady Catriska! We have caught intruders who managed to navigate the maze, and they claim to know you. By your...surface diminutive,” he added, not quite rolling his eyes.

“Uh-oh.” Catra rushed after Tao, the others trailing after her. *It’s gotta be them. Who else would be smart enough to get through the maze and stupid enough to think it’s a good idea?*

Once they reached the maze entrance that protected New Halfmoon, they found a dozen guards surrounding Scorpia, Entrapta, and Double Trouble. The soldiers pointed sword-staff weapons like Huntara’s, and glowing gauntlets, at the trio. Scorpia and DT had their hands up, while Entrapta had one hand and both pigtails in the air, while holding her recorder in her remaining hand. “Halfmoon log one. We have reached the entrance of New Halfmoon. The locals have *fascinating* technology, and are suspicious of visitors for some reason – oh, hi, Catra!” Entrapta waved with a pigtail.

“We can explain, I assure you,” DT added, their smile wide and almost not nervous.

“Oh, gosh, I think we made a bad first impression,” Scorpia added. “Um, help?”

Catra couldn’t help it. She laughed. Somehow, finding them here felt like...*like things are going to be all right, somehow.* Adora smiled at her. Catra smiled back. *Maybe...they are.*

Chapter End Notes

Why did I do this. WHY.

...I wanted to get to Halfmoon sooner rather than later, but this took so long I could've probably gotten to the Turn Right version by now. Oh well, hopefully folks enjoy. I mean, angst with a happy ending? What are the chances?

Menagerie

Chapter Summary

> Since it's going to take a while in "Turn Right," Vultak finally gets his in this timeline. Also, lost friends are found, and an old shadow is confronted.

Chapter Notes

> TW: Temporary character death.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Hey, Double Trouble," Catra drawled, staring with her arms crossed. *Stone interrogation room. Nice,* she noted.

DT smiled back. "You look good, kitten."

Catra's smile vanished. "Call me that again, and we'll find out if you can shapeshift a new face."

DT swallowed, their smile wavering. "I'm sensing a dash of hostility here."

"Blaming me for Hordak and Shadow Weaver, then telling me 'it's for your own good'? Yeah, just a bit," Catra retorted.

Double Trouble blinked in both directions. "Kit–" Catra popped her claws. "You were driving away everyone you weren't paying. Sure, Sparkles bribed me, but I–"

"Stop *pretending,"* Catra snapped, slamming her claws into the table between them. DT jumped, shaken at last. "What I did to Adora and Scorpia was wrong, but Hordak and Shadow Weaver kidnapped and indoctrinated me as a child. Blaming me for all of them at the same time wasn't trying to help. You wanted to destroy me. You twisted the knife and *enjoyed it!"* Catra's tail lashed, hands trembling.

Double Trouble was quiet for a few seconds. The two locked eyes. DT looked away first. “It was...a bit of both, but be honest, kit, you’re one to talk.”

“Now we’re getting somewhere,” Catra growled. DT looked back at her in surprise. “No games, mercenary. No acting, no messing around, no ‘getting into the role.’ You brought Scorpia and Entrapta to soften me up.” DT did smile at that, just a fraction. “Why?”

“Fine, no foreplay,” DT sighed, rolling their eyes. “I need your help.” Catra raised an eyebrow. “So, maybe…I regret how things turned out. And there was something I didn’t tell you about Elberon.”

“Stop messing around and spill it,” Catra hissed.

DT looked at the table, and their shame seemed so real that Catra straightened, claws retracting. “Flutterina’s...a real person,” they admitted, one ear flicking. “Vultak has her. I want to rescue her, and I suspected you’d want to help, seeing as you’re one of the ‘heroes’ now.” They met her eyes again, expression cool and neutral.

Catra scowled. “You can’t cry on cue,” she whispered. For the first time, she saw true fear in DT’s eyes, wide and vulnerable. “You imagine children falling. Sparkles and I had a lot of time to chat. So why do you care now?”

Double Trouble sighed. “Same as you, I suppose. Scorpia.” Catra’s tail stopped lashing. “I thought all those princess heroics were nonsense. Good for a laugh, and their egos, but not enough to stop me from taking their money. Then Scorpia stayed behind to save us. She knew she would be chipped...” DT ran delicate fingers through their hair. “...and, well, I heard about what you did. So now I have a conscience.” They threw their head back. “I hate it.”

Catra couldn't help it. She laughed. DT's smile looked almost genuine. "There," they said. "No games, no 'messing around.' Send in Her Sorcerous Majesty if you don't believe me. She has a way with truth spells."

"If you're being straight with me, then sure, I'm in," Catra agreed, then forced her eyes to narrow. "If not, there's a princess here, with powers from *two* Runestones, who thinks she owes me." Catra walked out before Double Trouble could unnerve her even more.

"So?" Glimmer asked, the group of princesses (plus Bow) waiting in the observation room. DT smirked at the illusory wall. "Do you think they're telling the truth?"

Catra grimaced. "Yeah," she admitted. "If it's my fault that Vultak has a *kid,* there's no way I'm going to let that slide. Even if it's not...I want to do some good that isn't just fixing my messes, and Flutterina's the only part of this that's on me."

"What if it's a trap?" Adora asked, fingers twitching. Catra could almost see the light of her new Sword between them.

"Then we spring it back on the buzzard," Catra replied. "Problem is, I'm too close to this. Does anyone else think Double Trouble's telling the truth? I wasn't sure they knew how."

Scorpia and Adora both snorted chuckles. "I kinda do, actually," Scorpia said, rubbing the back of her neck. Which looked weird with a claw. "They seemed pretty sincere when they came to us for help." She indicated Entrapta and herself with a gesture.

"Just let me use a truth spell," Glimmer cut in, punching her palm. Catra couldn't help a slight smile. "Like they said, it's worked on them before."

"I appreciate it, Sparkles," Catra admitted, "but I'm trying to be better here. If Deety's trying too, I don't want to throw them off." She hesitated, then looked at Adora.

The big dork gazed back with a joy that almost literally gleamed in her eyes. Then Adora cleared her throat and straightened, doing her best 'I am serious' look. "Okay. Scorpia's got good instincts when it comes to people."

"Except me," Catra muttered.

Adora 'hmmph'ed at her while Scorpia deflated. "Catra, you pushed her away because she saw the good in you, and after I abandoned you, that scared you." Catra stared – *Stars, when did you get good at that?* she wondered – while Adora continued. "Besides, I agree with her. I think Double Trouble's sincere for once. I don't think even the actor in them would let them look vulnerable otherwise." She glared at the door. "Besides, we can take precautions for if we're wrong." Felicia and Glimmer shared a look, nodding to each other.

"Then let's bring Their Sparkly Royal Majesties in on this," Catra said, scratching her chin with one claw. "I wanted to bring down Vultak anyway. This hostage thing just moves him up the priority list."

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Angella stared at Claudus' report, caught between hope and horror. *A child princess, in the hands of that vile monster. Peekablue, his captive for sixteen years. And yet – both alive. We can still save them.* Determination like steel forged itself in her spine. *I will. I must!* She looked at the Horde defectors. "Have you some plan, Adora, Catra?"

Adora glanced at Catra. The magicat tried not to react, but her ears pivoted up and she purred ever so faintly. Sir Percival looked like he could float away, puffed with pride as he was. "Apparently, Vultak's obsessed with you, Your Majesty," Catra began.

"That's putting it mildly," Micah rumbled. Angella twined her fingers in his.

Catra's smirk was sour. "Double Trouble wants to help. So, they disguise themselves as Angella, and I take 'her' in as my prisoner. My cover story is that I've given up on the good guy thing, and giving you to him is proof I'm still evil."

"You were never *evil–"* Adora objected.

"Tell that to the sea elf with one leg," Catra retorted. Adora took in a breath to retort, humming with frustration.

Angella clapped once before they could spiral. "A philosophical debate for another time. Lady Catra?" she prodded.

Adora grimaced, making her cheeks bulge. Catra huffed, tail twitching, as she continued. "Point is, Melog brings in backup under their cloak." She let herself smile again as the alien symbiote nuzzled against her hand. "We find out what he's up to, Entrapta shorts out the collars in Menagerie Tower, Adora calms them down with her 'animals love me' magic, and the rest of us rescue princesses and stomp bird brains."

"That shouldn't take long," Glimmer said, fists shimmering. Felicia smirked, stone floating around one hand and flame burning in the other.

Catra looked at them both with a grim, sharp-edged glared. *I see how this woman claimed such high rank in the Horde as a child,* Angella noted. "Do not underestimate Vultak," Catra warned. "He was Hordak's best strategist before me, and on normal days is nastier than me at my worst. His second, Force Captain Styrax, is a stone-cold professional. Scorpia's old squadmates Dylamug and Callix ran to him, and they're both stupidly tough." Scorpia sighed, tail drooping. "Half the Horde loyalists flocked to him, pun intended," she added, a touch of her old smirk returning, "and until we free Vultak's beasts, they make his tower just about invincible."

The others stared for a long moment. Then Bow smiled. "Pfft. Sounds like a normal day for the Best Friends Squad."

"Yeah! Don't worry, Catra, we've got this." Adora gave Catra a gentle shoulder nudge, eliciting a genuine, if thin, smile from the magicat.

Angella took a deep breath. *They are not going to like this,* she thought, steeling herself. "A sound plan, Catra. I have but a single amendment." That turned all attention toward her. "I cannot allow anyone to risk Vultak's...interest in my person. I will be your 'prisoner' from the start."

There was a single beat of open-mouthed disbelief from all save her beloved Micah, who facepalmed. An instant later, the table became a cacophony of objection. Angella clapped once, bringing the outcry to a halt. "I do not recall bringing this up for debate," the queen pointed out. "I have history with Vultak. It is time for me to face it, and him."

"Angie," Micah began.

"Relax, angel-dad, it's not happening," Catra cut in, glaring and crossing her arms. "I did not lose six pounds rescuing you just to let Vultak get his vampire hands on you." Adora quivered, eyes flickering from love to queen.

Angella regarded the (heartsick, fearless) magicat with all the imperious command won over twenty millennia. "And how, precisely, do you intend to overrule me, Lady Catra?"

"I'll do it alone," Catra riposted, and Adora turned ghost-pale, "if I have to. I can get there before you." Her expression softened at the queen's slight flinch. "You can go cloaked with Melog, Your Majesty. If this is personal, I get–"

"I assure you, Catra, I am rather faster than you suspect," Angella replied. Catra's ears went flat. "I *will* do this."

"Mom, this is crazy!" Glimmer blurted. Bow gripped her hand. "I mean, it's Double Trouble, we literally pay them to do this."

"He'll know," Catra whispered, forcing herself not to bare her teeth. "If we go in there and I don't have your powers locked down with, like, a drug or Entrapta gear or something, Vultak will *know.* And if you're powerless – you can't do this." Her ferocity melted away, revealing a vulnerable youth that almost broke Angella's heart again. "please."

Angella closed her eyes. She could almost see the First Alliance – Ivy and Mercia playing a prank on Crystal destined to backfire (again), Bee sparring with then-Captain Juliet, both women grinning, Micah going on about his latest spell design to...

...Peekablue, the young seer's eyes alight with joy and hope...

"Bee insisted that Peekablue was alive," Angella explained. "I believed no one could have survived her final battle. It is my fault she has spent half a lifetime as Vultak's prisoner, that Bee left us to save her beloved, that we were blind to Shadow Weaver's schemes when we needed sight most." Her hands were shaking. Angella stilled them and opened her eyes. "I, I must do this. I *must."*

Micah sighed. "Trust me, no one here wants Angie to do this less than I do, but when she's made up her mind, that's the end of it." He looked at Catra. "How many people can your friend Melog cloak?"

"At least six, plus themselves," Catra grumped, frowning. "That's what we had in Mystacor."

"Okay. I learned to move quietly on...so I'm going," Micah said. As much as Angella wanted him on the other side of Etheria from Vultak, she couldn't help the relief – and love – she felt.

"Me too," Glimmer insisted, arms crossed. Catra raised an eyebrow but said nothing.

Bow looked from Glimmer to Adora, eyes tight with worry. "I'll be fine, Bow. I'll have Swifty," Adora assured him.

"I'll go with the blonde," Felicia said with a fierce nod. Then she grinned. "Someone's got to keep Catra's girlfriend safe."

Catra looked over the team, then sighed. "Okay. I'll have Double Trouble infiltrate as a random guard or something. Having to 'play an extra' will help prove their sincerity." Her eyes flickered. "So. I have a really important question." The others looked at her, curious. "Does anyone else here trust Hordak?"

A single beat. A cacophony of objection. Angella, to her own surprise, smiled. *This is not the nightmare's beginning. This is its final act.* Her smile faded with the argument. *I will never leave anyone behind again.*

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Catra's heart pounded like a factory piston. Angella trailed half a step behind and beside her, wrists manacled behind her connected to a collar, all glowing with something Entrapta called an "optical feedback loop." *I know what each word means,* Catra thought, the two of them seeming alone in the ascending elevator, *but when Entrapta puts something together, it doesn't make sense.*

She bit back a sigh, forcing herself to look fierce and heartbroken. *It just works. If it doesn't explode.*

Vultak's elevator had a glass wall for one reason – to show off his 'collection.' Fearsome beasts from across Etheria rattled cages, snarled at their neighbors, or curled on straw, up and down the enormous tower. A giant beetle from the Whispering Woods chittered at a two-headed Crimson Waste serpent. A pair of Takdryl huddled close to each other as they watched a four-winged serpent creature drink. In the center of the tower, a silvery creature that looked like the images of dragons Adora had shown her from Brightmoon's library twined around a pole in the center of its tube-shaped cage. All of it was in the familiar Horde green, metal plates and rivets, the only difference being that the prisons had bars as well as force walls.

"Fear not," Melog said in her mind. *"We are with you."*

Melog did another one of their magic things, and she could see Sparkles, Bow, King Micah, and Hordak (of all people) standing there around and behind her friend. *Yeah. Sure. Remind me to tell Bow not to call you a 'pet' after all this, okay?*

Melog paused. *"No,"* they replied.

That brought a smile to Catra's face, just in time for the doors to open and take it away.

Vultak stood before a mess of comm screens much like the one Catra had destroyed after losing Scorpia, with the wall-sized window behind them opening to the enormous shaft of the ten-story menagerie. A host of creatures both familiar and strange chittered and snarled below them.

That, unfortunately, was the least of their problems. The command center was almost the size of Hordak's throne room, and it held four dozen soldiers – half Etherian Horde, half Prime clones. The muscular Styrax, cyborg Dylamug with his face in his chest, and the stone-skinned Callix stood in front of a cell. Angella shuddered at the sight of it, but Catra only caught quick glimpses of two figures, one tall and blue, the other short and pink. *Flutterina,* Catra realized, suppressing her own shiver, *and the queen's friend Peekablue, probably.*

The biggest problems, aside from Vultak himself, were those around him. A muscular member of Double Trouble's species was to one side, wearing purple Horde armor and armed with a mini-flamethrower, while a stunning winged woman with clawed feet was on the other, horns like a crown peeking through her hair. She leered a smirk at Angella. *What was that saying Sparkles said to her dad about Light Spinner? Something about beauty only being a surface thing.* Meanwhile, on different screens, there were two guys in white Galactic Horde outfits, one a massive green amphibian with webbing between his fingers, the other a much

thinner crimson figure with four legs, enormous ears, and eyes literally extending out of their sockets.

Vultak smirked without turning. "Ah, Commander Catra, so good of you to join us." He gestured to the screens. "You won't have met Leech or Mantenna, of Prime's Beloved. With me are False Face and Princess Hunga." The winged lady turned a more friendly (if still sickening) smile on Catra before turning her attention back to Angella.

"Vultak. Styrax." Catra nodded to them, then gave Angella's tether as gentle a tug as she dared while trying to look uncaring. Then she froze, unable to hold back a chuckle. "Wait, 'Beloved,' like with a capital letter? That's a Horde title?"

Vultak's smile vanished. "Being one of Horde Prime's Beloved is the *highest* rank, and honor." Catra's smile followed Vultak's, her tail lashing. "Aid us in restoring His glory, and we can welcome you once more."

True believer, Catra realized. *Oboy.* She swallowed, not bothering to hide her nerves. "Right," she muttered. "So what's the plan? We have like two hours before Adora shows up with every princess on Etheria."

"Monster!" Flutterina sobbed. Catra was proud that only one ear twitched, given that she felt gutted.

Vultak smirked again. "The great strategist Catra has no plan?" he asked.

"One: you don't trust me. Two: you knew I was coming. Three: you know the forces on-site. My plan A involves orbital bombardment, but you haven't done that, so we can't," Catra ticked off, meeting Vultak's eyes with her most piercing glare. "Besides, you've got the monsters, but they're still in their cages, so you've got something up your sleeve."

The others stared. Mantenna's jaw dropped a fraction. Vultak laughed. "You don't disappoint, Commander." With a flourish, he

yanked a cloth off a platform, revealing...a bowl? "I'll take Angella. Place your hands on the bowl, and become a goddess to rival She-Ra."

Catra snorted. "Right," she snarked, tugging Angella behind her as she approached the platform. "Tell you what. I'll 'become a goddess' first, *then* you get Angella." She looked into the bowl to find it filled with liquid darkness. "What the f–"

White eyeslits formed in the darkness – and then olive green circles with lines in them, one an inverted V, the other an L with a point at the corner–

–*broken eyes.* "WHAT THE F–" Catra gasped. "Shadow Weaver?!" She flared her claws three times.

"I just need a little more time!" Entrapta reported in Catra's ear. Bow whimpered; fortunately, the Horde didn't notice.

Too shaken to be relieved Entrapta had recognized the signal, Catra whirled on Vultak. "Explain. NOW!"

"As soon as you give me Angella," Vultak sneered, holding out one hand. The other heavy hitters moved in, circling. *Just gotta stall, that's the plan,* Catra reminded herself, glaring back. "When I have her, you gain everything you desire."

I already have everything I want, Catra rumbled, letting the growl form in her throat, *and way more than I deserve.* Instead, she held up the end of the leash. The gasps of the Horde goons at the sight of the button on the handle made Catra feel slightly less of a monster. She held her thumb over the button. "Yep. Quick release. One push, and you're fighting an immortal angel queen."

"She can't take all of us!" Hunga screeched.

Catra gritted her teeth at the awful voice. "She held off the Horde's best army – mine – by herself. So yeah, she can."

"Catra?" Shadow Weaver gasped, a sound like rustling branches.

Vultak's eyes narrowed. "You have all nine of your lives," he admitted, glancing at Leech, then back. "You give us one, and we bring back Shadow Weaver."

"You mustn't, Catriska!" Peekablue cried.

"Silence, princeling!" Vultak snapped, making a fist snarled in shadow. Peekablue whimpered and fell back, Flutterina gasping and standing between Vultak and Peekablue, arms outstretched.

The *déjà vu* from Catra's childhood almost overwhelmed her, until another struck her – a memory shaken loose: *"You could have had everything. All you had to do was swallow your pride and give Adora a chance."*

Catra almost unraveled on the spot. *She – she called me Void-Catra – no! Not now.* Peekablue's sobs brought Catra back to her reality. *He's hurting – and misgendering, apparently – his prisoners. Do the job.* She turned her attenton back to Vultak. "Now tell me the rest," she demanded, wiggling her thumb over the button.

"Resurrection magic is the most dangerous in the universe, more than even time travel, because Death herself stands against it," Vultak ground out, the circle of Horde heavies closing around them. "Yet Prime is eternal, and Shadow Weaver is bound to the...shadow He left behind."

Angella gasped. "The Spell of Obtainment," she whispered. "The Shakarran Horror–"

Vultak's sneer returned. "Indeed. Only the gift of a magicat can safely bridge Life and Death," he explained, "and young Catra, with eight to spare, need only donate two. One to restore Shadow Weaver as a lifeline, and the other, to cast out all other shadows."

Unable to resist, even given the stakes, Catra strode to the bowl and met the eyes within. She let her pain and madness off its leash, laughing her grief free. "My care-taker," she mocked, glaring. "You took care from me."

“I know,” Shadow Weaver rasped back, her voice still only half-real.

Catra froze. “What?” she breathed.

“I...saw the truth too late,” Shadow Weaver admitted. “I could have had daughters, but only sought weapons.”

Angella glared at the eyes while Catra shuddered. “This is a trick,” she snapped, the claws of her free hand flaring. “You’re trying to use me again, get me to lower my guard so you can....” She reached for where a tuft had been.

“The spell requires a living body,” Shadow Weaver explained. Vultak’s eyes bulged while Hunga hissed. “A Bubastis can provide a lifeline, but Death demands balance from magic.”

“Why…would you tell me that?” Catra whispered.

“So you will believe me when I tell you...I am sorry, my child.” The eyes looked away at last. “I am so very sorry.”

“She’s telling the truth,” Peekablue groaned.

“Why were you proud of me?” Catra begged.

“Because I tried to turn you into me,” Shadow Weaver explained, “but you transcended your suffering where I surrendered. I hurt you, because of your mother, because you were like me, because you were *better* than me, because you equaled Adora when I myself could never match the gifted.” Oily tears formed in the liquid. “I hated myself, and hurt you for it, and you refused to be ruined.”

“You were a monster,” Angella snapped.

Shadow Weaver laughed, bitter and empty. “An insult to monsters, Angella.” The queen stared, gaping.

"Use my body," Catra said. Everyone, even the Horde commanders, froze. "We'll – we'll figure something out, magic, tech, *anything–"*

"FOR THE HONOR OF GRAYSKULL!" Adora cried, her desperation and power roaring through Menagerie Tower.

Cursing, Catra crushed the button, freeing Angella. Angella flew at Vultak with a cry so fierce, Catra thought the scream alone would knock him out. Hunga whirled to help, but the others decloaked, and Micah hit her with his triple-ring blast. Glimmer dove into the clone platoon with fierce glee, while Bow caught Styrax in a net arrow. Hordak emerged in front of the Etherian Horde soldiers, halting them with a glare. False Face aimed his flamethrower at Catra, but Double Trouble leaped at him, the two shapeshifters becoming a blur of living arsenals.

No time to be impressed. Melog leaped to Catra's side, and together they charged Dylamug and Callix, bowl in one arm and a stun baton in her free hand. "Entrapta tell me you've got it!" she blurted.

Lights flickered around them, and Entrapta cackled with joy. "I think that's a yes?" Scorpia reported, and howls echoed from shattering cages.

"Great!" Catra dodged a blow from Dylamug, sticking her stolen baton in one shoulder, then slicing through the other with her claws. Melog knocked Callix aside with a bull rush at maximum size. "Slag it, Adora, this was not the plan!"

"Neither was giving yourself to *SHADOW WEAVER!"* Adora wailed, her golden light tearing through the menagerie ceiling. Every flying beast soared free, except the silver dragon. That creature latched onto the massive window, staring at Melog.

Melog's eyes and mane glowed the same silver. *"Her name is Silver Storm,"* they explained. *"She has taught me some of her*

power in thanks, and hopes we meet again." Melog grew silver wings from their mane.

Leech teleported into the room with more clones. "Hordak!" he roared, snarling with fangs Catra envied. "Traitor!" Hordak replied by forming his cannon around one hand and firing. Leech held up a hand, absorbing the beam. Hordak scowled.

No time, Catra decided, using Melog max-size-headbutt move to throw Dylamug aside, then freed Peekablue and Flutterina with a massive claw swipe. "Sweet Bee! You're on!"

Peekablue's eyes went wide. "Bee?" she whispered. Then a woman seeming made of golden armor, with bronze talons and crimson eyes, smashed through the wall. Her wings seemed more wasp-like as she swooped over and scooped up Peekablue, carrying the sobbing princess away.

Flutterina's smile was as wide as Adora's. "You tricked them! Peekie was right!"

Catra shrunk back to her normal size. "Yeah. Sorry, kid, I swear I didn't know..." One ear twitched. Leech drew a beam cannon and aimed at Flutterina. Catra grew to full size again, covering the girl with her body just in time to absorb the blow.

Ow.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

"Catra! *"Catra!"* Adora charged through clones and bots, grateful that the Etherian Horde soldiers just scattered at the sight of her. Felicia and Percival leaped in behind her, watching her back with familiar grace that made her heart ache.

The Leech guy turned from Melog's prone form, about a dozen Andreenids fallen around them. His hands glowed like Melog's mane in crimson. "The She-Ra," he growled. "I was made to defeat you."

“You’re months too late,” Adora snapped, charging. Leech darted in, grabbing her shoulder and abdomen. She-Ra knocked him aside, but golden light joined the red around his hands, and hints of weakness threaded through Adora’s might.

“Your magicat is dead,” Leech hissed. “Even she will not come back from a lost heart.” Felicia screamed and prepared to leap, while Adora’s heart stopped–

Catra screamed.

Most of the remaining combatants froze as the wound through Catra’s chest un-collapsed, the damage rewinding like reversed film. A miniature Shadow Weaver made of darkness formed in the bowl. “Catra!” Flutterina cried, hugging the again-breathing love of Adora’s life.

“Ow,” Catra grunted. “Sparkles! Kid evac!” Glimmer teleported over, grabbing Flutterina’s shoulder and disappearing with her. “Seriously, *ow.”* Then she turned a terrifying smile on Leech. “Well look at that. One life. One body. Perfect.”

“Catra, no,” Shadow Weaver insisted.

Catra bristled. Adora tensed. “I...don’t...” Catra swallowed. “...want you to leave.” Leech’s eyes flickered from magicat to bowl.

“The end of everything could not sever the bond you two share,” Shadow Weaver sighed, “but sometimes, you truly must let go. I am dead, Catra.” The darkness thinned, becoming gray mist. “Bury me.”

Catra knelt before the bowl. Leech roared and charged. She-Ra formed a hammer from the Swordlight and knocked him into a wall. Leech teleported away. “Thank you,” Catra whispered. Then, with a fierce cry, she shattered the artifact.

Shadow Weaver was gone. For good, this time.

Melog stirred and stood, nuzzling against Catra. Adora held her love while she silently wept.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

"It's official!" Scorpia insisted, hugging Double Trouble. "We're the Super Pal Quartet!"

Catra smiled at DT's long-suffering eyeroll, then watched in amazement while Hordak and Angella – *together* – herded the captured Horde forces onto Darla. "This is not the end!" Vultak howled, struggling in Micah's sorcerous grip. "Prime sees all! Prime knows all! You have chosen shadow, and Prime casts out all–"

Calm, noble King Micah zapped Vultak with his staff. "Oops," he said, smiling innocently as the buzzard collapsed into bee soldiers' arms.

Adora nudged Catra with her shoulder. "Hey," Adora said, offering her a smile. "You okay?"

"Yes. No. I don't know." Catra shrank in on herself. Percival rubbed her back, eliciting a faint purr. "She was sorry, Adora."

"You tried to save her," Micah replied, leaning on his staff. "More than once. Light Spinner did this to herself."

"I...did terrible things too," Catra whispered. "Why me and not her?"

"Because she erased your memory," Felicia retorted, "and tried to make her like you, and you *actually changed* anyway?"

Angella took Micah's hand. "After all Shadow Weaver did to you, Catra, you gave her peace," she said, smiling at them. Catra's tail lashed. "You have earned your own."

Catra looked away. "Have I?" she asked.

Angella stepped aside, drawing Micah with her and gesturing to the field around them. “You tell me,” the queen said. Netossa and Spinnerella were hugging Peekablue and Sweet Bee, the four chattering with excitement. Flutterina spoke with Glimmer at warp speed, their smiles shining like Etheria’s new sun. All around them, prisoners sentient and bestial reveled in their freedom, cheering, weeping, and dancing both on foot and in the sky. “This was the last blot of Horde oppression on Etheria. Many helped, but you stood at the heart of this pain and gave everything – even life – to heal it, and us.”

Adora scowled. “That reminds me.” She put her hand on Catra’s chest and glowed. Catra gasped as her ninth life returned to her. “Never do that again!”

Catra held her uncle and her love, purring. “No promises,” she quipped anyway. Adora sighed. “Adora...thank you. For being there.”

“Hey, does this mean we can have our Best Friend Squad Space Adventure?” Bow asked, bubbling over with...Bow-ness.

“Once her adoption is complete,” Felicia grumbled, arms crossed.

“And they foster her to Brightmoon!” Glimmer added, laughing. “Right, *Princess* Catra?” Catra groaned. *Seriously. These people.*

“And I have the perfect place to start!” Entrapta cheered, rushing over (and hugging Hordak with one pigtail) and calling up a hologram of several worlds orbiting a star like the moons around Etheria. “This is our solar system.” She pointed at one planet with her free pigtail. “This is Etheria. And this planet,” she continued, pointing at the next planet in, “is called *Eternia!”*

There was only one thing to say, so everyone said it: “WHAT?”

Chapter End Notes

1) Yep, this Catra is Void-Catra. That's why I took "Canon-Compliant" off the tags forever ago.

2) I imagine the Beloved as Horde Prime's Black Order. Seriously, he must have had *some* governors that weren't him.

3) Funny story -- one version of Horde Prime is basically Lucifer, torn in half after his rebellion against heaven. Only his spirit remains free, hence the whole body-hopping schtick. And, well, the Spell of Obtainment monster was just *right there*...

4) Double Trouble can cry on cue now. ;-)

5) Eternia will probably be the last stop for this fic, except maybe for an epilogue if I ever get TR Catra to a point where she can meet this Catra again.

Better Angels, the Movie: Revelations In Eternity

Chapter Summary

> The movie-length crossover event of the day! Can the Best Friends Squad survive the Revelation of Eternia?

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"You sure about this, Scorp?" Catra asked, running her final systems check. It felt...good, somehow, to be in the pilot's seat.

Scorpia nodded, beaming. "Don't worry, Wildcat," she replied. "I talked with Perfuma about this, like, a lot, and as long as I come home safe, she's okay with it." The titanic princess beamed, making heart-eyes. "And you gave me a nickname!" she gushed.

Catra focused on the control panel to hide her blush, tail lashing. "N-not like I put a lot of work into it…" she glanced at Scorpia out of the corner of her eye. "But this is just to Eternia?"

Scorpia shrugged. "Well, you guys are going to be gone a lot. And..."

Catra smiled. "And Perfuma."

"And Perfuma," Scorpia agreed, smiling again. "I don't wanna say 'one last Super Pal Trio' adventure, but it kinda feels like it, y'know?"

Catra huffed, curling up on herself. "We really only had the one," she muttered, "and it's when I turned the woman I love into a screaming monster against her will."

Scorpia crouched beside Catra, putting an arm around her shoulders. "Then let's make this a better one," she suggested.

Catra's responding smile was shy. "Yeah," she agreed. "I'm actually kinda looking forward to being real friends with DT, but...I'm glad this one's with you. I just wish we could take the whole team."

Entrapta burst in through a vent. Scorpia jumped while Catra chuckled. "I'm working on increasing Darla's weight capacity, but given the supplies needed per person, I thought it best to keep the group down to eight."

Glimmer strode in. "Besides, we don't want Adora's people to think we're an invasion. Between us, we can handle anything Eternia throws at us."

Adora, Bow, and Melog strode in, Adora taking the captain's chair as if born to it. Catra found herself surprised by how tiny the sliver of jealousy was. *And Adora wants me to be captain for our next trip – some place called "Thundera," apparently,* she mused. "Status?" Adora asked, Bow dropping into the chair beside Catra.

"All systems nominal," Hordak reported over comms. Entrapta squeed and leaped back into the vent. "Ready for launch."

"Once Entrapta's out of the vents," Catra quipped, earning a few laughs.

With the sound of Entrapta's arrival (in a surprised Hordak's arms, apparently), Adora nodded. "Go."

Catra took them up while Bow read out environmental conditions and trajectory arcs. "Wow, Wildcat, when did you learn to fly Darla?" Scorpia asked.

"Eh, I spent time studying the systems while we were planning to take down Vultak," Catra explained.

Bow chuckled. "Plus, her reflexes are amazing."

"One might even say–" Glimmer added.

"Sparkles don't you dare–" Catra blurted.

"–*catlike."* Glimmer's smirk was ridiculously smug. "Princess Catra."

"I know where you live," Catra warned.

Bow sighed. "I'm a little better with the cannons, but Catra has a gift for this. The simulators rated her equal to a First One with years of experience."

"Good!" Adora didn't quite shout, turning all eyes towards her. She cleared her throat. "Um, good. Catra, you have the conn." Adora stood.

And there go her nerves, Catra thought as she headed out. "Um, Adora," Bow offered, "do you want us to hyperjump over? It'd only take a few–"

"No! No, too risky," Adora insisted. "Besides, we'll be there in a few short hours! Heh. Y'know...really short. Hours." She rushed out the door.

Catra groaned. "Bow, take over?" He smiled and nodded. "Glimmer, you've got the hot seat."

Glimmer took the captain's chair with obvious reluctance, while Scorpia petted Melog. "Is she okay, Wildcat?" Sparkles asked.

"Probably. Knowing Adora, it's just nerves," Catra insisted. "I'll talk to her." She trailed after Adora's scent, leading to...the heavy bag. *Of course. Punching out her feelings,* Catra thought, grinning. "Hey, Adora."

Adora almost fell over, catching herself on the bag. "Catra!" she yelped, regaining her footing, more or less. "Shouldn't you be, y'know," she continued, making a 'flying' motion with one hand, "driving the ship?"

"If anyone's stupid enough to attack *us,* Bow can handle it until I get back," Catra replied. "Adora, I get it. Halfmoon scared two lives out of me."

The savior of the universe sat with a thump, biting her lip. "I, just, what if they're all jerks? Or they're the evil empire now that Prime is gone? Or they're not evil, but just, 'yeah, whatever' about us. I mean, I'm so happy that you have a family now..."

"Hey," Catra cut in, kneeling in front of Adora and taking her head in the magicat's hands. "I've had a family since you saved me from Prime. *You've* had a family since you got to Brightmoon."

Adora threw her arms around Catra. "I'm scared, Catra."

"I know," Catra whispered. "It's okay."

"All this time, I wanted to know where I'm from, but now…" Adora shuddered.

"Adora," Catra insisted, forcing herself to purr. Nothing calmed Adora more reliably, and it worked its magic once more. "No matter what, we're gonna be okay. All right?" Adora nodded. "Good." Catra let go and stood, offering Adora a hand up. Then she smirked. "So, you want something a little more challenging than a pounding sand?"

Adora lit up. "*Stars,* yes," she admitted.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Adora fidgeted in the captain's chair as Eternia grew on the scanner. *Stars,* it was beautiful from a distance. It had fewer moons, but two exquisite rings, and a healthy-looking mix of blue seas, green lands, white clouds, and golden lights.

"Report," Adora ordered. *Stay on mission, nice and simple.*

"Um, looks like two primary civilizations," Bow said, going over scanner data, "one hemisphere that always had respect for the

ecosystem, and the other just relearning it. Lots of tech on both sides, but only a few sites with First Ones crystals."

"The northern continent has lots of different tech!" Entrapta reported. "Several different societies, probably."

"It also appears that the blighted region once hosted a Fright Zone," Hordak added, "but one long since abandoned."

"Wow," Glimmer whispered. "Even the Horde couldn't handle this place."

Hordak grunted. "Prime was able to drive back the empire, but Eternia remained invincible, even divided."

Adora sat up straighter. "Divided?"

"Some time between Etheria's disappearance and my creation, the people of Eternia became divided on their imperial ambitions. One faction sought to reclaim the glories of the past, and the other attempted a society more like that of modern Etheria, multicultural and accepting," Hordak explained. "This is the world Prime exiled me to, though I learned little of the war between Eternos and Point Dread before one of the latter's sorcerers cast me into Despondos."

"And this is only coming up now because…" Catra grumbled.

"Because that is all the information I have," Hordak explained. "I was unable even to assess their military capabilities, let alone their civilizations, before my exile."

"It's okay, Catra," Adora assured her, though nothing felt okay.

Catra sighed – then straightened in her chair, tail sticking out. "We've got incoming!" she barked, already taking evasive action.

"There's a dozen – no, two – three dozen drones, incoming!" Bow gasped, charging the weapons.

“They look like green hawk heads with orange fins,” Catra muttered. “Like Bow said, drones, no people.”

“Glimmer, try to contact whoever sent them,” Adora ordered, fingers tight on the chair’s arms. “Bow don’t fire unless fired upon–”

Blasts rocked Darla. “Pretty sure that qualifies!” Catra snarled, spinning Darla in a display of aerobatics that almost left Adora’s jaw slack. Bow returned fire, bringing down drones with his usual amazing skill.

“This is Princess Glimmer of Etheria! Please, we come in peace!” she pleaded into the comms.

“Then leave!” a man’s voice roared. “Our equipment has detected the stink of magic on your relic of a spaceship. Unless you intend to embrace the light of Motherboard, Eternia has had enough of sorcery!”

“That doesn’t make sense,” Entrapta interrupted. “The First Ones used science to understand magic.”

“And blighted the universe!” the man bellowed. “They grew proud and cruel, then called down the wrath of Horde Prime. Now Eternia is dying.”

“What?” Adora gasped. “No, please, we’re here to help, my name is Adora, I’m from Eternia, we can help with your magic!”

“The only salvation is in the machine,” the guy continued, “in Robotics, Automation, and the Holy Sprocket.”

Glimmer’s console beeped. “Aaand he’s gone.”

“The crazy Motherboard guy? I’m crushed,” Catra quipped, arcing back up. “So, Entrapta, where’d his signal come from?”

“The same region as the abandoned Fright Zone,” Entrapta explained.

"Scanners call it 'Snake Mountain,'" Bow added.

Hordak shuddered. "A far more prosaic and disarming name than 'Point Dread,'" he said.

"Well. That makes one thing easy," Adora decided, standing. "Head for the area that's not called Point Dread, where they *aren't* trying to kill us."

Catra's laugh made Adora's heart do flip-flops. "Good thing we've got you for these tough, complicated decisions," she quipped.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Catra was really glad she was used to big, sprawling palaces by this point. It was even tasteful compared to places like Brightmoon or the Snow Kingdom. *Not as awesome as Halfmoon, but what could be?* she thought, eyeing the white pillars topped with purple roofs as they landed in the main courtyard. They were met by a woman with feather-covered arms, an Andreenid bee-warrior, a cyborg wind guy in yellow and blue armor, and a cyborg reptilian – no, his face *spun* in his helmet, and he turned into a human.*Okay then.*

Adora fidgeted at the ramp, fingers clenching and opening. If she'd had a tail, it would have been lashing. The moment the ramp hit the ground, the spinning-head-guy stepped forward. "Greetings. I am Perkaedo, acting Man-at-Arms of Eternos. Please identify yourselves."

"You're being awfully polite, Man-E, considering they showed up in an Imperial warship," the Andreenid muttered.

"Excuse you," Catra hissed, while the feathers-lady facepalmed. "We salvaged it." She glanced at a squee-ing Entrapta as she scrambled up, eyes sparkling at the sight of the cyborgs. "Well, mostly Entrapta." The geek princess waved using a pigtail.

"I'm Adora," the blonde blurted. "I...think I'm from Eternia." The others trailed behind them as Adora went halfway down the ramp,

stopping as several guards in orange and green armor strode forwards, blasters at the ready. "We're from Etheria. Well, we *came* from Etheria – this is Catra, um, Princess Catra, that's complicated," she muttered.

Catra grabbed her hand. "Adora," she whispered. "Easy. Maybe you should let Sparkles handle it from here."

Whatever issues Catra ever had with Glimmer, she'd never doubt her ability to pick up on a cue. "My apologies," Sparkles said, "this is our initial first contact effort, and my friend is nervous. I am Glimmer, Princess of Brightmoon. The royal family of Halfmoon recently adopted Catra, making her princess of the magicats."

"The magicats live?" the wind guy blurted. Catra relaxed a fraction; he sounded relieved.

"The Horde did their best to finish us off, but yeah, we're still kicking," Catra explained.

"These are the rest of our companions, Bow, my betrothed and tech-master of Brightmoon," Glimmer continued as Bow bowed, "Princess Scorpia and Princess Entrapta. Lord Hordak, formerly of the Horde, is now co-engineer with Entrapta, maintaining the engines with Catra's companion Melog."

"And that is your entire crew?" a guy whose whole vibe screamed 'king' asked, striding forward. His eyes were narrowed, and his body had the stiffness of suspicion all through it.

Adora took a tentative step forward. "It is, sir? Um..."

The four elites moved closer to the crown-guy. "I am Randor Grayskull, King of Eternia," he explained.

Glimmer bowed, the others following suit. "Your Majesty," Sparkles said. "Please allow us to open formal relations with your world." They straightened. "A man claiming to serve, or worship, a Motherboard, attacked us on our approach. He seems to be opposed to magic, was he with the Horde?"

Randor folded his arms, then stroked his chin. “Tri-Klops? No, he was an agent of Snake Mountain, but now rules its hollow remnant in his mad crusade.”

Catra chuckled. “Okay, I’m sorry, but ‘Tri-Klops?’ My name is *Catra,* and even I think that’s ridiculous.” Randor chuckled back for an instant before composing himself. Adora almost smiled.

Then a woman whose scent reminded Catra of Adora’s walked up from behind the king. “Oh, it gets worse, dear,” she said, her own crown simpler than the king’s. Randor went still, his good humor dying on the spot. “His real name is Trydor Esooniux. He *chose* Tri-Klops.”

Catra cackled outright at that, and Adora’s laughter made her purr. “Marlena, I don’t think this is the time,” Randor said, tone frosty enough for Snow Kingdom. That killed the mood on the spot.

“Um...Marlena?” Adora asked, all nerves again.

“Queen Marlena,” she explained, “for the moment, at least.” The king and queen pointedly did not look at each other.

“Okay,” Glimmer jumped in. “Why don’t we all go inside, and you can tell us what’s going on with the magic here. Since Adora and Catra–”

Marlena transformed on the spot, going from confident-if-withdrawn to wide-eyed, looking fragile enough that a breeze could shatter her. “Adora?” she breathed, staring at...well, Adora.

Adora chuckled nervously. “Yep! That’s me. Adora, apparently from Eternia, kidnapped by ‘Light Hope’ to be She-Ra. Princess of Power.”

Randor’s eyes narrowed again, and he put a hand on the queen’s shoulder. “Marlena, after all that has happened, we cannot afford to assume–”

"Look at her *eyes,* Randor," Marlena whispered, her own eyes as wide as the spell moons. "After what happened to Adam–"

Randor's jaw clenched. "Don't you dare," he hissed.

"Your Majesty?" bird-lady asked, sounding as confused as her pals looked.

Marlena flinched, and for a moment, Catra wanted to leap to her defense, but then...she began to sing. "Hush, little baby, don't you cry, mama's gonna sing you a lullaby. Hush, little baby, don't say a word, mama's gonna buy you a mocking-bird. And if that mocking-bird don't sing–"

Adora's eyes got wider with each word until she sang in time with Marlena, "Mama's gonna buy you a diamond ring." Both women gasped, Randor joining in a moment later.

"Randor," Marlena said, "there are only two children in a thousand galaxies who know that lullaby."

"I, I still want to run tests," Randor stammered. "And what's this about She-Ra?"

"Oh, that!" Adora blurted, holding up her hand and forming the Sword. "For the honor of Grayskull!" She turned into the Princess of Power, Catra forcing her tail still during the transformation.

The king and queen – Adora's parents? – didn't look happy. "I think we should continue this inside," Perkaedo-Man-at-Arms said. *No kidding, Faces,* Catra thought.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

It took over two hours to get through just the basics of each side's stories. Randor and Marlena – Adora's *parents* – were both horrified by her upbringing in the Horde, but Adora was still dealing with a different shock. *I had a brother,* she thought, looking at the echo of the Sword's hilt in her palm. *My brother Adam. He was boy She-Ra. And it killed him.* Adora felt Catra's

arm and tail wrapped around her as if her love could protect her if Catra just held on tightly enough.

"Horde Prime, dead at last," Delora said. She was the bird lady, 'the Stratos of Avion,' and to Adora's trained eye, the most formidable warrior in an impressive unit. "One blessing in this midst of this nightmare, at least."

"Your son was a true hero," Glimmer added, though she glanced at Adora. The sympathy in her eyes was as much wound as comfort, but Adora put on a brave face.

Marlena – Mom – nodded. "To the very end," she agreed, voice soft.

"I thought he'd become a wastrel," Randor growled, hand slapping the table. Even the wind guy, Sy-Klone, jumped a little. "I never stopped hectoring him, I didn't understand what had become of the responsible son we'd raised – if I'd known..."

Marlena sighed. "Randor, I love you with all my heart, but you can't keep a secret to save your life."

Catra's chuckle was weak, but Adora welcomed it all the same. "Runs in the family, huh?" she asked. Adora took in a breath to object–

"So it's my fault?" Randor barked, standing in even a magicat's eye-blink. "My fault that my best friend – my court wizard – my own *wife* – lied to me about my son's entire life?"

Marlena sighed. "I did not say that, Randor."

Glimmer and Bow looked at each other. Bow gave her an encouraging little wave, and Glimmer stood. "Your Majesties," she said, in full Royal Mode. "You have Brightmoon's deepest sympathies in this terrible time. If Adam was anything like Adora, it was a true blessing to have him in your lives." She took a breath. "Now, your world is in jeopardy because of the magical disruption."

Randor sighed, still leaning on the table. “Princess Glimmer, I am grateful that you wish to help, but what happened in Castle Grayskull – the Hall of Wisdom – is not something any ordinary spell can undo. The Sorceress has few equals in the entire universe, and she has been powerless to fix this.”

“Maybe if she had a little help?” Scorpia suggested.

“I was able to restore magic on Etheria,” Adora blurted, hoping she didn’t sound like an idiot as she stood, “well, we were,” she added, taking Catra’s hand. “If we go to the castle–”

“NO!” Randor boomed. Adora quivered for a moment, food shaking on the table. “No. That place is accursed. Ruined.” He glanced away. Marlena also stood, looking from husband to daughter.

“But I can–” she tried again.

“That place killed my son!” Randor erupted. Then his eyes softened, tears just starting to form at the edges. “I won’t let it take my daughter, too.”

Adora sighed, closed her eyes, took in a breath, then let it go. She composed herself – *I guess Shadow Weaver was good for something after all,* she admitted with bone-deep reluctance, and came to attention. “Sir. I’m grateful that you care, after...everything we’ve told you. I’m glad you believe us, accepted us, even welcomed us.”

Man-E-Faces spun his head to go robot. “Your story is improbable and does not portray you or your lover in the best light, yet has no discernible contradictions of note. It makes for an improbable lie, but a convincing truth.”

Adora blinked. “Um, thanks...I think?” she replied, then shook her head. “The point is, Eternia needs me. I have to go.”

Randor shuddered. “Young lady–” he began.

“Don’t bother,” Catra sighed. Randor glared at her. “Look, I get it. You have no *idea* how much I get it. When I wasn’t trying to beat Adora out of jealousy, I was trying to stop her from throwing herself into every buzzsaw Etheria put in her way. It won’t work.”

“With all due respect, Your Highness,” Randor replied, quiet and dangerous, “your story does not inspire me to trust you.”

Catra flinched. “Now just a minute,” Adora objected, most of the others joining in.

“Guys!” Catra barked, and they all stopped. “That’s fair, and you know it.” She sighed again, holding her forehead. “I don’t expect you to trust me. If you believe our story, then you know what she’s like. Shadow Weaver raised Adora to sacrifice herself for everyone else.”

Adora paled. “I’ll be careful, Catra” she insisted.

Catra looked at her, smile sad. “I know,” she replied, but it sounded so beaten, Adora’s heart felt torn in half. Then she turned back to Randor. “The best we can do is go with her and try to keep her from doing anything stupid.”

Marlena nodded. “Well then. I suppose I should change.”

“M-Marlena!” Randor blurted. “You can’t be serious!”

“You don’t want me here,” she whispered, “and our daughter needs me.”

Alarm shot through Adora. “Your Majesty – Mom – this isn’t–”

“Adora, I may seem old to you, but I carried that lullaby across a thousand galaxies,” Marlena explained, still headed towards a side door. “I’ll tell you about Earth on the way to Castle Grayskull. All you need to know for now is, I was an explorer before I was a queen, and I fought every evil on this planet making sure Randor survived to win the crown.”

Adora blinked. “Earth?” she asked. “Like, dirt and stuff?”

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Catra looked at the cemetery while Adora and her mom – the queen, because of *course* she was a literal princess – traded notes and suited up.

There were thousands of graves. All lost in the wars with the Horde and Point Dread. In the center, though, were the deceased “Heroic Warriors.” They had names like Ram-Man, Stratos, Fisto, Mekaneck, Sky High, and Moss Man. Some of them had real names, too – Ram-Man’s birth name was Krass, so points for a less-stupid warrior name – but they’d taken so much pride in their idiotic titles that they’d had them engraved on their headstones, each with a life-like statue atop it.

It would have been hilarious if it weren’t so heartbreaking.

In the center was a massive stone with two statues. One was a skinny kid just buff enough to be Adora’s brother, but he looked more like he was related to Kyle than her. That was Prince Adam. The other one was a massive slab of muscles in a harness and an honest-to-Hordak *loincloth.* They’d actually called him He-Man. Both statues had the same smile, so much like Adora’s, that stupid jock mix of humility and cockiness that she made work somehow.

No wonder he’d been as much of a dork as Adora.

“Hey, Wildcat,” Scorpia called, picking gently through the tombstones. “You okay?”

“Look at this place,” Catra replied, waving at the field. It was the size of the grasslands outside Brightmoon. “I thought we had it bad, but this…” she shook her head. “That Skeletor creep was a nightmare.”

Scorpia nodded, hugging herself. “Yeah. I mean, he sounds ridiculous, and my name is Scorpia, you know?” Catra’s chuckle

was humorless, but she nodded anyway. “Then you look around, and see...this.”

“And their world’s dying,” Catra pointed out, tail end flicking behind her.

Scorpia wilted, tail drooping. “Yeah. That too.”

“Pfft,” Catra scoffed, “Eternia’ll be fine. Adora’s going to save them.” She crossed her arms. “We just have to make sure she lives through it.” Scorpia nodded, still quiet. Catra looked her up and down, then carefully did not sigh. “You need a hug, big gal?” Scorpia’s eyes lit up, and she held out her arms.

Catra purred as they embraced. “Y’know, you are good at this,” she admitted.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

On the one hand, the woman in the white jumpsuit was almost unrecognizable as the queen they’d met earlier. On the other hand, Adora felt like she knew her mother for the first time.

Marlena had an expression of unstoppable determination as she piloted the odd craft, one Adora had practiced countless times in mirrors throughout the Fright Zone and Brightmoon alike. Her mom made it look effortless.

Adora knew it wasn’t. “Mom?” Marlena turned, beaming like the daymoon – or a “sun” – at being called that. “Do...you want to talk about it?”

Mom turned her attention back to the horizon. “I’m afraid there’s a lot of ‘it’ to talk about, dear,” she pointed out.

Adora managed to stop at a single snort of amusement. “Fair,” she admitted. “So. Um. You and dad. What happened?”

Marlena shuddered once. “Adam died. I figured out his secret. Randor didn’t.”

“Why didn’t you tell him?” Adora asked.

Marlena sighed. “Adora, I know Catra made several mistakes, but aside from the portal, she went out of her way to avoid loss of life. The pain in her never swallowed the good…” Mom gritted her teeth. “...that *vile* Shadow Weaver tried to beat out of her. And you.”

Adora nodded. “Well, yeah.”

“Keldor was evil before I reached Eternia, but after his magic turned him into Skeletor, he embraced evil,” Marlena explained, shaking her head. “Reveled in it. Randor loved your uncle, once. Now, he doesn’t even mourn him.”

Adora gripped the back of the chair she was supposed to be in. *I had...no. Control yourself, Adora. You’ve still got so much more than Catra found in Halfmoon.* She looked at her mom. “I still don’t understand what that has to do with Adam’s secret.”

“Horde Prime brainwashed the woman you love,” Marlena reminded her. Adora’s world spun for an instant, the horror of the memory overwhelming her before she put it back in its hole. “Imagine if he could have done that to anyone in Brightmoon. Or Shadow Weaver had been able to capture your friends any time she wanted, not just at the ball.”

Adora had gone pale, her mouth dry. “Oh,” she whispered. “Skeletor could have...”

“He went after the few He-Man was known to be attached to, and they were some of the greatest warriors Eternia has ever known,” Marlena continued. “If he’d known about us? Or his friends in the palace?” Mom deflated, blinking tears from her eyes. “How desperately he loved Teela?”

“That’s the lady who left, right?” Catra asked, striding forward. Adora turned, and a rush of very different feelings rushed through her. Catra had donned one of the white suits from Earth, its red and blue trim suiting the magicat. She’d torn the fronts and backs

off the boots so its soles protected hers, but she could still feel the ground.

She'd also cut a diamond-shaped opening in the...front, much like her previous outfit. Adora's mouth was no longer dry. "You are so not helping my concentration right now," Adora pointed out.

Catra laughed and leaped into the seat opposite Adora's from Marlena. "Buzz kill stuff comes from dad's side of the family, right?" the magicat asked her mom. Adora blushed.

Marlena's chuckle was sad. "Randor has his moments," she defended, checking her scanners. Darla was still close behind them. "You seem to have adjusted well to Eternia, Princess Catra."

"Holy Bast, *please* just call me Catra," Adora's love pleaded, sitting up straighter. "But yeah. Messed-up world where I can expect everything to try and kill me? It's the first time my life has felt normal since the war ended."

Adora groaned, falling into her chair and rubbing her face with both hands. "You are the worst," she said, looking at the ceiling. "If you want me to live, maybe don't get yourself killed!"

"Hey, I have nine lives," Catra retorted, "especially since you keep topping me off."

Marlena's brief bout of terror subsided. "You...it's true, then? Magicats can return from death?"

"I mean, it's possible to get around that if you know how," Catra replied, "but apparently mine's extra-strong because blah blah magicat Champion," she explained. (Sort of.) "But yeah, I've died...eleven times now? Twelve?"

Marlena's horrified expression warmed Adora's heart. "That's...terrible!"

Catra shrugged. "We did mention Shadow Weaver?" she pointed out.

Marlena's expression grew hard. "Well, things will change when you live here," she said, and to Adora it sounded like she was giving orders to the universe. "I won't have my daughter-in-law being endangered on a regular basis."

Adora smirked. It was Catra's turn to blush. "Um. We're not married."

"Yet," Adora replied, pointing at the golden wing pinned over Catra's heart.

"Ugggh," Catra grumbled. "I'm not the worst, *you* are."

Marlena laughed, and for the first time, Adora saw her free of grief and guilt. *I can't stay here forever, but...I think I want her to be my mom.*

Then a ruined castle of First Ones crystal appeared in the distance, and Marlena's joy vanished. "We're here," she explained. "Girls, welcome to the Hall of Wisdom, all that remains of Castle Grayskull...and the last hope for Eternia. If not the universe."

"Don't worry," Catra drawled. "Etheria can take up the universal magic slack. We only have to save Eternia's ten billion people. No biggie."

"You sure know how to cheer me up," Adora quipped.

"Hey, I've gotta earn my keep somehow," Catra quipped back.

For the first time since she met her parents, Adora thought things might be okay after all.

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After the ruined outside, Catra hadn't expected a place named 'Castle Grayskull' to be *beautiful.* There was a long flight of golden stairs, and even withered the remnants of hanging garden were breathtaking. The crystals were less creepy than the ones from Etherian First Ones sites, too.

The deathly ill old lady and her sad tiger kinda brought the mood down, though.

At least Melog was interest, padding up to the quivering cat and giving him a sniff. Then they started meowing at each other, talking a klick a minute about taking care of their–

"Hey!" Catra objected. "I'm not a human, Melog!"

"Oh," the tiger said, "you can understand them too?"

Several of the others yelped and jumped back. "Wha – that – are all the cats magic in space?" Glimmer babbled.

Catra laughed. "I am the only non-magical cat anywhere, Sparkles."

Glimmer huffed back. "Says the magical princess, *princess."*

Before Catra could riposte, Adora whistled. Loudly. That got grandma to stir, and tiger-boy sighed. "Sorry, Sorceress," he mumbled.

"It's all right, Kringer," the Sorceress replied, standing with bones Catra swore she could hear creak.

"Wait, someone named you 'Kringer?' And I thought Shadow Weaver was a bi–" Catra growled.

"It wasn't mean," Kringer insisted. "It's just...me." His back rippled in a feline shrug.

"Well if it helps," Scorpia added, also offended on the poor guy's behalf, "I think you're cute."

Kringer lit up. "Really?" he asked.

Entrapta's mad cackles of joy brought Catra's attention back to the problem at hand. "Entrapta, don't blow up the universe," Catra warned.

"Oh, I can't do that now," Entrapta explained, pointing at the weird unfolded metal thing next to grandma Sorceress. "Someone already breached the containment unit. The Sorceress lady is holding what's left."

Adora peered at the tiny spark in the old woman's hands. "That's all that's left of Eternia's magic?"

"I'm afraid so," the Sorceress admitted, "miss…?"

"Adora," Marlena announced, stepping forward. The Sorceress gasped while Queen Mom crossed her arms. "Now, perhaps you would like to tell me why the Elders saw fit to choose *both* of my children for this burden."

"Oh, Marlena…" the Sorceress swayed, and Catra leaped over to catch her. "I am sorry. The Light Hope protocols were the creation of Point Dread's Skeletors, far beyond my power to influence. If I were to hazard an opinion, I would imagine that Keldor turned the systems on Adora for the specific purpose of hurting you and Randor."

Adora blinked. "Is it weird that that's kind of comforting?"

Catra chuckled. "You're weird, Adora," she pointed out, "but that's why we like you." Adora gave her a flat glare. "If it helps, I get it," she continued. "It's probably kinda like me finding out I wasn't just dumped in a box? That there was...a choice, like someone did something to make it happen instead of the universe throwing random crap at us."

"Sorceress?" An older man's voice called down. "Is everything all right down there?"

"We're fine, Duncan," Marlena called back up.

'Duncan' gasped. "Your Majesty!" A guy in the orange-and-green armor of the soldiers, but way heavier and more advanced, rushed towards them. "What happened? Why are you here? Who

are…" he slowed, eyes locked onto Hordak. He didn't draw a weapon, but readied blasters in his bracer.

"There is no longer a Horde, warrior," Hordak explained.

Marlena beamed. "They're with Adora, Duncan."

Duncan's eyes blew wide. "...Adora?" he gasped, spotting her immediately.

Adora waved. "...Hi?"

Catra facepalmed. "Can we speed-run the exposition, please? Or better yet, do it after Adora does whatever crazy She-Ra thing Eternia needs her to do to fix the magic?"

Duncan looked at Marlena, more amazed than ever. Marlena turned her cool glare back on the Sorceress. "I believe the Sorceress was about to explain," Queen Mom said.

The Sorceress swayed again, and Catra steadied her. "Thank you, dear. The truth is, I am not certain, but again, if I must suggest a connection, I would imagine that the Elders' insights extend even into Despondos. While Adam was unquestionably worthy, I suspect they chose him because once Light Hope took Adora, she was the destined She-Ra."

Adora paled. Again *That can't be healthy.* "You mean it's my fault?" she gasped, and Glimmer slapped her forehead in time with Catra. "It's my fault Adam's–"

"It's Skeletor's fault, Adora!" Catra blurted. She blinked. "His name still sounds weird." She shook her head, tail lashing. "Not the point. Adora, you were a slagging *baby!* How is a baby responsible for anything? Even the Horde wasn't that messed up."

The Sorceress exhaled, deflating. "Indeed. Adora, I am so deeply sorry that I could not protect you, but from everything I can surmise, you have been an extraordinary She-Ra."

“Uh, duh,” Catra quipped, grinning.

“She saved the Rebellion,” Glimmer joined in.

“Adora saved everyone,” Bow agreed, his smile a silvermoon in the depths. Queen Mom all but glowed with pride.

“Even those of us who did not deserve it,” Hordak whispered. Catra flinched, grin vanishing.

“We were all Prime’s victims,” Adora insisted, standing straighter. “If I deserved a second chance, then so did you.” She looked at Catra and took her hand. “All of you.”

Catra looked into Adora’s eyes, feeling so loved she thought she might explode. “Adora,” Catra whispered.

“Come on. I can’t do this without you.” Adora nodded her head sideways at the Sorceress, Catra nodded back, and they walked to the old lady. Adora held her free hand over the tiny spark in the Sorceress’ hands. “For the honor...of *Grayskull.”*

Catra’s heart skipped a beat when First Ones script that looked like the slagging *Failsafe* appeared in front of her hand. Then she realized it was just the center of a longer piece of writing, with the single First Ones word Catra recognized in the middle.

Heart.

Power flowed through Adora and Catra, turning the minuscule spark in the Sorceress’ hands into a small daymoon. It surged through the earth, into the walls, life blossoming where it had withered moments before. Even Catra, who had been abused by sorcery every day of her life, could not help but watch in awe as dying futures became living hope all around them.

The Sorceress, meanwhile, grew younger as Adora poured limitless magic into her spark. Wispy white hair turned russet-red, while wrinkles smoothed away. Her heartbeat grew stronger, and even her scent lost the spiky must of age.

In a single stroke, the flow crashed to a halt. Something flung Adora back, and Catra was glad that she was holding onto her, both of them dragged several feet from the Sorceress. None of Adora's work was precisely undone, but Eternia was already bleeding Adora's efforts away, like a wound that could not heal. A single strand of gray hair remained to the Sorceress, the first hints of crow's feet at the edge of her eyes.

"I failed," Adora whispered, because of *course* she did.

"You bought us time, Princess Adora," Duncan replied, striding up with an aura of confidence Catra envied. "Time that will save countless Eternian lives."

Catra sniffed out the energy trickling from the weird unfolded metal thing in the center of the chamber. "The First Ones did something to the planet, Adora. Like the Heart of Etheria...no, like the opposite. They cut a hole in...magic?...like opening someone up for surgery, then patched it with this thing."

Duncan scowled. "And when Skeletor shattered the Orb, he reopened a wound that never healed."

The Sorceress shook her head, folding her arms. "No. The Elders would not have done such a thing," she insisted.

Catra hissed, but subsided at Adora's gentle touch. "I used to think that Shadow Weaver was teaching me to achieve my destiny, but all she did was use me, and hurt the people I loved most. The *person* I loved most. Then Light Hope did the same thing." She stepped forward, Catra leaping to stay beside her. "Are you sure about the Elders, ma'am?"

Catra's anger faded when the Sorceress looked stricken, turning to Duncan. "It couldn't hurt to ask, Sorceress," the big guy said.

"It better not," Catra grumbled. Adora stroked her back, never going against her fur.

The Sorceress sighed, then raised her hands, gathering the bleeding sorcery. "Elders! By the ancient ways, I beckon thee! By the ancient rites, I invoke thee! By the ancient pact, I *summon* thee! COME FORTH!"

Nine figures shrouded in silver-gray mist appeared around the chamber. Kringer cowered, hiding his head under his forepaws and whimpering. Melog leaped in front of the green tiger and hissed. "We know why you summoned us, Sorceress, but we cannot help you."

"Is it true?" the Sorceress asked. "Did Adam die for the sins of the past?"

"Your question has no simple answer," the Elders replied. It was a single voice, but faded slowly from man to woman, then to another man's. "In the first days, when we truly were the First Ones, our discord took the form of debates, never worse than acrimony. We built wonders, thinking ourselves masters of the universe. And in a way, we were. Only the Oans rivaled us, back when they were still called Maltusians."

The voices hesitated, and even through the haze, Catra could feel all their eyes on her, heads tilting towards her. "Then we discovered the Bubasti. The 'magicats' were a playful species, seeming chaotic and aimless, but with magic beyond even ours. Some of us thought them delightful and harmless. Even that was arrogant and short-sighted, so enamored with our power were we.

"Yet it was far from the worst to come. Our most aggressive faction, the Clan of Dread, refused to accept the might of the 'magicats,' unwilling to imagine a species whose wizardry surpassed our own. They invaded, only for their efforts to be shattered by the first She-Ra. Dread's leader, Karak Nul, created an undead mockery to delay the Bubasti, then retreated to this sacred place. Here, he tore a hole in the universe, claiming worse than chaos for himself."

Duncan gasped. “The Havoc Staff?” he whispered. Then his narrowed eyes hinted at thunderheads. “So that’s why it has the might to challenge the Sword of Power!”

“Nul surpassed all limits to become the first Skeletor. He tore potential from the Bubasti to turn chaos into Havoc, then opened the ‘wound’ you speak of. An equal horror was that he crafted a weapon to bind the power of the She-Ra and named it ‘Sword of Protection.’ Ashamed,” the Elders explained, “we sealed the wound, then separated the realms you call Preternia and Subternia to forge the Sword of Power. With our new Champion, a He-Ro to mirror the She-Ra, we defeated the Lord of Destruction, his fall casting him into Subternia for all time.” *That’s right, Felicia mentioned something about She-Ra being a magicat thing,* Catra remembered. Adora was horrified – again–

The Sorceress gasped. “But Teela is headed to Subternia now!” she cried, distracting Adora from the casual revelation. “They go to reforge the Sword!”

Duncan snarled a word Catra didn’t recognize, but made a note of for later use. “I was going to go back for her anyway,” he said. “Her party sails through the Crystal Sea, and Mer-Man will undoubtedly give them trouble.” He turned to the Sorceress as the Elders faded away. “Will you be all right?”

The Sorceress smiled and formed a ball of magic light. “Adora’s efforts have restored my strength, Duncan. Go.”

Catra moved to head out with the others...then slowed to a stop. “Ugggh,” she groaned, covering her face in both hands. “Adora...I’m staying here.”

Adora stopped and turned, jaw slack. “What?” she blurted.

“Look, that Tri-Klops guy is going to come after the magic lady sooner or later. Besides, Entrapta is...Entrapta,” Catra replied, pointing at the cackling genius using her hair to probe crystals two floors up. “Hordak’s not leaving her. So you take the,” she

rolled her eyes as hard as she could, "the 'Best Friends Squad' with your mom and the Duncan guy. I'll stay here with Scorpia." Melog 'mrrped' at her. She smiled, ears and tail drooping. "Sorry, Melog. I need you to go with Adora." He padded over to her, head pressed against her chest. "Look after her for me, okay?"

Glimmer smiled and turned to go, then stopped when the others looked at Adora and Catra. "I...but, Catra…" Adora swallowed.

Then Glimmer groaned. "Catra's right about one thing. *Ugggh,"* she complained. Catra blinked. "I'll stay." Catra glared, but Glimmer was unmoved. "Come on, Catra, Adora's going to need you. Besides, I'm a better sorceress than you."

Catra snorted. "Sparkles, that one I'm *so* happy to give you." She paused. "Are you sure?"

Glimmer nodded. "The Sorceress can teach me the magic she needs to help her protect this place, and you can make sure Adora doesn't lose She-Ra."

"You can lose She-Ra?" Marlena asked, striding forward.

"After I destroyed the Sword of Protection, Catra became my connection to her," Adora explained. "She's my strength, my hope, my...everything." Catra's fur went completely flat. *Slag it, Adora!* she cursed, purring beyond all control.

Glimmer sighed. "Exactly. Adora needs you, Catra, now more than ever. I'll stay here with Entrapta and Hordak. You take everyone else and go save the world. Or the universe, or whatever."

"Half," the Sorceress whispered, kneeling before the metal blossom in the middle of everything. "With the return of Etheria, Eternia's death would doom half the universe."

"And I'll try to perform repairs here," Entrapta agreed, dropping down near the mechanism.

Catra sniffed at it. "It's damaged?" she asked.

"Oh, the mechanism? No, and that's amazing!" Entrapta gushed. "It grounded enough magic to destroy entire galaxies, when the most powerful hero in the world blew up right over there!" She pointed at a burn mark on the ground with a pigtail, and Adora flinched. "It's the ether that's damaged. They scarred it, and before now I would have thought that was impossible, but–"

Catra said it with her. "–data never lies." She glanced between Scorpia and Melog, but the two looked at each other, and Melog strode over to Glimmer. "Melog?" Catra asked.

=Go with your mate,= Melog purred. =I will remain with your friends. The pretty tiger boy can translate for me.=

Kringer's jaw dropped. "P-p-pretty?!"

Scorpia nodded. "You be careful, Entrapta."

"Uh-huh," Entrapta muttered, pulling a drill, a buzzsaw, pliers, and a wrench out of her hair.

Catra couldn't help it. She laughed.

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"But no! You forgot all about Mer-Man," the self-styled 'Sea Liege' snarled. "Now, you'll never forget Mer-Man!"

Teela turned a flat look on the Aquatican sticking a spear in her face. *Gods, Lyn, is there one villain on Eternia you haven't pissed off?* she wondered.

Engines roared in the distance, approaching at speed. Three Wind Raiders zoomed towards them, each carrying two riders. One had a boy and a crazy-tall blonde, the second bore a Qadian and scorpion-woman of some kind, and the third carried–

–the queen – and *Dad?*

They engaged with the Aquaticans with incredible skill, even by Teela's high standards. Dad and the blonde landed on their ship, plowing through Mer-Man's soldiers like they were practice dummies. Teela grabbed Orko and ducked, not wanting to get in their way. Roboto covered them, while Andra rolled to Teela's side.

Mer-Man howled and thrust his arms into the air. A column of water carried the ship up, jets of foam lashing out at the three Raiders. They all dodged with grace to equal Queen Marlena's. The Qadian muttered something to herself, then shouted, "Scorp! Strafe 'em!" 'Scorp' blasted lightning into the column of water holding them up, knocking away almost all the amphibious soldiers, while Marlena and the boy stunned the rest.

When Teela stood, the blonde had Mer-Man under her boot. Her smirk reminded Teela of...she tucked the grief away for later. "So!" Blondie said. "What's with cut-rate Mermista here?"

The Qadian landed her Wind Raider on the back of the ship with barely a jostle. "Who cares? Let's get the stupid swords, save the world, and go home." She glared around, clearly trying not to display the classic Qadian fear of oceans. "This place gives me the creeps."

"But they destroyed one of our engines," Orko pointed out. "Even with the power that restored Eternia's magic–"

"Oh!" The blonde actually raised her hand like a schoolgirl. "That was me."

Andra gasped. Teela frowned. "Sure it was," she said, glaring.

Marlena stepped forward, her smile a mix of pride and pain. "Teela, I would like you to meet my daughter Adora, Princess of Power – the She-Ra."

Teela gaped, her own blend of grief and fury piercing her anew. *"What?"* she snapped. "More secrets, Queen Marlena?" The Qadian darted between Teela and Adora with speed even Teela had rarely seen, claws out and hissing.

"It's not what you think," her father cut in, hands raised. "Skeletor transmitted Adora's location to the old Light Hope systems, and she was kidnapped to Etheria as a baby. We all thought she was dead – not a secret, just a wound too painful to speak of."

"But I'm alive!" Adora blurted, waving a Sword of pure light before releasing its power. Mer-Man squirmed for a moment, but she literally brought him to heel. "I survived on Etheria, and it came back into the universe, and we defeated Horde Prime. And now we're here."

"We can give you the long version on the way to, uh, Subternia," the boy added, his smile bright and gentle.

Beast-Man knelt in front of Mer-Man, glaring. "We should filet the fish, milady," he growled.

Evil-Lyn chuckled. "I rather doubt such shining heroes would be willing."

The Qadian chuckled. "I would," she said, and Teela's estimation of her dropped, "but Adora's way too nice. As long as he behaves himself, we kinda have to let him go."

"Excuse you," Adora retorted, looking offended somehow, "who killed Horde Prime again?"

"Only because the literal *entire universe* was at stake," the Qadian shot back.

Teela whistled. That brought the conversation to a halt. She turned on her dad. "I told you to go to Grayskull!" she pointed out.

"And I told you that I love you," Duncan replied. They both smiled.

"That's all very touching," Evil-Lyn drawled, "but I believe we still have an unmoving ship.

The Qadian smirked, then concentrated. Darkness trickled, then poured out of her palms, reaching to the back of the ship and literally pushing them towards the entrance to Subternia. Adora – the She-Ra – then kicked Mer-Man into her hand like a fallen blade. "Go," the princess warned him, "and don't come back." She tossed him into the Crystal Sea, and he swam away so quickly it was as though he'd vanished. Roboto took the wheel again. "You okay, Catra?"

"Please," Catra scoffed. "I've had worse in basic training." Teela sighed, holding the bridge of her nose. *This just got a lot more complicated.*

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Catra watched as Teela stared at the newcomers, Bow wrapping up the exposition just as they reached the freaky crystal shores they were headed for. "That's...quite a story," Teela said, still not sounding quite convinced.

"I know, right?" Scorpia gushed. "I mean, I lived it, and it still sounds crazy to me sometimes!"

Teela glared at Catra the moment she let go of her shadow magic, the boat halting on the glittering sand. "And you trust the Qadian, Queen Marlena?"

"You're welcome," Catra hissed, claws flaring.

"The love she shares with Adora saved the entire universe," Marlena replied, smiling. "So, yes."

"Look, we all made mistakes," Bow pointed out.

"Yours didn't tear a hole in the universe, kid," Teela said, glancing from the Subternian gate, back to Bow. Catra's tail lashed.

"Catra has worked harder than anyone I know to make up for the things she's done," Bow replied. Scorpia put a hand on the Qadian's shoulder, tossing Teela a protective glare. Catra looked

away. “We need to trust each other if we’re going to get through this.”

Teela glanced at Evil-Lyn and Beast-Man, then back at the kid. “My trust is stretched thin right now, Bow...”

She trailed off when Catra’s ears flicked. She looked up, then turned, strange, spinning sounds echoed from the water’s surface. “Incoming,” Catra warned, claws flaring.

“Rotons,” Beast-Man warned, his own ears twitching. Scorpia looked at him in confusions. “Nothing sounded quite like an approaching Roton,” the big guy explained.

Nothing quite looked like a Roton either, apparently, black discs with glaring eyes and spinning crimson blades hovering in their approach. At the head was some kind of techno-pope, his green headband adorned with three eyes. One narrowed as they landed. Adora strode forward to meet them, Sword forming in her hand. “You,” the eyes-guy barked, pointing at She-Ra. “You carry the accursed magic!”

“Tri-Klops, you ridiculous fool,” Evil-Lyn snapped, light flaring around her staff. *This is the guy?* Catra wondered. In spite of his...everything, Trydor was somehow less ridiculous than she had expected. “If we don’t restore the magic, everything dies!”

“The flesh is weak!” Tri-Klops snarled back, his creepy robed troops growing tentacles from their sleeves. “Only the Motherboard and her children will survive the end!” The cyborg with the worst underbite in the universe giggled with a metallic echo.

“You’re just upset about the stupid goblet,” Teela smirked, drawing her mockery of a clawsword.

“The goblet was meaningless,” Tri-Klops said, glaring at her. “You killed a dozen of my acolytes to steal something I would have traded with you for!”

Teela's friend Andra looked horrified, but Teela just scoffed. Catra whirled on her, glaring. "And you were seriously giving *me* a hard time? You're just a thief and a murderer who abandoned her people!" she snapped.

"They lied to me!" Teela snapped back.

"'They,' like King Randor," Catra snarled, "who didn't know either?" Teela stared, paralyzed.

"Catra," Adora pleaded, putting a hand on her shoulder.

Catra sighed. "No," she said, shrugging out of Adora's hand. "Look at me, Tri-Klops. Really look at me, since that's the only part of you 'converted' to your Motherboard."

Tri-Klops flinched, eye darting away. "Motherboard has not calculated my readiness," he muttered.

"Oh." Catra shook her head, then straightened. "I know something about evil mothers, Tri-Klops. I doubt there's anyone alive on this planet more hurt by magic than me. Look at me."

His eyes spun again, and Tri-Klops glared. "You cannot keep secrets from me, you–" his eye lit up, and he froze. "Holy Sprocket," he gasped, recoiling. "What did they do to you?"

"Her name was Shadow Weaver," Catra said, taking another step forward. The entire techno-cult moved back with their high priest. "She hurt me, every day, just to remind me that she could." Adora had started crying again behind her. "Most days it was just a little zap, or a moment choking me, or a few seconds of paralysis." She held out her arms, and Tri-Klops's scan resumed. "When I did something she didn't like, or the Rebellion frustrated her, or she was just in a bad mood, Shadow Weaver got creative. Some of the punishments were normal stuff, like cutting off my rations or locking me up, but others...well. She'd lash me with lightning, break a toe with shadows, paralyze just my lungs so I could thrash around, trying to breathe."

“Oh...Wildcat…” Scorpia sobbed.

“Then why?” Tri-Klops demanded. “Why are you with *them?”*

“Because magic’s probably saved me more times than anyone on Eternia, too,” Catra explained. “That’s Adora. She brought me back from *death.* Scorpia here took control of the magic Shadow Weaver hurt me with, and makes sure no one else ever will. Two of my best friends are one of Etheria’s greatest sorceresses and our most brilliant engineer, who puts magic and science together.”

Tri-Klops shook his head. “I don’t believe you!” he yelped, staring in horror.

Terror rippled through Catra, but she shook it off and let it go. “Data never lies,” she said, stepping towards him and turning sideways. She pushed her half-regrown hair from the back of her neck, showing him where Horde Prime had implanted her. “I don’t know what you’ve done to your soldiers–”

“Acolytes,” Tri-Klops corrected.

“Whatever,” Catra huffed, rolling her eyes. “I’ve got an interface. Take a look at the data for yourself.”

“Catra, you can’t!” Adora gasped, taking a step forward.

“Adora, stay back!” Catra insisted. “Teela’s...not wrong about me,” she said, looking away. “I’ve done awful things. I have to make up for them. Besides, he was your mom’s friend once.”

Tri-Klops’ jaw dropped, and he looked from Adora to Marlena. “Skeletor took my little girl, Trydor,” Marlena said, voice cold. “Catra, any bond I had with this traitor is long dead.”

“Captain Glenn,” Trydor whispered. Then he straightened, taking out a sphere and opening it. Weird black goo bubbled inside. He poured some into his hand, and placed it on the back of Catra’s neck.

The cries of Catra's friends seemed walled away, Eternia swirling and warping around her. She saw a technical genius lost on an alien world, making friends with a monk while he looked for his crew. Keldor convinced him the monk had tricked him, and Trydor lost his eyes fighting alongside the cruel sorcerer. Tri-Klops built his headband and joined Point Dread, turned against his captain before he knew what had happened.

He only learned about Skeletor's treachery after the creep died.

"Gah!" Tri-Klops recoiled, holding his eye-thing.
"That...you...how..."

Catra watched with almost detached curiosity as the impossibly tiny machines merged with her magicat changing magic. "Huh." She turned her claws metal, then back to natural. "Cool." She looked at Marlena. "Skeletor tricked him, you know."

Marlena's eyes widened. "He – what?" She looked at her old friend turned enemy of decades. "Trydor?"

"It doesn't matter," Tri-Klops sighed, deflating. "None of it matters." He boarded his Roton again. "Go."

The big cyborg looked at Tri-Klops in disbelief. "Tri-Klops?"

"We will let them try, Trap Jaw," Tri-Klops ordered. The acolytes retreated. "You are a fool, Catriska D'riluth. A doomed...brave fool." He paused, hand on a control lever. "Captain Glenn. I...am sorry," he whispered, and Marlena's hands went to her mouth. "I was lost."

"Trydor," Marlena replied. "Please, go to Randor. It's not too late. We can save Eternia together."

Trydor shook his head. "I lost Earth, my crew, my dreams...even myself. Motherboard is all I have left." He pivoted the Roton to leave. "I have to take care of them. I have to do something right with my life for once."

Marlena pulled her coronet out of a pouch. “Take this to Randor,” she said, holding it out. “Tell him that it’s from me – for Sarah.”

Trydor stared in shock at the crown. Then he laughed. “Search and rescue and homing? An old NASA code, Marlena?” He took the offering. “I will do what I can, but few accept Motherboard’s blessing.”

“Eternos can always use more Heroic Warriors, Tri-Klops,” Orko insisted.

Trydor looked at the coronet, then the heroes. “I…” his smile was slight. “Maybe.”

The Rotons flew off. The Eternian heroes stared. Catra’s friends smiled, and Adora threw her arms around Catra. “You...you turned Tri-Klops,” Evil-Lyn whispered. *“Tri-Klops.”*

“He was lost,” Catra replied with a shrug. “I remember what that’s like. So.” She waved at the massive dark crystal. “How do we get in?”

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Teela listened to the Etherians with new respect, trying to salve the sting of Catra’s accusation as she led them into the depths of Subternia.

“You’re just a thief and a murderer who abandoned her people!”

Is that why I didn’t like Catra? Teela wondered. *Did her story hit too close to home?*

The biggest problem was Adam’s completely ridiculous sister gushing over her girlfriend. Fiancée. Whatever. “Could you at least tone it down, Blondie?” Teela pleaded. “It’s distracting, and we’re literally in Hell.”

Adora stopped at last. “*Thank* you–” she began, turning.

Everyone was gone. “Orko? Andra? Roboto?” she called.

The only response was a series of glowing lights leading her down.

She switched her multi-staff to sword mode and descended. *That isn’t a bad sign at all,* she thought, scowling.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

The flash of light faded, and Catra found herself with the little floaty guy and Shadow-Weaver-lite. They were on a balcony looking over some kind of magical paradise, with floating islands, weird trees, and green sky. Behind them, two birds landed, but the beating of their wings didn’t cause wind to register to her whiskers. “Oh, goody,” Catra huffed, then grinned at...Orko, right. “We’re stuck in an illusion with bucket-head instead of Adora.”

Orko giggled while ‘Evil-Lyn’ scoffed and looked away. “An illusion? But it looks so real! Maybe it really is Trolla?”

“Does Trolla smell like smoke and wet soil?” Catra asked, tapping her nose.

“Well, at least you’re useful,” Evil-Lyn muttered. Catra hissed. “We have other problems. Where are the others?”

“Mystic observation lens,” Orko chanted, “reveal where we may find our friends!” His managed to conjure an actual lens – which fried the two ‘birds’ to ash. Catra winced, giving the imp a sympathetic pat on the shoulder.

Evil-Lyn sighed. “Imbecile,” she muttered.

Catra darted in front of her, forming a Halfmoon clawsword and lineshield with her new tech. “If you run the little guy down one more time, Evil Weaver, I swear–”

“Please don’t fight!” Orko pleaded, darting between them with his arms outstretched. “Besides, this proves you right about the

illusion. My magic works the way it's supposed to on Trolla."

Evil-Lyn gave Orko a second glance. "True enough, I suppose," she admitted, heading into the fancy room off the balcony. It looked like a library with a moon-mobile over it, showing the world and its satellites. Under the mobile was some kind of strange altar or ritual device.

"Are you okay, Catra?" Orko asked.

Catra grinned. "I grew up in Hell. I'll be fine, and this place is no match for Adora." She looked around. "Anyway, where are we supposed to be?" she asked as they followed the witch.

"The Academy of Magic," Orko replied. "Maybe someone can help us in there, even if they're an illusion?"

Catra shrugged. "If I have a better idea, I'll let you know."

"Unlikely," Evil-Lyn commented, striding towards the altar-thing. It had four round tables arrayed around a spiral cone.

"I don't see you doing any better, Evil Weaver," Catra shot back, crossing her arms.

"I am not your mother, Qadian," Evil-Lyn finally snapped, glaring.

"Nah," Catra cackled. "She would've eaten you for lunch."

Evil-Lyn's eyes narrowed. "Even less likely."

"Oh, I meant that literally, Feeble-Lyn," Catra smirked. "She cast the Spell of Obtainment."

Evil-Lyn and Orko both recoiled. "And survived?" Lyn blurted.

Orko put his hands over...well, the place where his mouth probably was. "Is that was she did to you?" he gasped.

Catra shrugged. "Some of it." She waved at the altar-thing. "Any idea what this is, Impy?"

“Huh? Oh!” Orko marveled at the thing. “The Spellspring!”

“‘Spellspring?’” Lyn and Catra asked at the same time.

“An amazing font of mystical energy. The never-ending source of Trollan magic,” Orko explained. “But...it’s empty,” he whispered, floating closer. Orko peered above them looking for signs of life. “There’s no one here. We’re alone.”

“No,” Catra insisted. “Not as long as we stick together.”

Evil-Lyn scoffed again. “Unbelievable,” she said, turning a skeptical look on Catra, arms folded. “For all your fierce talk, you’re as much of an insipid do-gooder as your friends.”

Catra unsheathed her claws. “Keep pushing, Feeble-Lyn,” she hissed.

“No, she’s right,” Orko agreed. Catra turned a cool glare on him, and the imp waved his arms in denial. “I don’t mean the ‘insipid’ part, obviously, but you’re a hero, Catra.”

Catra looked away. “I’m a monster, Orko,” she admitted, hugging herself with one arm.

“I’ll bet Tri-Klops doesn’t think so,” the imp replied, earning a stunned look from Catra. “You did what dozens of heroes couldn’t since before you were born. You changed his mind.” He put a gentle hand on her shoulder, and Catra fought back tears. “That’s the greatest magic of all, Catra. The power of your heart.”

Catra hugged Orko on an embarrassing impulse. “I know zip about your sorcery,” she said, “but you’re one Hell of a magician, Impy.”

“That is all very touching,” Evil-Lyn drawled, “but real magic is dying, and not just on Eternia. But who is showing us this, and why?”

Catra bit back another hiss. “Okay. Maybe we *should* know something about Orko’s sorcery.” She looked at the amazed Trollan. “Why are you so good in your home dimension, but on Eternia...not so much?”

“Well, the magical frequencies are different,” Orko said. “Almost backwards, but not quite.” He shrugged. “Dree Elle – my girlfriend – says it might actually have something to do with how powerful I am at home.” He sighed, dropping to sit on the edge of the Spellspring. “You know, my name isn’t really Orko.”

Catra cocked her head, curiosity peaked. “It isn’t?” Evil-Lyn asked in spite of herself.

“My uncle sensed my magical potential, so my parents wanted to set me up for greatness. When I was born, they gave me a name they thought fit what I could become.” Orko touched his fingers together in embarrassment. “But when you’re little, some words are tough to pronounce. I said ‘Orko,’ but–”

“Oracle,” Evil-Lyn finished for him, looking sympathetic for the first time. “They named you Oracle.”

“And for a while, it suited me,” Orko sighed, deflating. “Then I got caught in a magical storm while I was looking for a flower I wanted to give to Dree Elle, and I ended up on Eternia.”

Catra sat beside him. “Why did you stay?” she asked.

He looked at her, and Catra could swear she sensed Orko smiling at her. “Why did you stay in the worst place on Etheria? I don’t love Adam the way you do Adora, but he was special. I could sense it.” He shrugged. “I saved him, half by accident, before the Sorceress made him He-Man, and in gratitude King Randor made me the Royal Buffoon.”

“Wait,” Evil-Lyn blurted, turning from her examination of the illusory books. “That was your actual court title?”

Orko drew himself up with pride. “I wasn’t very good with magic there, but I could still make people laugh.” He folded his arms. “And I helped thwart the mighty Skeletor plenty of times, didn’t I?” To Catra’s amazement, Evil-Lyn smiled.

“Even when you were small and insignificant, you fought for all the respect no one would give you,” Lyn realized. “Your enemies, true, but especially your friends.”

“Except Adam,” Catra said, looking at the imp with new respect.

Orko nodded. “Except Adam.”

“I suppose he was the only one who understood, then,” Lyn said, looking into the orb on her mini-staff. “How even the tiniest spark of determination can fill an entire universe, if you know how.” She walked over to the pair sitting at the Spellspring. “Your vile mockery of a mother called it sorcery, Catra, but to Orko – to me –”

She held up her staff, and Catra watched as a tiny blue light formed a beautiful bird, flying through the hall. It left shimmering light in its wake, falling around the spring as though it had come back to life. Lyn’s smile was honest, unguarded, for the first time since Catra met her. “...it’s magic.”

Orko turned to look at Lyn. “Can I ask you a, uh, personal question?” he asked.

“No, they didn’t call me ‘Evil,’ I added that part later,” Lyn said, as though it were a normal question.

They laughed, and Catra couldn’t help but join in.

Then creepy shadow-Trollans flowed into the room, filling the Spellspring until it formed a giant creature like a triple-sized Beast Man. Evil-Lyn smirked and fired a blast that knocked it into the far wall. Her smirk vanished when it tore loose of the debris, bellowing. “Okay, even for me, that’s new.” Catra tore at it with her shadow magic.

The monster screamed, thrashing in place. It melted and shifted, becoming less Beast-Man and more...magicat. Catra recoiled from a horror that was her made of darkness, twenty feet tall. “HEY, CATRA,” Void-Catra boomed.

“I think we should run,” Orko whispered.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

“Catra? Catra!” Adora cried, whirling around. They were back in Mom’s palace, except the place was empty. The long table where they’d eaten together was bare, and the chandeliers flickered with dim light.

“Easy, honey,” Marlena said, placing a hand on She-Ra’s arm. “She’ll be fine.”

“You don’t understand,” Adora sobbed. “I have to be there for her. Catra needs me.” She shuddered, losing her fight against tears. “I think She-Ra was supposed to be hers, after that thing with the Elders, and...I promised.”

“Adora, listen to me,” Marlena soothed, rubbing Adora’s arm. “Subternia’s power is illusion and deception.”

“You would know all about that,” Randor said, striding in (from nowhere), “wouldn’t you, my dear queen?”

Marlena gasped, then glared. “You’ll have to do better than that, Scare Glow,” she mocked, drawing her blaster.

Adora chuckled in spite of the nightmare they were in. “I’m sorry, ‘Scare Glow’ runs this place?”

“They call him Scare Glow,” Adora heard in her own voice, “to pretend they don’t fear him.” A corrupted She-Ra, wearing her original outfit and scarred by red First Ones energies, appeared opposite ‘Randor,’ wielding the Sword of Protection. “His real name is Karak Nul.”

“The first Skeletor,” Adora gasped.

“Do not give him your fear, Adora,” Marlena warned, bracing herself. Mother and daughter alike flinched when she shot the false Randor between the eyes. He fell over, staring sightless at the ceiling.

“Pathetic half-She-Ra,” Adora’s evil counterpart snarled, while a warrior with a massive arm stalked towards Marlena. “We know what you truly fear, and I will give you...despair”

Marlena sighed. “I’m sorry, Malcom.” She gunned down the battle-fist warrior as well. “Adora, you can take her.”

“You failure of a mother,” ‘Despara’ snarled. “She’s nothing without Catra, and she knows it!”

Adora screamed and leaped, Sword blazing. “LIAR!” She-Ra roared, Swords clashing.

Despara laughed. “You were so angry at her for staying,” she mocked, while Marlena shot down a human battering ram, “but you loved proving you could manage without her, didn’t you?”

Adora crashed Sword against Sword. “I tried!” she snapped, circling her foe. “I did everything I could to reach her!”

“But you wouldn’t leave *for* her, would you?” Despara snarled. Adora felt more stabbed than the times she’d actually been stabbed. “You believed Shadow Weaver over her, Light Hope over her, even Horde Prime–”

With a snarl, She-Ra drove her Sword through Despara’s, shattering the Sword of Protection once more. “I know I should have listened to her,” Adora said, her glare cold as Despara melted away with a look of horror on her face. “You’re an old fear. And we’re done.”

“Ah,” Shadow Weaver said, and Adora’s blood became ice, “but the oldest fears cut most deeply, don’t they, Adora?” Marlena

turned away from Delora's brother to drill a dozen blasts through the sorceress' body. They passed through without harm. "I tried to teach you properly, but you simply would not–"

Adora sliced 'Shadow Weaver' in half with almost pathetic ease. "That felt good," she grinned. "Who's next?"

"Who else?" Catra – the lost Catra with her single sleeve – strode forth, tufts sliced away and a whip in her hand. "Hey, Adora."

Adora grunted, risking a look behind. Tears ran freely down her cheeks, but Mom still dropped a guy with an extending neck with practiced ease. "You are not Catra."

"Oh, but I *am,"* she purred, stalking forward. Adora slashed out, but Catra dodged with ease – then her claws passed through She-Ra's throat. It felt like ice through her entire neck, but Horde Catra hadn't left a mark. "The funny thing is, that's not even your greatest fear!" Horde Catra laughed. "It burns, doesn't it? It burns, knowing I could have brought you down any time I wanted. And it's still not the worst one."

Adora looked down, then banished the Sword. She looked back at Catra, and Mom's latest opponent – a plant man who looked like something Perfuma would dream up – vanished. "No," she whispered. "It's not."

"Our love 'saved the universe,'" Catra snarled, "and you're still afraid I don't love you."

Adora strode over, the illusion jumping in place exactly like the real thing. As gently as she could, Adora held Catra's cheeks and smiled. "I love you too." The Catra image froze, eyes wide.

For just an instant, Adora thought it was the real Catra when they kissed.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Void-Catra froze, eyes wide. “Adora?” the real and false Catras said as one.

“Orko!” Evil-Lyn called, firing blasts into Void-Catra. Her shadow-form just absorbed the bursts. “Why don’t you just reverse your spells?”

“I tried that!” Orko wailed, pulling their Catra away from her equally-stunned counterpart. “It’s only almost opposite. I was never able to work out which part’s the same!”

“You,” Catra whispered. “That’s why being powerful gets in the way.”

“Of course,” Evil-Lyn breathed. “You have to reverse the flow, but your spells must remain the same.”

Catra huffed. “That’s part of it, but there’s something more important than that.”

Void-Catra smashed through a bookshelf. The trio ducked behind the wreckage. “Like what?” Orko asked. Catra took in a breath to explain–

“There’s nothing wrong with you,” Evil-Lyn gasped, staring at the ceiling in shock. “You’ve spent so long as a failure after being able to cast spells as easily as breathing, you think that you must be the problem.”

Catra grinned at him. “But you’re not. There’s nothing wrong with Orko…” she glanced at the witch. “...or Lyn.”

The Trollan and the Eternian looked at each other. Orko held out his hand. Lyn placed her wand in it, still holding on. Catra joined in. All three turned their attention to Void-Catra. At some point, she’d donned Shadow Weaver’s mask. “HEY, CATRA,” she snarled.

“I already beat you once,” Catra hissed, “and we’re *all* done with you.”

They unleashed fire to start a new sun. Void-Catra burned to nothing.

Subternia took form around them once more. "Wildcat!" Scorpia cried in relief, and Catra accepted the ensuing hug as gracefully as she could manage. "Oh, Stars, are you all right? I had to fight you, but it wasn't you, was it?"

Catra flinched, then shook it off and smiled at Scorpia. "Not who I am now," she explained. She looked behind Scorpia at a shaken Bow. "You all right, Crop Top?"

"Glimmer," he explained with a shiver. Catra nodded as Scorpia put her down–

–and Adora scooped her up, kissing her in Adora's natural form. *I am losing all control of this purring thing,* Catra thought, but with Adora's lips on hers, found it hard to care.

"But where's – TEELA!" Orko cheered. Teela climbed out of a massive pit, a dark Sword in hand.

Catra couldn't help a grin. "Not bad, Undercut," she admitted.

Lyn stepped forward. "Give it to me," she ordered. Teela, predictably, didn't, pulling it away from her.

Catra leaned over. "I'm the last cat to talk, but maybe try a little gentler?" she suggested to the sorceress.

Lyn sighed. "That is only one of the Swords," she pointed out. "I need it to reach the other." With obvious reluctance, Teela gave Lyn the Dark Sword. Lyn cast a spell that impressed even Catra, opening a doorway to a place that looked like a legit paradise.

Scorpia whistled. "Okay," Bow admitted as Lyn collapsed, Beast-Man catching her, "that is some impressive magic."

"Is that…" Teela asked, taking a step forward.

"Preternia," Orko answered, floating over to Lyn and her companion. "For all of us. Turns out, no one's born evil," he said, giving Lyn a wink.

"Yeah yeah, warm fuzzies," Catra quipped, "can we leave the literal Hell now?"

The ground rumbled, because of course it did. "No," Nul growled, striding towards them.

"Go!" Adora ordered, but the ground itself reached up to grab them. Only Orko's floating and Catra's shape-changing eluded the grasp. "For the hon–mmph!" Karak Nul, in an annoying fit of intelligence, focused on Adora first.

"Feed me your fear!" Nul exulted, stalking towards them. "No one cheats Death!"

Catra scoffed leaping forward and firing shadow-blasts. "Do you even *know* what a magicat is? Orko, get those dorks out of here!"

"Catra!" Bow and Scorpia cried. Both opened fire on Nul, but he parried with ghostly skulls.

"More! More!" Nul demanded. "This time, Teela, you will pay!" He stomped the ground, and the stalactites (stalagmites? Entrapta would know) came down on them. Catra flung out a shield of darkness–

–but they stopped before reaching her friends. Orko floated there, holding them up with a gesture. "You save them, Catra," he insisted. "I'll handle Scare Glow."

Catra groaned, slashing Adora free. "–of Grayskull!" she finished, turning back into She-Ra. Adora turned to rescue the others; Catra broke Scorpia out, then raced to help the Trollan.

Orko flung the – pointy rocks – at Nul, who dodged most and tanked one. "Innnsect!" Nul snarled, conjuring a flood of moaning green skulls. Orko blocked the eruption with a golden shield.

“What is it with this planet and skulls?” Catra complained, backing Orko’s spell with her shadows. “Orko, I told you to move! I can handle this creep.”

“Catra, get out of there!” Adora begged.

“Orko, come on!” Teela agreed.

“Thank you, Catra. You were right – there was never anything wrong with me,” Orko said, sounding at peace with himself. “Teela, it’s okay. I’m ready, and I’m not afraid.”

“Yeah, well, I am,” Catra replied. “Sorry, Impy.” She grabbed the back of his robe. “I can’t lose anyone else.” Orko gasped.

With all her might, Catra flung the little wizard towards the door, then pushed everyone through it with her darkness magic. She held off Scare Glow with her other hand, Tri-Klops’ tech bolstering her shadow shield. “Adora!” she called, smiling at her. “This isn’t the end.”

“Catra, no! Please!” Adora cried, rushing back towards the gate.

“You’ll see me again, Adora,” Catra swore, still smiling as the first Skeletor bore down on her, roaring in fury. *“I promise.”*

With a savage yank and a roar echoing from the first Bubasti, she slammed the gate shut.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

“Catra! *Catra!”* Adora and the Trollan pounded on the rock where the gate had been, but all that remained were shards of the underworld.

“No,” Teela whispered.

Marlena walked over to Adora, putting a hand on her shoulder. Adora flung herself into her mother’s arms, knowing she had a duty to complete, wanting nothing but to be buried with Catra.

“I tried to save her,” Lyn whispered.

“We know,” Orko agreed.

“No,” Teela said, glaring at Lyn. “It should have been you.”

Adora’s head snapped up. “What?” she asked, pulling out of the hug to face the Eternian warrior. “It, it shouldn’t have been any of us!”

“Trusting Evil-Lyn was a mistake, Princess Adora,” Teela continued, turning her rod into a sword. “But we can fix it.” Lyn recoiled, Beast-Man stepping between the blade and the sorceress.

“Wait, please,” Orko said, darting in.

“Trusting *her* was a mistake?” Adora barked, bringing Teela up short. “Catra tried to warn you about taking short cuts, but you didn’t listen, did you?”

Teela stared at her, eyes wide. “What are you talking about?”

“‘No one cheats Death,’ he said,” Adora said, cold as space. She formed the Sword with a thought. “But you did, didn’t you?”

“Okay,” Bow said, joining Orko, “why don’t we all take a moment to step back and figure out what we need to do next.”

Adora trembled for a moment, Sword quivering in her hand. Teela moved into a defensive position, Andra and Roboto beside her.

“Mom?” a young man’s voice asked. *“Teela?”*

They all turned – and the Eternians gasped, staring. A skinny blond stared back. “By the power of Grayskull!” he blurted.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Teela forced a calm she didn’t feel. Almost everyone had shared some of the ”exposition” duties, except her. (“Best boy” Bow had done the most work on that; Scorpia’s nickname for the kid made

Teela smile.) Adora no longer looked *completely* broken, but she still looked like a good tap would shatter her. The former Man-at-Arms was glad they were all sitting.

"So!" Adora blurted, using that now-too-familiar forced cheer. "You're...not actually dead!" Adora couldn't help a smile of her own.

Adam shrugged. "Well, technically, I died, so – I think I am?" he pointed out. Orko was still hugging him almost an hour later, though he'd finally stopped crying.

Bow took out his 'tracker pad,' which did a lot more than tracking but okay, and scanned Adam with it. "Heartbeat...lungs breathing...active synapses...as Entrapta would say, 'data never lies.' You're alive, Adam." He smiled, and Adam blushed. Teela couldn't help a chuckle. *You really do love everyone, don't you, Adam?* she mused, shaking her head.

Adam looked at his hands. "But...I don't understand...what does that mean?"

Marlena took one of his hands, tears streaming. "It means you can come home, Adam."

With a sigh, Adam stood. "I'm still not sure I can get *you* home. Under normal circumstances, there's no way out of Preternia."

"Could we go back the way we came?" Scorpia asked, pointing at where Evil-Lyn's gate had been. "Maybe open the big rock thing from underneath, and…" she glanced at Adora.

Adora's eyes glittered, harder than diamonds. "Save Catra."

"Let me try from this end first," Adam suggested, holding up his hands. "Teela, Roboto, Orko, you have both Swords now." Teela stood as well, the others following. *He just* had *the Sword, because of* course *he did.* "I need to see the man himself."

"What man?" Andra asked.

Adam's smile rivaled Bow's, and Teela stomped on her heart before it could do cartwheels in her chest. "King Grayskull," he said, as if that were normal somehow.

"Wait," Andra fangirled, Bow perking up. "*The* King Grayskull? As in stopped the Horde from taking Eternia *while* fighting the first Skeletor, King Grayskull?"

Adam chuckled. "Yep, and pretty much all the stories are true. I'll need a little time to find him, though." His smile broadened. "Today is the Wild Hunt."

Adora huffed, brushing off her pants. "Then let's go hunting. You guys do the...Sword...thing." She waved at the two Swords, standing beside Adam. Marlena joined them.

Teela handed Roboto the Swords. "Go. Makes us a Power Sword."

Andra nudged Bow with her shoulder. "Time to put those Tech Master skills to use," she said.

"I can't wait to work with you," Bow added. "Roboto, can Scorpia's magic help?"

"Oh, most certainly," Roboto agreed. "We will require enough electricity to power a world. Possibly more. Princess Scorpia's abilities will be useful."

"Okay!" Scorpia agreed. "Y'know, as long as you don't need me to do, you know, delicate stuff." She waved her claws.

"You'll be fine," Teela said, patting the big gal on the shoulder. "Come on, Grayskulls," she continued, joining the royals. "Let's find your million-times-great-grandfather and get this done." They headed into the forest, and Teela was glad not to be alone with Adam.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Bow was caught between fear and joy.

On the one hand, they had the chance to save Eternia's people and half the universe. Andra's plan to turn He-Ro's solid-Eternium tower into one giant forge was inspired. Thanks to Adora's gift, Orko, Lyn, and Scorpia seemed to have enough power to reunite the Sword. Most importantly, Roboto sounded confident that he could make the impossible-seeming plan work.

But it also sounded incredibly dangerous. Roboto had told them to get to 'the minimum safe distance,' and Bow wasn't sure there *was* one. Glimmer and the others were still back on Eternia with that planet's biggest target over her – their heads. The heroic Eternians still didn't really trust Lyn, except Orko. Poor Orko, for all that he had overcome his magical problems and made friends with Lyn, was still beside himself with guilt over...

...Catra...

Trapped. In Hell. Alone. Bow had finished forgiving her a while ago, but if anyone wanted to claim that Catra hadn't atoned for what she had done, he would have words with them. And if necessary, arrows.

Orko, Lyn, and Scorpia were situated at three of the four electrical conduits. Andra had devised a lightning rod to power the fourth, Bow and Beast-Man seeding the clouds with the help of smoke arrows and local creatures. "I just hope it's enough," Bow muttered.

"Do…" Orko whispered. "...do you think Catra's okay?"

Lyn smiled, shaking her head. "She's a survivor, Oracle," she said, gathering power around her wand-orb. "Maybe, if I had fallen for someone like Adora, instead of…" she chuckled. "...having 'a Skeletor in my closet,' I might have become like her instead of, like me." Beast-Man looked away.

"You're not so bad," Bow said, "when you're not being 'Evil'-Lyn."

"I don't know," Lyn whispered, looking into her orb. "Catra was a wounded, literally tortured child lashing out in terror. All she ever

wanted was for someone to acknowledge her worth. I was a spoiled fool who always wanted more."

"Sounds like that's not who you are now," Bow offered, managing a tiny smile.

Beast-Man took a step closer to Lyn. "And there was always more to you than greed, my lady."

Lyn turned a shocked look on Beast-Man. "Raquill," she breathed, one hand stroking his cheek. "I left you so many times. Led you into the most terrible evils. Why do you always come for me?"

"Because I have always seen more in you, my lady," Raquill said, bowing. Then he smiled without mirth. "And I was hardly an innocent when we met."

"Okay, I'm not getting involved in...whatever's going on there," Andra said, gesturing at the two of them, "except, well, he literally followed you into Hell."

"It can be hard to believe in yourself when you've made a mistake," Bow admitted, looking away for a moment. "It helps when you can believe in each other."

Lyn's smile returned. "Your Glimmer had better appreciate you, archer," she replied, and Bow blushed.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Glimmer wove through the spell just as the Sorceress had taught it to her. "Wow," she said, watching the life spell come to...well, life. The plants around them, already withering in Adora's absence, bloomed again, and the Sorceress' aging reversed until she only had the one lock of gray hair. "My Dad's an amazing sorcerer, but you're..."

"I have advantages your father does not," the Sorceress assured her. "Aside from my centuries of life, I have access to the Hall of

Wisdom's knowledge." Her smile was wry. "Besides, I don't get out much."

"Who could blame you?" Entrapta gushed, zipping down with a mix of grapple line and hair limbs. "All the knowledge in the universe, right there to study." She stroked one of the fallen metal triangles with a pigtail. "Personally, I prefer direct experimentation. Perhaps I've developed an aesthetic appreciation for explosions."

Hordak smiled down at the little genius. It was...strangely un-creepy. "I fear that the only explosions in our immediate future involve our enemies."

Entrapta nodded, going over her data pad. "I could use the experience, anyway," she admitted. "If we're going to keep traveling through *space,"* she paused to look up, eyes sparkling at the notion even underground, "I have to learn to defend myself and my friends." She bit her lip. "I couldn't do anything when Horde Prime grabbed me..."

"Hey," Glimmer cut in. "It took Adora becoming the most powerful She-Ra in thousands of years – maybe millions – to beat him. If this is what you really want, then go for it, but you're fine just the way you are, Entrapta."

Entrapta looked down, arms drooping while she twiddled her pigtails like fingers. "I don't know," she muttered. "I hurt so many of my friends."

Glimmer shrugged. "Me too," she said, looking at the magic around her staff. "I wanted to save everyone, but all I did was make things worse." Melog rubbed against her hip, and she gave him an ear scritch with a tired smile.

"Sometimes," Hordak offered, "mistakes can lead to greater good. Without Entrapta's defection, you would never have known so much about Horde technology when Prime arrived," he continued, touching the First Ones crystal over his heart, "or gained a useful

ally in the final hour. Imperfection, it seems, truly is beautiful sometimes." Entrapta beamed at him.

"Well said, Hordak," Duncan agreed, grappling down.

"Words I never thought I'd hear as a kid," Glimmer quipped.

"All the same, I need all combat-ready warriors on the surface. We have incoming," Duncan explained. Glimmer immediately teleported up, using an Eternian scope to look over the incoming forces. It was more of those Roton things, led by a cyborg with a metal jaw and two reptile men. One was a massive warrior with a wrecking ball for a tail. The other was still tall and muscular, but more slender, combining power with speed. Memories of fighting Catra made the princess frown.

Duncan and Melog reached the parapet Glimmer had chosen. The human was hefting a massive beam cannon as easily as Glimmer carried her wand. His helmet dropped a visor over his eyes. "Kobra Khan," he muttered, sounding worried.

"How bad?" Glimmer asked, prepping a shield spell.

"He's the closest thing our world has to your Catra," Duncan explained, "when she was with the Horde."

Glimmer shivered. "So *really* bad, then."

"He wanted his people to be more aggressive against Snake Mountain, but they rejected his call to arms. Keldor is not quite the racist his predecessors were," Duncan explained, "and offered Kobra rulership over the Reptons in exchange for his loyalty. He was ever Snake Mountain's greatest strategist, equal to Tri-Klops and Evil-Lyn in rank."

"And now he's top skull," Glimmer filled in.

"What is our strategy, Man-at-Arms?" Hordak asked over comms. "Our two best options appear to use the choke point of the bridge, or a variable zone defense."

“Zone,” Duncan replied without hesitation. “If it fails, we can always fall back to the gatehouse.” Glimmer charged her wand and grinned. Melog grew to maximum size, growing the wings of the silvery dragon Adora rescued from Vultak, and roared.

Then blasts struck the invaders from behind. A mix of Wind Raiders and Rotons, the latter repainted the green and orange of Eternos’ military, struck at the invaders. They scattered, though Kobra Khan proved every bit the strategist Duncan had warned of, managing the retreat in good order in spite of the devastating surprise attack.

King Randor and a guy with a cybernetic eye band strode out from the front of their reinforcements. Delora and Sy-Klone trailed close behind. Duncan grappled down, and Glimmer teleported to join them. “Your Majesty,” Duncan said, bowing, “I cannot yet offer you my life for this defiance of your orders, but when Grayskull and the Sorceress are safe–”

“WHAT?” Glimmer blurted, then teleported between Duncan and Randor. “Your Majesty, your former Man-at-Arms has given priceless service to both our worlds. Brightmoon would take it as a grave affront if you were to kill him for protecting Eternia and the entire universe.”

Randor looked from Duncan to Glimmer and back. Then he started to laugh. It built, not sounding entirely healthy, until he leaned on Tri-Klops’ shoulder and cried from laughing so hard. (But it was also obvious that laughter wasn’t the only reason for his tears.) Duncan looked up in shock. “Oh, get up, you crazy old goat,” Randor said at last, offering Duncan his hand. Man-at-Arms took it, and the king helped him up. Then Randor offered Glimmer a respectable bow. “Your Highness, you and your subjects have the gratitude of all Eternos for your efforts.”

“Oh! Uh, no problem at all!” Glimmer replied, rubbing the back of her neck and trying not to chuckle nervously. “Saving the day is kinda our thing.” Melog purred in agreement.

Duncan looked over the forces Randor had brought with them. "I presume Eternos is secure, Your Majesty?"

"Perkaedo has his husband and Illumina to back him up," Randor explained. "Buzz-Off has also called on his people in case Kobra Khan tries an 'end run,' as Marlena would say." The king's remaining good cheer vanished, and he looked at – Marlena's crown? Duncan gasped, and Glimmer's hand went to her mouth. "It's not what you think," Randor added, tucking the crown away. "It was a message. Of trust."

"Captain – Queen Marlena vouched for me," Tri-Klops explained.

Duncan snorted. It reminded Glimmer of a Minotaur considering a charge. "And what convinced her of your sincerity?"

"Not what. Who. The same person that convinced me to try and...find my way again," Tri-Klops replied.

Glimmer grinned as Entrapta raced over to gush at Tri-Klops' tech. "Adora," she guessed.

"No," Tri-Klops said, glancing at Entrapta as she probed at his cyber-eyes with her hair. "Catra."

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Catra traded blows with Karak Nul, exulting in the purity of their duel. *No innocent people to hurt,* she thought, savage joy howling through the magicat. *No question who the bad guy is. Just me, and the monster who ruined the world.* He fought with rock-shattering fists, control over the stone around them, and blasts of ghostly power. Catra struck back with claws, shape-changing tricks, and her shadow might. *Too bad I never learned how to use Freezefire. It'd really come in handy right now.*

"You denied me my rightful prey!" Karak Nul howled, firing a cavern-filling barrage of green skulls. "I will devour your fear whole!"

"Teela made a mistake!" Catra snapped back, parrying his blast with another shadow shield. *He's repeating moves,* she realized, circling. *I...I think I can take him!* She shrank to housecat size, dodging behind some pillars, then leaped out as a lioness, knocking Nul back. "She's trying to save her friends, and you broke the entire *universe!* You don't *get* to judge her!"

"I bargained in good faith!" Nul snarled. "I was so *hungry!* I…" he held his stomach, slowing. Somehow, he looked sad even with a skull for a head. "It's been so long..."

Catra came to a halt herself. *"Broke the universe"...projection much, Catra?* she thought, ears and tail wilting. "So talk to me," she said. "You want fear? I'm a seven-course meal." She shook her head. "Which sounds like a whole *week* of rations, but that's Brightmoon for ya."

Scare Glow dimmed, looking her over. "You're a magicat," he whispered.

Catra raised an eyebrow. "Uh, duh? Are you just figuring that out now?"

"There are many feline species across the universe," Nul replied, pushing his cape out of the way and sitting down. "Even Halfmoon's descendants on Thundera have diverged from your kind. Why are you not trying to destroy me? You could become a god here."

"Yeah, no. If you don't want out, you can have the place," Catra explained, waving at the glowing caverns around them. "If I don't have to claw my way through you to reach Adora, then we're good."

"Sit with me a moment," Nul said, gesturing in front of him. Catra crossed her arms, one eyebrow raised. Nul sighed. "Please." Catra sat. "The current Skeletor lives."

"Wait," Catra blurted, "like, the 'killed Adora's brother' Skeletor? He's still around?"

“Hiding in Evil-Lyn’s wand,” Nul explained, “waiting until Teela restores the magic.” He shrugged. “That said, as Prince Adam is in Preternia, if they can find a way from Paradise, so can he.”

Catra blinked, unable to think of a reply more witty. “Okay,” she settled on. “So. Um. What do you want?”

“The one thing you cannot give me, Bubastis,” Nul explained. “Freedom.”

Catra stared, calling up her magic. Shadow Weaver’s knowledge told her almost nothing about this. “Why can’t I?”

“Because you made a promise, magicat,” he said. “The only way I can have peace is for someone to take my power, willingly.” Nul laughed suddenly, the sound filled with madness and pain. “To become the Lord of the Dead, the ‘Scare Glow,’ is to become a Master of the Universe. But this universe is empty.”

Catra looked around at the glowing green stones. “All-powerful,” she realized. “All alone.”

“I can have anything I want down here,” he explained, waving. “Except companionship. When I was new here, I could have breached the surface at the cost of my life. Now, though,” Nul continued, gesturing at the glow of his bones, “I am weighed down by the sins of the Skeletors, eons of bigotry and cruelty stealing my choices, as I stole them from so many.”

“But I could,” Catra mused, scratching her chin. “If I’m careful, I can escape and keep my promise.”

Nul’s eyes widened, their glow brightening. “You’re a magicat. Of course. That could work, if you were able to...but understand,” he warned, “this price is not one even She-Ra can undo. I am not truly Death, and it is Death you must tithe. Even a cat cannot cheat Her.” He paused. “You would also have to forgive the most evil being in all of history.”

"I met Horde Prime," Catra retorted. "You're not him." She held out her hands. "Okay. Let's do this."

Nul's eye sockets went wide. "Are you serious?"

"Yeah." Catra made fists for a moment. "I've been forgiven by so many people who should have hated me forever...hurt the woman I love more than anything, in almost every way possible...burned down homes, towns, kingdoms, even my entire world." She let go, offering Nul her hands again. "I'm going to be worthy of them. Of *her.* If it takes the rest of my life."

"You...are a good woman, Catra of Etheria." Nul placed his hands in hers. The glow faded from his bones, slowly filling hers with interwoven patterns of blue and gold. "Thank you…"

When the glow vanished, so did Karak Nul.

Catra shivered from the power coursing through her. She formed a mirror in the air, looking at her creepy-cool new look. Her borrowed jumpsuit was now a red top and blue pants, trimmed in gold, and she wore Scare Glow's cape. Catra gave it a little flick. *Huh. I make it work.* Then she thought about remaking Subternia, and in seconds, the barren caverns took the form of the entire city of New Halfmoon, with her between the thrones of the magicats. *Master of the Universe. He wasn't kidding. I need to be very careful with this plan.*

Drawing on all the training Perfuma and Angella had given her in meditation, Catra sat on the floor in front of Halfmoon's thrones and concentrated. She couldn't affect the other worlds, but she could see them. Adora was with Teela, after a crazy hunt where she'd robbed some big shot king of his 'prey.' Catra smirked; of course she saved the cat. *Don't give up, Adora. I'll be there.*

I promise.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Adora watched as Adam and her mom – their mom – laughed with the other ancient heroes around the campfire. The only one missing was–

"Are you all right?" Mara asked.

Adora jumped, hand over her heart. "Mara!" she blurted. "Fine! I'm fine. I'm just, y'know, trying to help out." She glanced at where the geniuses had gathered to reforge the Sword of Power, lightning crashing like a hundred storms at once.

Mara took her hand. "Adora, it's not your job to fix everything," she insisted.

Adora pulled her hand away and threw up her arms. "I know! I know, 'I deserve love too,' but the woman I love is *literally trapped in Hell,* and I'm stuck here in this so-called 'Paradise' waiting for other people to undo damage I should've been able to handle just by being She-Ra!"

Mara's smile was somehow gentle. "It's not Heaven if she's not here," Mara said.

Adora sighed, head drooping. "No. It's not," she whispered.

"Honey, I think she could use your help," Mara called.

Light Hope appeared by Mara's side. Adora yelped and jumped back; somehow, they held hands. That meant Light Hope was a solid being, at least partly human...ish? "I do not believe Adora desires my advice, Mara," Hope said, looking downcast.

"You were fighting the First Ones' programming," Adora realized, eyes wide. "When I destroyed the Sword..."

"The malevolent aspect of my personality matrix attempted to fire the Weapon, yes," Light Hope admitted. "However, you should not discount your heroism. I would not have been able to resist for long. When you destroyed the Sword, you saved over 99.784% of sentient life in the known universe."

"Okay, wow," Adora gulped. Then she shook her head. "Look, I am – *so* happy for you two, I really am, but I need to help Teela and Adam get over their, their whatever is going on with them so they can save Eternia." She made a fist. "And I am going back for Catra, no matter what."

"Just don't forget to take care of yourself," Mara insisted, "okay, Adora?"

Adora nodded, following Teela as she left the party. One glance back made her smile, each heroine with an arm around the other's waist. Then she rushed to catch up with the Eternian warrior who reminded her so much of Catra.

"I'm not in a mood to talk, Princess Adora," Teela sighed, standing at the edge of a pond.

"I'm not the one you need to talk to," Adora replied. "I mean, I want a chance to apologize, but–

Teela turned in surprise. "Apologize? For what?"

"I was...kind of hard on you after Subternia," Adora admitted, looking away. "*Really* hard on you, if I'm being honest. I've learned the hard way that I need to be less judgmental."

"Hah," Teela scoffed. "*You* need to be less judgmental? You healed the magic–"

"–temporarily–" Adora objected.

"–and your girlfriend stayed in Hell to save Orko and half the universe–" Teela continued.

"–that was her choice–" Adora interrupted, trying not to feel bitter.

The two warriors looked at each other for several seconds, neither speaking nor moving. Then they both laughed, hard. "What is wrong with us?" Teela asked, wiping away a tear.

“Me? Shadow Weaver,” Adora replied, shaking her head as she chuckled. “Not sure about you.”

Teela’s laughter trailed off, and she found a tree to lean against. “I just...wish…” she looked back towards camp. “I can’t,” she whispered.

“You can,” Adora said, walking over and taking Teela’s hand. “Catra’s the bravest woman I’ve ever known. You remind me of her, the *best* of her. Whatever the truth is, you can handle it.”

“And I’ll tell you the truth this time,” Adam said, entering the clearing. Teela straightened, pulling her hand back. “I promise.”

“And if he doesn’t,” Adora quipped, “I’ll tell on him to our mom.”

All three laughed. “Okay,” Teela said, steeling herself and glaring at Adam. “Why?”

Adam’s smile vanished. He had the strength to meet Teela’s eyes, but the quiver in his jaw and his hands clasped in front of him gave away his nervous guilt. “The Sorceress asked me not to. Begged, in fact.”

Teela’s jaw dropped. “The – the *Sorceress?”* she blurted. “The Sorceress didn’t trust me?” Teela sounded hollowed out.

Adam shook his head, reaching out. “No, it wasn’t like that!”

“But, but you could tell Orko, and Kringer, and your mom and my dad?” Teela demanded.

“I never told anyone,” Adam sighed, looking down again. “The Sorceress brought Duncan in when she summoned me. Orko and Kringer snuck after us. Mom just...figured it out, because she’s my mom.” Adam met Teela’s gaze again. “There was no one I wanted to tell more than you, Teela, I swear by the power.”

“Then *why?”* Teela demanded, the woman who had defeated the Devil himself on the verge of tears. “Why didn’t the Sorceress tell

me?”

“Because of the other secret she kept,” Adam explained. “You’re her daughter.”

Adora gasped. Teela froze, eyes moon-wide. “I – I’m – what?”

“The Sorceress fell in love after hundreds of years,” he continued, “but uncle Keldor was the most dangerous Skeletor in ages. She had you in Castle Grayskull, which gave you the potential to be the most powerful sorceress that ever lived.” He deflated, wringing his hands. “But that would have meant the Elders would choose you to become the next Sorceress, trapped in Grayskull for who knows how many lifetimes. And that’s if Skeletor didn’t grab you while you were helpless. I mean, Mer-Man almost sacrificed you as a baby, and he only sensed the tiniest fraction of your potential.”

“She did it to protect Teela,” Adora realized. “So she could live free.”

“And, well, you were so proud of everything you could do without magic,” Adam said. “If you’d been interested–”

“I found out once,” Teela whispered, eyes shining with tears. “She – she erased my memory.”

Adam gasped, suddenly as upright as if he were at attention. *“What?”*

Teela laughed, hand over her face. “Gods,” she scoffed. “You – you know what the worst part is? I *get* it now. I get why she did it. Skeletor could have won just by putting me in a battery or something.” She glared. “I’m still furious at her, but I get it. What the HELL does that have to do with you being He-Man?”

“I don’t know,” Adam admitted. “She just said that if you found out about me, you’d find out about yourself.” He chuckled. “‘Something something magic.’”

Teela chuckled back. “Oh, gods, I remember that.” She sighed. “Do you have any idea how much it hurt?”

“I don’t know,” Adam admitted, “but...I think so? Because not telling you hurt, every day.” Teela looked at him in amazement. She glanced at Adora.

Adora held up her hands. “Don’t look at me,” she pleaded. “I have enough baggage to fill Brightmoon, but this isn’t a thing I ever had with…” she trailed off.

Teela gasped. “Adora, I’m sorr–”

“That’s not it,” Adora realized. “Catra hid her pain, her scars, her...everything, as much as she could, of what Shadow Weaver was doing to her. She did it because if I found out, I would’ve done anything to save her. And we wouldn’t have had a chance against that witch.” She sighed. “The worst part of being She-Ra, Teela, is that sometimes there’s no good answer. There’s no *right* answer. You just do your best, and hope the people you love can forgive you.”

Teela looked at Adam again. He smiled. “I understand if you hate me, Teela. I wish things could have been different. But please, so many people made sacrifices so you could decide who you wanted to be.” He almost held out his hand, then pulled it back. “I just hope you can decide to be happy.”

Teela’s eyes shone with tears again. “Adora, can you give us a minute?” Smiling, Adora took a step back–

–and the top of Eternia Tower exploded.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Adam watched, on the edge of despair, as Orko and Lyn completed Roboto’s grave, moving the dirt back over his chassis and standing a gravestone up over it. Orko, still crying, inscribed just three words on the stone:

Roboto

A Miracle

Andra and Bow were still crying. Scorpia had found some flowers for the mound, leaving them there as the group packed up to leave. Teela bore the Sword; given the price she had paid for it, that seemed right.

The trip to Grayskull Tower was quiet. Orko was still sniffling. Adam put an arm around him, and the little Trollan just sobbed into his shoulder.

It turned out that King Grayskull had a gateway to Eternia just stashed at the top floor, with all the security and secrecy of a box of old toys in the attic. Teela paused. "You're coming with us," she asked, resigned, "aren't you?"

"Someone has to bring back the Power," Adam said. "We don't have time to find someone else to attune to the Sword, if the Sorceress is even able."

Marlena looked at Teela in shock. "Why would you want him to stay?" she asked.

"Because he can live here forever," Teela pointed out, and Marlena understood in an instant, "in peace."

"Understand, Prince Adam," King Grayskull warned, "that if you leave, there is no coming back."

"Roboto gave his life to reforge the Sword," Adam insisted, facing his legendary counterparts. "Catra is still trapped in Subternia. If I stayed here after their sacrifices, let Teela fix my mistakes and my sister go after her fiancée without me, I wouldn't deserve Paradise anyway."

"Thank you, Adam," Adora whispered, and that was enough to make his decision worth it.

But there was something, some*one,* more important. He smiled at Teela. "I go where you go."

With one last round of goodbyes, they passed through the gate to Eternia–

–and into a war zone.

They were just outside the wounded Hall of Wisdom, where Skeletor soldiers fought Eternos troops and robed cyborgs. Kobra Khan led the invaders, while Duncan led the counteroffensive with the help of a super-sparkly sorceress, a Horde soldier in shapeshifting armor, Dad, and – Tri-Klops? "Is that Tri-Klops?" Adam blurted, then yelped in fear when a soldier jumped at him.

Beast-Man, of all people, saved Adam then, followed by Sy-Klone and Tri-Klops. Dad rushed over to Mom, the two of them fighting as if they shared one mind. "I do want you here, Marlena," Randor cried, "more than anything!"

"I love you too, Randor," Mom replied. "Now fight!"

A few seconds after that, Adora stabbed her blade into the ground, sending a very He-Man-like shockwave at the Dread forces. Adam smiled as the others cheered, and his parents kissed.

He looked away, blushing, when the kiss didn't stop for a while.

"Your Majesty," Teela said, tone grave as she bowed to the king. "I will make no excuses for my dereliction. All I will say is that we once more have the Sword of Power."

"Rise, Captain Teela," Randor ordered, and Teela responded with a start. "I was no less emotional than you when I exiled your father and…" he glanced at Marlena. "Well. It was not my finest hour, either." He closed his eyes. "Adam's loss is a void nothing can fill." He opened them, a hand on Teela's shoulder. "Yet we must honor his sacrifice and continue forward, Man-at-Arms...if you would still have the role."

Orko cleared his throat. “Actually, Your Majesty, there’s something we have to tell you.” The crowd parted, and Randor saw Adam at last.

Even knowing that his father loved him, Randor’s shock and tears left Adam speechless. “Adam?” the king whispered. *“Adam!”* he cried, throwing his arms around his son. “You...you are grounded, young man,” he sobbed. “For a year.”

“Yes, father,” was all Adam could say to that.

It wasn’t long afterward that Duncan, Kringer, and all the others were hugging and crying as well (though only Kringer licked him, thank the gods). “How?” Duncan asked.

“Preternia,” Marlena said, as if that explained everything. (Adam supposed it did, really.) She turned somber in an instant. “Though we paid the price for this victory.”

“What price–” Duncan looked through the group in horror. “Where’s Roboto?”

“Reforging the Sword was...too much for him,” Teela admitted, wiping her eyes. “He had feelings, at the end. He said to tell you he was a miracle.”

“Yes,” Duncan shuddered, nodding. “Yes he was.”

“What about Catra?” Glimmer blurted, teleporting to Adora’s side.

“Trapped,” Adora explained, “in Subternia. But we are going back for her.”

Randor nodded. “I promise you, daughter, that all the might of Eternos will be at your command in your quest.” He shrank a little, holding Mom’s crown. “If you can forgive an old fool his weakness.”

Adora didn’t hesitate, throwing her arms around him. “Thanks...Dad,” she said.

“Okay.” Teela handed Adam the Sword. “Let’s go into the Castle, you say the magic words, and we save the world. For Roboto.”

Adam nodded. “And Catra.” They marched into the Castle, only the shock of a Sorceress frail and half-gray stopping him for a moment.

“I am so proud of you...Teela,” the Sorceress said, her smile beatific.

“Thanks,” Teela said, swallowing, “but when this is over, we need to talk...Mom.” A chorus of gasps made Adam winced.

The Sorceress looked down, shoulders slumped. “Teela...I know you will never forgive me. But all I ever wanted was for you to be free and happy–”

Teela hugged her. “I’m still mad at you,” she whispered, “but even when I wasn’t happy, everything I did with my life was my choice, so...thank you, Mom.”

With that, they all descended into the Orb chamber. “Still know the tune?” Teela asked with a smile.

“Some things,” Adam replied with his own grin, “you never forget.” He held up the Sword. “By the power of Grayskull!”

Adora’s efforts had already healed so much of the damage, the rush of Grayskull’s power seemed to make things right in a heartbeat. The Sorceress was restored, life blossoming, and the damage to the Hall of Wisdom reversed. The illusion of Castle Grayskull returned. “I...have...the POWER!”

Even in the rush of might, Adam had been fighting Point Dread for so long that the sound of metal on bone was unmistakable. “Oh, *come on!”* Skeletor whined.

He-Man gasped. *Skeletor!* He whirled to face the villain–

–and there was Catra, hand gripping the Havoc Staff where Skeletor had tried to stab her in the ribs. “Hey, Skeletor,” Catra drawled.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Adora’s emotions were a complete mess. Ecstasy, terror, relief, and fury all warred through her. Catra was alive. Skeletor was trying to stab her. Catra was free. *Skeletor was trying to stab her.*

With a cry of absolute fury, She-Ra leaped at the villain, Sword blazing in her hands. Skeletor dodged a little, but Catra was still holding onto the creepy staff, so Adora was able to slash a mark in the floating skull. “Catra! How?”

That laugh made everything right. “I’m awesome, obviously,” Catra quipped. “I’ll explain later. Right now,” she continued, glaring at Skeletor, “I’ve got a bonehead to pick with your uncle.”

That was when Catra’s skeleton glowed, half-blue and half-gold, but otherwise like Scare Glow. Adora swallowed. “Catra?”

“Evil-Lyn! Do something!” Skeletor demanded.

Adora looked from Lyn to Skeletor and back. Lyn looked at her staff, then at Orko of all people. He nodded to her, and she smirked. “Well, Lord Skeletor,” she said, pointing her wand at the combatants, “if you insist.” She blasted her former master into the wall.

As if waiting for the moment, Beast-Man leaped to Catra’s side with a howl. Catra grinned at him. “Raquill, right? How many pieces do you want of Bone Daddy here?”

“I fight for my lady,” he snarled, cracking his whip. “I’ll aid as I can, but I have no need for revenge.”

“Okay,” Catra replied with a nod. “Muscles! How about some percussion to start this party!”

He-Man looked at Adora. "Does she mean me?" he asked while Glimmer began a howling assault of sparkle-blasts.

She-Ra laughed. "Probably," she said, crouching. Skeletor knocked Glimmer back, but Catra shielded her. He-Man grinned and crouched as well.

About then, Skeletor realized just how many people were aiming spells, blasters, and various assorted weapons at him, only hesitating to avoid friendly fire. "Bah!" he snarled, rocketing upward on a column of dark magic.

Catra leaped after him, propelled by bursts of blue force that left golden trails. "Don't let him escape!" she warned, but they were both at the ground floor by the time she did.

Both already prepared, Adora and He-Man both leaped after Skeletor, reaching him and Catra in a single bound. Glimmer teleported up with Bow and Scorpia. "Don't worry, Skeletor," He-Man quipped, "you'll get plenty of running practice in jail."

Skeletor sneered, no mean feat without lips. "Oh, *Adam.* Don't you realize why Miss Kitty is so desperate to stop me here? If I escape, *I win."* He-Man frowned. Adora stared. "Once I'm in the wind, I can pick off your loved once at my leisure." Adora gasped. "Perhaps I'll rip the legs off dear old Dad. Randor always was proud of them," Skeletor snarled. "Or maybe I'll drop your precious Earthling mommy into a bottomless pit to fall forever. Turn Orko into an ash tray. Give Teela to Mer-Man for that sacrifice he's been dreaming of."

"And make Adam give you the Sword so you'll stop," She-Ra filled in.

"Ten points to the dumb blonde in the tights!" Skeletor laughed. "Just give up now, He-Man. You've lost – *what?"*

Again, Catra cackled, but this time, both her hands were on the Havoc Staff. Teela was the next hero to reach them, grappling up while the others coordinated below. "Oh, Skeletor. Mean, dumb

Skeletor. You really don't get it, do you?" she mocked, her glow infusing the staff. "You're not the Master of the Universe now. I am."

"I–Impossible!" Skeletor raged, struggling with Catra for control of the Staff. "No magicat could wield the Havoc Staff, it was made to be anathema to your kind!"

"Unless, and you should have figured this out by now," Catra smirked, "I'm the Lord of the Dead." Skeletor gaped, dark magic lashing out around them both. Even He-Man recoiled, but Adora risked pushing through. *I will never lose her again!* she swore while Catra cackled. "I have the power of the first Skeletor. You, loser, are just the *last* Skeletor. Any questions?"

"How did you escape Subternia? Karak Nul was trapped there for eons!" Skeletor demanded.

"Oh, that one I'll tell you last," Catra said, still pouring magic into the Havoc Staff. "Right now, I just need to kick your–"

The light coming from Catra's skeleton flickered. "No," she groaned. "Not now. Not yet! I'm so close–"

Skeletor laughed and kicked Catra in the gut. That forced her to let go of the Staff, and he blasted her right through the front gate. "NO!" Adora howled, leaping at Skeletor again. This time, when her Sword met his Staff, she managed to crack it – but he just changed its shape and teleported behind Adam. He-Man spun in time to parry a blast, but then Skeletor ran.

Teela had already reached Catra, checking her pulse. She looked up with devastation that – that – *no,* Adora insisted to herself, leading the charge after Skeletor. *This isn't the end. She promised.* Skeletor reached the opening, evading Teela, and firing a signal-blast to his troops.

Catra took a pained, shuddering breath. Teela looked down in amazement. "Where?" was all Catra asked.

“He’s in the field,” Teela warned.

“Slag,” Catra sighed, then made a fist. The same stone tendrils that had grabbed them in Subternia locked onto Skeletor’s legs. “Teela. Adam. The Sword of Power isn’t evil, obviously, but the clue’s in the spell. *You* have the power. The Sword’s just a lightning rod. Just ask Adora.” In no mood to explain, She-Ra held up her conjured Sword, trying to restore Catra’s lost life.

She failed.

Adora looked at Catra with a moment’s horror. *Focus, Adora.* She leaped at Skeletor again, Sword tearing through the night itself. Skeletor parried once more, but this time, it was obvious that she was pushing him to his limits. “You’re not going anywhere, Bonehead,” she quipped.

“Filthy cat-lover!” Skeletor snarled, throwing all his power into a pulse-blast. It only pushed She-Ra back a few inches, but freed him from the stone. He turned to flee, the ‘Heroic Warriors’ engaging with Skeletor’s army–

–but Catra was already there again, grabbing the Havoc Staff before he could react. “Aw, who doesn’t love cats?” She laughed again, then turned serious in an instant. This time, the power flowed away from Skeletor, the Havoc Staff melting *towards* Catra. “Oh, wait. You don’t. Not that it’ll matter much longer.”

“Wh-what are you doing?” Skeletor cried, struggling in Catra’s grip. Scare Glow’s power made her already-amazing strength enough to rival Eternia’s strongest. He-Man and Teela rushed up beside Adora.

“Oh, this? I’m taking away your Skeletor-ness,” Catra explained, as if discussing the weather. “You can do that when you’re Lord of the Dead and Master of the Universe.”

The odd struggle lasted a few moments longer, Catra seeming to have the advantage. “You...you…” Skeletor writhed in place – then froze and grinned. “You little fool!” All at once, the power

suffusing Catra erupted out of her, pouring into Skeletor. “Did you really think a magicat could hold the power of the First Ones who hated you, in battle against *me?”* He threw a limp Catra aside.

She-Ra rushed to catch her, easily reaching Catra before she hit the ground. *She’s light...so light,* Adora worried. “Stay with me, Catra!”

“Sorry, Adora...gotta go...for a bit.” Skeletor laughed maniacally, arms raised in triumph. “Hey, Skele-dork. I said I’d tell you how I got out last.”

Skeletor smirked at them. “Oh? Do tell, then, before I decide how many ways I can skin a cat.”

“You have to give up your life,” Catra whispered, head lolling back. Skeletor gasped as the ground started to swallow him. “You’re a Master of the Universe now, Bonehead. Just not this one.”

“No! NO!” Skeletor thrashed in terror, prying at the force pulling him into Subternia. “YOU TRICKED ME!”

“Yep,” Catra breathed, limp in Adora’s arms. “Thing is...I...have...nnn...”

Catra died in Adora’s arms.

“No.” Adora knelt, cradling Catra. “I told you before, Catra. You’re not done. Not yet.” She poured all her power, her life, her love, everything she felt for Catra, combined with the blessing of Etheria. Something kept it from flowing the way it should, magic pressing against a scar that would not heal.

“NO!” Skeletor screamed. “IT WILL NOT END LIKE THIS!” With incredible force and skill, the sorcerer pushed Karak Nul’s power into the Havoc Staff. Reality itself fought back, space and time warping and howling around him, but in the end, his magical prowess triumphed, and a toxic green glow pulsed within the Staff. With grave effort, Skeletor pushed himself out of the Earth. “Clever, Miss Kitty,” he hissed, pointing the Staff at Adora, “but not

clever enough." He-Man and Teela rushed in between them, Adora still pouring the power of the universe through her Catra.

Catra came to life. She took in a breath as if to scream, then looked at her hands in amazement. She was changing, growing, her red and blue garb becoming twin to She-Ra's. A Sword formed in her hand. To Adora's overwhelming frustration, she could not restore Catra's two lost lives, but what mattered is that she was alive *now.* "Adora?" Catra asked, staring at her new form. "Did you turn me into She-Ra?"

"Who, me?" Adora replied, smirk belying her innocence. "The magic did that. I just, you know,' she made a waving gesture, "gave it a nudge."

"It doesn't matter," Skeletor gloated, holding the Staff high. Green skulls and purple force gathered around him. "Send all the Champions you can dream of at me! Now *I* am Lord of Death!"

"Why was the Havoc Staff indestructible?" Catra asked, smirking. Skeletor froze. "It was malleable. Shifting, flowing, growing, shrinking – even with all that evil, it was alive. Now, it's a conduit for death." Skeletor shook the Staff, but it remained the same shape. "I mean, sure, I didn't think you'd be smart enough to figure that out, but that was plan B." She pointed her Sword at Skeletor. "And I *always* have a plan, Bonehead. Adora! Double time!"

Together, they leaped at Skeletor, both Swords crashing into the Havoc Staff as they pressed for his stupid skull of a face. "Still...not...enough!" Skeletor roared. "You two will never–"

"Muscles! Undercut! You're on!" Catra shouted.

He-Man and Teela called on the Power, both infusing their swords, and leaped. As one, they shouted battle cries as they soared overhead. Skeletor screamed, but with Adora and Catra pinning him down, there was nowhere for him to run.

Together, the two Eternians shattered the Havoc Staff, ending the Skeletor line forever.

Skeletor's scream grew higher and louder, then faded into pathetic echoes as his entire body turned gray. Catra gestured, using shadow to fan the air, and the Lord of Destruction became ash in the wind.

Both couples embraced, Adora kissing Catra again at last. *You and me,* she thought, love overflowing, *at the end of the world. Always.*

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"So it seems only one dilemma remains," the restored Sorceress pointed out. "How do we deal with the forces of Dread that came to Grayskull's aid in our darkest hour?"

"That's the only dilemma?" Teela asked, crossing her arms.

"Ours is a...personal matter," the Sorceress explained, arms folded. "You are free, as I always wished. Whether you decide to forgive me or your father is entirely your decision."

Teela looked at her hands, where the power of the universe had been just minutes before. "I...want to learn magic," she said. The Sorceress' eyes went wide. "Don't get me wrong, I don't want to be stuck in Castle Grayskull forever, but this is part of who I am."

"Perhaps one solution can serve another," Lyn suggested.

Randor turned a wary eye on Point Dread's witch. "And what might that be?"

"Let me be the Sorceress of Grayskull," she offered. Half the heroes assembled stared, eyes wide. "I deserve reward, for my efforts to save the world. I...deserve punishment, for my efforts to conquer it. Let this be both. I can learn the secrets of the magic I love at last, wielding them with a mastery for the ages...while trapped in an elegant prison, powerless ten feet outside my door."

“I will stay with my lady,” Beast-Man added, standing beside her, “to protect her and Grayskull. This will be my prison as well, far from any creature I could command.”

Lyn smiled at the Sorceress. “And you, Teela-Na, can be with your love and daughter at last.”

“And how are we to know,” Randor demanded, “that you will not abuse the power of the universe?”

“I’ll stay too,” Orko added, floating beside her. “I’ll vouch for her.”

Adam and Teela stared as one – though to be fair, so did almost everyone else. Only Catra seemed unsurprised, grinning. “But...Orko,” Teela sighed.

“I have my own mistakes to make up for,” Orko admitted, “and I can keep an eye on Lyn.”

Randor turned a worried look on the Trollan. “This is a brave and noble offer, old friend, but how can you hope to keep a Sorceress in check?”

Orko chuckled and rolled up his sleeves. “Barren field, return to life," he said, aiming his hands at the wasteland around them. “Prove that there is no more strife!” In an instant, the cracked earth overflowed with grass and flowers. “Thanks to Lyn and Catra, I’m like an unemployed jester – nobody’s fool!” He giggled.

“Yes,” Marlena said. “Catra.” They turned to face the Etherians. “Adora, you and your beloved have proved yourselves true Champions and protectors of the universe.”

Catra’s facial fur went flat around the cheeks. *Magicat blush, probably,* Teela thought, but kept her smile unobtrusive. *Not that I’m going to rat her out.* “Like Sparkles said,” Catra replied, “we do this stuff.”

“This was Adora’s choice,” Randor added, “but please, take our blessing of your union in the spirit which we offer it.”

“Thanks, Mom, Dad,” Adora said, a little teary-eyed.

“You know,” Adam added, and Teela took his hand before he got the wrong idea, “Eternia’s still got plenty of adventure to go around. Skeletor’s gone, and the ancient wound is finally healing thanks to the destruction of the Havoc Staff, but Kobra Khan is still out there, and there are plenty of lesser evils waiting in the lands of Point Dread.”

Adora and Catra looked at each other, then smiled. “Cool offer, but Eternia’s already got a ton of magic,” Catra said.

“And there are so many more worlds Horde Prime stole magic from,” Adora added, “not to mention what our ancestors did.”

“Then at least stay for the celebration of Eternia’s restoration,” Randor pleaded, “as well as the reunion of the Grayskull family.”

“That we can do,” Glimmer agreed. “Let’s *party!”*

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“Holy Bast,” Catra chuckled as they boarded, “your family knows how to celebrate.”

“A week did seem excessive,” Hordak muttered, heading for the engine room.

“But they had tiny snacks!” Entrapta gushed. “And we learned so much from Tri-Klops!”

“Not to mention the new shell for Darla,” Bow added, calling up a hologram of the purple-and-white exterior for the ship. *Which matches Brightmoon* and *Eternos,* Catra noted. *Convenient.*

“And here I thought family drama would be boring,” Double Trouble joined in, hand on their forehead. “I am definitely not missing any more of the excitement.”

“It’s a shame that old First Ones tech spooks other worlds,” Adora sighed, pulling on her jacket, “but we’ll make things right.”

“As long as I get a proper honeymoon, Adora,” Catra warned with a grin, trailing her tail along Adora’s arm.

“Oh, I’m not letting you out of my sight again,” Adora retorted, shivering, “after that stunt you pulled in Subternia.”

“Maybe think about that next time you want to sacrifice yourself for everyone else,” Catra pointed out.

“Okay, guys, points made,” Glimmer insisted. “We’re taking a nice, long break after Thundera.” Adora and Catra looked at each other. “What? Come on, how many undead overlords can there be out there?”

Adora laughed. “Let’s find out.”

Catra kissed her. “Let’s not,” she drawled. Adora held her, and she purred.

Two minutes later, Darla took to the stars, Catra’s heart lighter than it had ever been.

And they adventured happily ever after.

Chapter End Notes

> I was planning this crossover for months...then MotU: Revelations came out, and boom! Plans blown to bits.
>
> Turn Right and She-Ra: Champion of Power will continue, but aside from a possible epilogue where TR-Catra meets this Catra, here is where we leave our heroes. I hope everyone enjoyed the ride.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!